

Iran apologises to Gulf countries

Donald Trump warns of escalation

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian apologised on Saturday to neighbouring countries affected by Tehran's recent attacks, even as Iranian missiles and drones reportedly continued flying toward Gulf Arab States — a development that has raised concerns about the extent of civilian leadership's control over the country's armed forces.

In his statement, Pezeshkian expressed regret over the strikes on regional countries and attempted to reassure neighbouring nations that Iran did not intend to destabilise the wider region. The apology



Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian

appeared aimed at calming tensions with Gulf Arab States that fear being drawn deeper into the conflict.

However, the continuation of military operations despite the apology suggested that Iran's political leadership might not have full command over the actions of its armed forces during the crisis.

Analysts say this disconnect could reflect internal divisions

within Iran's power structure, where military institutions such as the Revolutionary Guard often operate with significant autonomy.

Pezeshkian also rejected repeated demands from US President Donald Trump that Iran surrender, signalling that Tehran would not yield to external pressure despite rising military and diplomatic tensions.

Meanwhile, Trump warned that more Iranian officials could become targets as the confrontation escalates. Writing on his Truth Social platform, the US president said: "Today Iran will be hit very hard!" Trump's message came shortly after he referenced Pezeshkian's apology to neighbouring nations, but his remarks indicated that Washington was preparing to intensify its response.

"Under serious consideration for complete destruction and certain death, because of Iran's bad behaviour, are areas and groups of people that were not considered for targeting until this moment in time," Trump wrote, without elaborating.

Why this matters for the region: The developments underline the growing risk of

a wider regional conflict. Gulf Arab States — including Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and others — host key global energy infrastructure and shipping routes. Any escalation could disrupt oil supplies and international trade through critical waterways such as the Strait of Hormuz.

For regional Governments, Iran's apology may signal an attempt to prevent the conflict from spreading beyond its immediate adversaries. At the same time, the continuation of missile and drone activity suggests that military dynamics on the ground may be moving faster than diplomatic efforts.

Diplomatic channels are expected to remain active in the coming days as regional and global actors attempt to prevent the crisis from spiralling into a broader conflict.

President Murmu cries foul over Mamata; PM terms it shameful

DEEPAK KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi/Kolkata

A major row has erupted after President Droupadi Murmu was not accorded a State Government's protocol upon her arrival in West Bengal, as neither Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee nor any of her Cabinet representatives were present at Bagdogra Airport.

Murmu, in her capacity as President of India, is not known for making political remarks, also wondered over the sudden change of venue for the tribal community's annual programme from Bidhannagar to Goshapur, where the turnout was reportedly low.

While Prime Minister Narendra Modi termed it a



President Droupadi Murmu addressing an event in Siliguri

shameful, unprecedented turn of events in West Bengal, Banerjee alleged that the BJP was using the Rashtrapati Bhavan to malign the State Government. Banerjee said it was not always possible for her to attend such programmes in the run-up to

elections. According to the protocol, the Chief Minister or a minister of the State Government is usually present to receive the President. Banerjee was on a protest demonstration against the alleged Election Commission SIR drive.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Decks cleared for Nitish Kumar's son as Dy CM



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

As JD(U) patriarch Nitish Kumar is all set to hang up his boots as Chief Minister of Bihar, his party on Saturday claimed that a consensus has been reached for appointing his son Nishant as a Deputy CM.

JD(U) MLA Hari Narayan Singh, a close aide of Nitish Kumar, claimed that a "unanimous" decision has been taken to make the party supremo's son Nishant the deputy CM in the new Government to be formed upon his father's resignation and the same has been conveyed to stakeholders of the BJP-led NDA.

Singh, the MLA from Harnaut, in Nalanda district that Kumar himself had represented in the 1980s, also claimed that Nishant, who is

entering politics in his late 40s, will be elected to the State legislative council next month. Nishant's entry comes days after his father, known to be a vociferous critic of "dynasty politics", chose to hang up his boots, within less than four months of having been sworn in for a fifth consecutive term in office.

Speculations are rife that the chief minister's post shall now be taken by the BJP, the single-largest party in the ruling NDA, and JD(U) might insist on having two deputy CMs with the crucial Home portfolio, a complete reversal of the arrangement that is currently in place. Of the two deputy CMs, Samrat Choudhary and Vijay Kumar Sinha, both from the BJP, the Home portfolio, in which the control of the State police is vested, is held by the former.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

PM backs Speaker Birla amid turmoil



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kota/New Delhi

In an interesting note, two days ahead of the Lok Sabha, taking up a motion of no-confidence moved by the Opposition parties against Speaker Om Birla, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday described Birla as an outstanding Member of Parliament and "excellent" Speaker of the Lok Sabha. Modi praised Birla for functioning above party lines and carrying everyone along while presiding over the House.

"Om Birla ji is as outstanding a Member of the Parliament, and he is an excellent Speaker of the Lok Sabha. He is fully dedicated to the Constitution, and he maintains complete allegiance to parliamentary procedures. Today, he is not a member of any one side; he is completely above party lines when it comes to ruling side and Opposition," Modi said during his virtual address at the foundation

stone laying ceremony of Kota airport.

In an obvious reference to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, Modi said even when some arrogant, troublemaking "students" from prominent families (*bade gharana*) come in, who just won't give up their habit of creating a ruckus, even then, he handles everyone like the head of the House.

"And all our Honourable MPs present in the House, he handles them very well; he greatly respects their feelings and their requests. He is such a speaker who has the nature of giving the utmost respect to the MPs," he said. Birla is a three-time MP from the Kota-Bundi seat and is serving his second successive term as Speaker of the Lok Sabha.

The debate and subsequently the voting on the no-confidence motion moved by the Opposition against the Lok Sabha Speaker will be taken up on March 9, when the House reassembles after the recess.



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LIC / P1 / 2025-26 / 35 / Eng

Government to build 100-ft Lord Ram statue in Mangolpuri

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Inspired by the Lord Ram statue in Ayodhya's River Saryu, the Delhi Government plans to build a 100-foot-tall statue of Lord Ram in Mangolpuri. A proposal to this effect has been approved by the Delhi Rural Development Board on Saturday.

Sharing the details, Board chairman Raj Kumar Chauhan told *The Pioneer* that the Board has approved a proposal to build a 100-foot-tall statue of Lord Shri Ram at a cost of about ₹55 crore in Mangolpuri Kalan village, located in the Mangolpuri area. It will take approximately 18 months to build this statue.

Chauhan also expressed gratitude to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Culture Minister Kapil Mishra for approving the project. He said there is a huge park in Mangolpuri Kalan village where the statue will be installed. The entire area will be developed as a picnic spot. The statue's base will be about 10 feet high, atop which an 81-foot statue of Lord Shri Ram holding a bow and arrow will be placed, with a large canopy installed above it. He said it would strengthen Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision for rural development.

Elaborating on the project's objectives, Chauhan stated that the park would be developed as a cultural, spiritual, and community public space.



Regarding the statue of Lord Shri Ram, he said it symbolises courage, righteousness, sacrifice, and ideal leadership. In the statue, Lord Shri Ram will be depicted standing on a lotus flower with his

bow resting on the ground, in a posture of blessing, symbolising both strength and compassion.

"The statue will incorporate traditional artistic embellishments and symbolic elements like a halo. The structure will be built with a strong RCC foundation, steel framework, and outer metal cladding to ensure long-term durability and safety. The park's redevelopment will also include landscaping, lighting, seating arrangements, and other park facilities under this project," he said.

Besides, the Board has approved a total of 574 projects with a total cost of around ₹1,317 crore for the development of rural and dehat areas. Of the total project, the Board meeting was attended by Rural Development Board Vice-Chairman Gajendra Daral and members Neelam Pahalwan, Rajkaran Khatri, Kuldeep Solanki, and Ravindra Negi.

Recently, Prime Minister Narendra Modi unveiled a massive 77-foot bronze statue of Lord Ram at the Shree Samsthan Gokarn Partagali Jeevottam Math in Partagali, in South Goa. The unveiling by Modi was part of the 550th-year celebrations of the Shree Samsthan Gokarn Partagali Jeevottam Math. This is the tallest statue of Lord Ram in the world. The 108-foot-tall statue of Lord Ram in Kurnool, Andhra Pradesh, which will cost over ₹500 crore, is under construction.

LPG price hike sparks concern among households

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The ₹60 increase in domestic Liquefied Petroleum Gas cylinder prices has triggered concern among households, labourers and small business owners across the country, with many saying the hike will add further pressure to already stretched family budgets.

Oil marketing companies raised the price of domestic LPG cylinders on Saturday. In Delhi, a 14.2-kg non-subsidised cylinder now costs ₹913, up from ₹853 earlier, according to data from Indian Oil Corporation. The price hike comes amid a surge in global energy costs linked to tensions in West Asia.

While Government sources said the impact of the hike would be limited when calculated on a daily basis, many consumers expressed concern about the cumulative burden on household finances.

Residents in several parts of the country said the increase will affect both domestic budgets and small businesses that rely on LPG for cooking.

A delivery worker, Mohan



Kumar, said the price rise is already being felt by ordinary families. "Domestic cylinders have become more expensive. When they are delivered to homes, the final cost becomes even higher after adding delivery charges," he said. Kumar added that wages for many workers have remained unchanged for years while the prices of essential goods continue to rise.

Another resident, Sunita Sharma, said the increase will hit low-income households the hardest. She said many families depend entirely on LPG cylinders for cooking and cannot afford repeated price hikes.

Political reactions to the price hike also emerged. Devender Yadav, president

of the Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee, criticised the increase and said it would put additional pressure on household budgets.

He also demanded that subsidies on LPG cylinders be restored, arguing that rising inflation and repeated price increases have made it difficult for families to manage kitchen expenses.

Small business owners also expressed concern over the rise in commercial LPG prices. The cost of a 19-kg commercial cylinder has increased by ₹114.5 and now stands at ₹1,883 in Delhi.

Rakesh Verma, who runs a small roadside eatery, said businesses that depend on cooking gas will face higher operating costs. "Hotels, restaurants and food stalls

use commercial cylinders regularly. When gas prices increase, it directly affects our expenses," he said.

Analysts say the price revision follows a sharp rise in global oil and gas prices after tensions escalated in West Asia. The conflict disrupted tanker movement through the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's most important energy shipping routes. The disruption has pushed crude oil and natural gas prices higher in international markets. Brent crude recently rose sharply, while Asian spot prices for liquefied natural gas reached a three-year high amid fears of supply disruptions.

India is particularly sensitive to such disruptions because it imports a large share of its energy needs. According to official data, the country consumed more than 31 million tonnes of LPG in 2024-25, with a major portion coming from imports.

Government officials, however, said the price revision was necessary due to global energy trends and maintained that India's LPG prices remain lower than those in several neighbouring countries.

Capital logs hottest first week of March in 50 years

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

In an unusually hot start to March, Delhi on Saturday recorded a maximum temperature of 35.7 degrees Celsius, the highest reading logged in the first week of the month in the past 50 years, an IMD official told PTI.

According to weather data from the past 50 years, earlier the highest maximum temperature reading during the first seven days of March at Safdarjung, the city's base weather station, was 34.8 degrees Celsius logged on March 5, 1999.

With the mercury touching 35.7 degrees Celsius on Saturday, it is now the hottest day in the first week of March during the 50-year period, the IMD official said.

India Meteorological Department (IMD) data 2011 onwards shows that the second-highest temperature reading during the first week of March



was recorded in 2016, when the mercury settled at 33.6 degrees Celsius on March 4.

Meanwhile, the city's air quality deteriorated sharply on Saturday. The 24-hour average Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 246 (poor) at 4 pm, compared with 170 ('moderate') recorded at the same time a day earlier, according to the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB).

The deterioration comes after three consecutive days of 'moderate' air quality.

Forecasts by the Air Quality Early Warning System indicate that the AQI is likely to improve to the 'moderate' category over the next two days before worsening again on Tuesday.

According to the CPCB classification, an AQI between 0 and 50 is considered 'good', 51-100 'satisfactory', 101-200 'moderate', 201-300 'poor', 301-400 'very poor', and 401-500 'severe'.

Safdarjung, the city's primary weather station,

recorded a maximum temperature of 35.7 degrees Celsius on Saturday, 7.3 degrees above normal, and a minimum of 17.4 degrees Celsius, 3.4 notches above normal.

Only one week into the month and the average maximum temperature so far stands around 33 degrees Celsius and the average minimum at 16.3 degrees Celsius, the highest since 2022, IMD data showed.

In 2022, the average

maximum temperature for March was 33.4 degrees Celsius, while the average minimum was at 17.6 degrees Celsius.

The all-time highest temperature recorded in March in Delhi remains 40.6 degrees Celsius, logged on March 31, 1945.

At Palam, the maximum temperature was 33.4 degrees Celsius, 4.6 notches above normal, while the minimum settled at 18.3 degrees Celsius, 4 degrees above normal.

The Lodhi Road station recorded a maximum of 35.8 degrees Celsius, 7.8 notches above normal, and a minimum of 17.6 degrees Celsius, 4.6 notches above normal.

At the Ridge station, the maximum temperature reached 36.4 degrees Celsius, 7 notches above normal, while the minimum was 19.1 degrees Celsius, 3.9 notches above normal.

Ayanagar recorded a maximum temperature of 36.1 degrees Celsius, 7.3 notches above normal, while the minimum settled at 17.3 degrees Celsius, 4.1 notches above normal. No rainfall was recorded across these stations during the 24-hour period on Saturday, the IMD said.

Support, opportunities key to women's progress: CM Rekha

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday said that capable women in positions of responsibility should help other women by providing the support and opportunities needed to move forward.

Speaking at the "Bharati Naari to Narayani: National Convention of Women Thought Leaders" organised by Rashtriya Sevika Samiti, Gupta said women must work together to ensure that the next generation of girls gets better opportunities.

The chief minister said the country is progressing, and it is important that daughters receive the courage and opportunities that many women earlier could not get.

She said women who are currently holding positions of responsibility should



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta during the Nari Shakti Conclave organised by Varvasi Kalyan Seva Samiti at Ramjas College in New Delhi PANKAJ KUMAR

extend support to others who need guidance, resources and encouragement to advance in life.

"When women hold each other's hands and move forward together, it becomes easier for the coming generations to progress with confidence," Gupta said.

The CM congratulated the organisers for holding discussions over two days and

said such platforms can provide direction and motivation to women to contribute actively in different sectors.

She also expressed hope that the deliberations during the convention would help strengthen efforts aimed at supporting women and encouraging greater participation of girls and women in the country's development process.

Man arrested for killing 5-year-old cousin to teach his mother lesson

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

A 22-year-old man has been arrested for allegedly strangling his 5-year-old cousin and slitting his throat to "teach the boy's mother a lesson" over frequent disputes with her husband, officials said on Saturday. The accused has been identified as Ravi Kumar, a labourer who sold fish by the roadside, they said.

"A PCR call was received at 12.20 pm on March 5 reporting that the body of a five-year-old child with sharp injuries on the neck had been found in an under-construction building in Mohan Garden, about 50 yards from his house," a senior police officer said.

The victim's father, Pachu Mahto, told the police that



his son had been missing since March 3, and Ravi Kumar had first noticed the body around noon on March 5. Initially, Mahto suspected his wife of having killed their son as she had recently left the house following family disputes. Police analysed her call detail records and traced her to Chhapra in Bihar, where she was questioned. She denied any involvement and said she had left home due to frequent quarrels.

Investigators later analysed CCTV footage from the area and spoke to local vendors and shopkeepers.

The footage showed the child last seen with Ravi Kumar at around 3.24 pm on March 3, raising suspicion against him, officials said.

He told the police that he was angry at the boy's mother over frequent disputes with his maternal uncle (her husband) and wanted to teach her a lesson.

On March 3, after consuming alcohol, he took the child to an under-construction building, pushed him to the ground and strangled him. He then slit the boy's throat with a kitchen knife, police said.

A post-mortem examination was conducted at Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital on March 6, and a case under Section 103(1) (murder) was registered. Police said the knife used in the crime has been recovered.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, .PWD DIBRUGARH ROAD OFFICE,DIBRUGARH
No. DRC.XIII/16/98/NIT/DIB/PT-I/166

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER

This office of the Superintending Engineer P.W.D, Dibrugarh Road Circle, Dibrugarh on behalf of Governor of Assam invites bid from the approved and eligible contractors/Firms registered with Assam PWD (Roads) for the following work.

SL NO	NAME OF WORK	ESTD Value (in Lakhs) (Approx)	EMD/Bid Security (in Rs)	Tender Fees (in Rs)	Pre Bid Date & Time	Last Date & Time of Bid Submission	Date & Time of Bid Opening
1.	Construction of 1 No. Jatiyani Gaon Road (L=1.50 Km) under SOPD-G for the year 2025-26, Khowang LAC	141.27	282600.00	4000.00	N/A	27/03/2026 up to 14.00 Hrs	27/03/2026 At 15.00 Hrs

The Details of Tender Documents form may be seen and can be Downloaded from Website-<https://assamtenders.gov.in> from 11/03/2026 and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The Bid will be opened on the E-procurement portal as per the scheduled mentioned above.

The tender inviting authority reserves the right to accept and reject any Bid/Tender, and to cancel/annul the Bidding process and reject all Bids at any time prior to the award of contract.

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer PWD
Dibrugarh Road Circle , Dibrugarh

DIPR/C/PIO/944/8-Mar-26

RAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Bhakta Mata Karma Complex, New Rajendra Nagar, RAIPUR (Chhattisgarh) 492006
Website : <https://rda.cgstate.gov.in>, Email : ceordaryp@gmail.com, Fax : 0771-2536188

NIT No. 05
Online Bids are invited for the following of works upto **06.04.2026 at 5:30 PM**

Sr. No.	System Tender No.	Name of work/Description of work	Type of Contract	Tender Amount	EMD Amount	Time Period	Tender Fee+ Processing Fee
1	186796	Construction of 48 Nos. 1-BHK & 96 Nos. 2-BHK Apartments (Total 144 Units) in G+8 Floor Building Blocks with Stilt (Parking) Floor, including 9 Nos. Small Shops, all Related Site Infrastructure and Development Works, as per Approved Drawings, Designs, and Specifications; Complete in all Respects and Ready-to-Move-in Condition, with a Defect Liability Period of Three Years, under the Redevelopment Scheme of 96 Tenement Project at Tikrapara, Raipur (C.G.)	Lump-Sum	Rs. 1692.89 Lacs (Exc. GST)	Rs. 10.00 Lacs	24 (Twenty Four) Months including rainy season.	Rs. 17,250/- including GST+ Rs. 311/- (Non Refundable) to be paid online

The details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Chhattisgarh e-procurement portal <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in>. More details of the tender and bidding process may be obtained from the above-mentioned portal.

NOTE : (1) All eligible/interested contractors are mandated to get enrolled on e-procurement portal. **(2)** Contractors can contact help desk for any clarification of their doubt regarding the process of electronic procurement system. Help Desk at Toll Free No. 1800-233-7188 or through Email ID ceordaryp@gmail.com, ceordaryp@gmail.com. Website : <https://rda.cgstate.gov.in>. **(3)** For more details, please download NIT details.

Superintending Engineer

PUBLIC NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that Mrs. Neha Dhangra (hereinafter referred to as the said Mortgagees/Borrowers), is purchasing Flat No. 10027, 10th Floor, measuring 1270 Sq. Ft., built on GH Plot No. 7, Crossings Republic, Dundaehra, NH24, Ghaziabad, U.P. (hereinafter referred to as the said property) from Mr. Shalendra Yadav, Mr. Sudhir Yadav & Mrs. Ruchi (all legal heirs of Late Savitri Yadav), who became the owners of the said property vide Sale Deed dated 20.01.2012, registered as Document No. 617, Book No. 1. Vol. No. 9537 on pages 221 to 276 on 20.01.2012 read with Surviving Members Certificate dated 30.06.2020. The Borrower will create mortgage in respect of the said property in favour of our clients Aus Bank Ltd., Aditya City Centre, Indraprastha, Ghaziabad. Any person, body, individual, institution having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property by way of sale, exchange, lease, lien, mortgage, charge, encumbrance, gift, trust, easement, maintenance, inheritance, testamentary disposition or otherwise or having in their custody any title documents pertaining to the said property shall communicate the same to the undersigned at our address within 07 days from the publication of this notice with documentary evidence in support thereof, failing which all the claim, of such person shall be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned. Any objections raised after the completion of the 07 days shall not be binding upon the said property or my client.

Adv. Shweta Garg
100, 1st Floor, Office Phase III, New Delhi - 110020
Phone:- +91 1149774545/99

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby informed to the general public that Mr Pankaj Sahni, resident of C-9, South Extension - II, New Delhi - 110049, expired on 20/07/2025.

The deceased was the allottee of Unit No. G1-2004, Tower G1, in the project presently known as Altura (earlier known as The Grand), Gurugram, Haryana.

The following legal heirs survive him:

- Mrs. Arina Sahni – Wife
- Mr. Arman Sahni – Son
- Ms. Sheryl Sahni – Daughter
- Mr. Praveesh Kumar Sahni – Father

Apart from the above-mentioned persons, there are no other legal heirs of the deceased. Any person having any claim, objection, right, title, or interest in respect of the aforesaid property or the legal heir ship of the deceased is hereby required to submit such claim/objection in writing, along with supporting documents, within 21 days from the date of publication of this notice to:

SARE GURUGRAM PRIVATE LIMITED
5th Floor, Wing A, Statesman House,
148, Barakhamba Road, Connaught Place, New Delhi – 110001

Failing which, any such claim, if any, shall be deemed to have been waived and the company shall proceed accordingly without further reference.

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform that I, RITABRATA ADAK – DIRECTOR OF DADAR PROPERTIES & FINANCE PVT LTD., 9, EZRA STREET, TOP FLOOR, ROOM NO. 47, KOLKATA-700011, WB, THE PROPERTY SITUATED AT PARADISE CITY-I, ILAHABAS, TESHIL-DADRI, DISTRICT-GHAZIABAD (PRESENTLY IN DISTRICT GAUTAMBUDH NAGAR, NOIDA) OF PLOT NO.C-25, C-26, C-31 IN KHASRA NO. 216 & PLOT NO B-63 IN KHASRA NO 399, IN THE NAME OF M/S SAS (INDIA) LIMITED, REGISTERED AT SRO OFFICE TESHIL-DADRI, GHAZIABAD. THE ORIGINAL TITLE DEED (REGISTERED SALE DEED) AND ALL DOCUMENTS TO THE PROPERTIES HAVE BEEN LOST AT NEW DELHI RAILWAY STATION COMPLAINT LOGGED ON 09.01.2024 VIDE LR NO.13276964/2024 FINDER CATCHED 9433304583.

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Joginder Dahiya S/o Sh. Bhup Singh R/o Village Dhanwapur Daultabad-53, Post Daultabad, Distt. Gurugram Haryana-122006 declare that Joginder Dahiya & Joginder Dhaiya both names are the same and one person. My Correct name is Joginder Dahiya for all future purposes.

PD(414)C

I, Usha W/o- No.6498491N Nk Ravi Yadav R/o- H.No. 272 VPO-Ghumana Hera, South West Delhi, New Delhi- 110073 have changed my name from Usha to Usha Yadav, vide affidavit dated 07/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(415)C

I, Baria Prabhatsinh Virsinh, Father of No.16030617N Rfn Baria Pareshkumar Prabhatsinh, R/o- At & PO- Bodidra Buzarg, Teh- Godhra, Dist- Panchmahal, Gujarat- 389120, have changed my name from Baria Prabhatsinh to Baria Prabhatsinh Virsinh, vide affidavit dated 07/03/2026 before Godhra, Gujarat.

PD(416)C

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, PWD
GUWAHATI BUILDING CIRCLE-II, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3

PRESS NOTICE

The Superintending Engineer, P.W.D, Guwahati Building Circle-II, Chandmari, Guwahati-3 on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites bids for the following works having experience of similar nature of work from APWD registered contractors having establishment in Guwahati. Details of the bids may be seen at e-procurement portal website: www.assamtenders.gov.in and also in the office of the undersigned during office hours. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in for participating in the bidding process.

Name of work	Approx. Value of Work (Rs.)	Category of APWD (B) registered contractor
Construction of Temporary Pandals in connection with the conduct of the forthcoming General Election to Assam Legislative Assembly 2026 at Maniram Dewan Trade Centre, Guwahati-35	1,14,51,290/-	Class-I (A/ B/C)

Note:-

- Any modification of tender may be seen in the portal www.assamtenders.gov.in.
- Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
- The prospective bidder must visit the work site before submission of tender.
- This tender is invited as an advance action in anticipation of obtaining Administrative Approval from concerned authority and the work will be allotted on receipt of Administrative Approval only.**

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer, P.W.D.
Guwahati Building Circle-II

DIPR/C/PIO/950/8-Mar-26

PM Modi to inaugurate new Metro corridors, launch 3 more in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate two new corridors of the Delhi Metro and lay the foundation stone for three additional Metro corridors in the national capital on March 8. These new metro corridors will significantly expand the city's public transport network.

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the new Metro projects will improve connectivity across residential and commercial areas while strengthening clean and efficient public transport in the city. She said the expansion will help reduce pressure from private vehicles on

roads and contribute to controlling pollution in the Capital.

According to the Chief Minister, the Prime Minister will inaugurate the Majlis Park-Maujpur-Babarpur section of the Pink Line and the Deepali Chowk-Majlis Park section of the Magenta Line. With the opening of the Majlis Park-Maujpur-Babarpur corridor, the Pink Line will extend to about 71.56 kilometres, making it the country's first fully operational Ring Metro corridor.

Officials said the corridor will significantly improve connectivity between various parts of Delhi, particularly areas in North East and North West Delhi. The new

link will enable commuters to travel more efficiently between several residential and commercial neighbourhoods without requiring multiple interchanges.

The Deepali Chowk-Majlis Park section is an extension of the Magenta Line. With the commissioning of this corridor, the total length of the Magenta Line will reach about 49 kilometres. The extension is expected to enhance connectivity for several residential colonies and business hubs along the route, providing smoother travel for daily commuters.

The Chief Minister said the Prime Minister will also lay the foundation stone for three new Metro corridors



CM Rekha Gupta inspecting inauguration site

PIONEER PHOTO

under Phase V (A) of the network expansion. These include the corridor from Ramakrishna Ashram Marg

to Indraprastha, often referred to as the Central Vista corridor, the Aerocity to Indira Gandhi Airport

Terminal-1 corridor, and the corridor from Tughlakabad to Kalindi Kunj.

Once completed, these corridors are expected to strengthen connectivity between Delhi's administrative centres, residential neighbourhoods, and commercial districts. The Aerocity-Terminal-1 corridor will also provide faster and more direct Metro access to the airport for commuters.

The Chief Minister said the expansion will benefit not only residents of Delhi but also commuters from neighbouring cities in the National Capital Region. Travellers from Faridabad and Ballabhgarh will be able to reach Tughlakabad through

the Violet Line and then travel directly towards the airport through the upcoming Golden Line corridor. Similarly, commuters coming from Noida will be able to reach KalindiKunj through the Magenta Line and then travel easily towards South Delhi and the airport through the new route.

The Chief Minister said strengthening public transport remains a priority for the Delhi Government. She highlighted that the Transport Department has been allocated ₹9,110 crore in the 2025-26 Budget, which is nearly 60 per cent higher than last year's allocation of ₹5,702 crore. Out of this, ₹2,929 crore has been ear-

marked specifically for accelerating Metro projects.

She added that the Government aims to create a modern, efficient, and environmentally friendly public transport network across the capital. Expanding the Metro system, she said, will ensure that residents have access to reliable transport while reducing traffic congestion and pollution.

The Chief Minister also said the Delhi Government is working in close coordination with the Centre to strengthen the city's transport infrastructure and develop a world-class Metro network that supports the broader vision of a developed India.

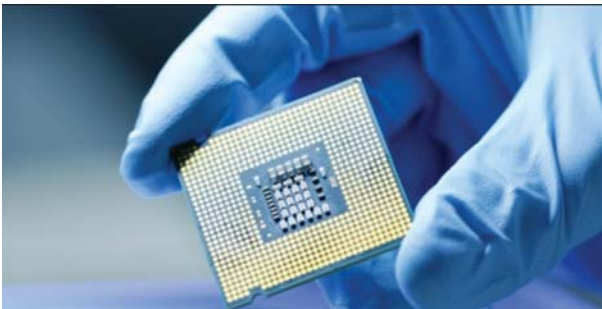
Universities in Delhi key to India's semiconductor talent push

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several leading universities in Delhi are playing a key role in supporting India's growing semiconductor ecosystem, the Government said on Saturday. Union Minister for Electronics and IT Ashwini Vaishnaw said India has made significant progress in its efforts to build semiconductor talent under the India Semiconductor Mission. The initiative includes training, upskilling, and workforce development through the Chips to Startups Programme, which aims to develop skilled engineers in semiconductor design.

Vaishnaw said that in the past four years, India has moved steadily toward its ten-year target of training 85,000 engineers in semiconductor design. The programme is also expected to generate major employment opportunities as the global semiconductor industry expands rapidly.

Several prominent institutions in the National Capital Region are contributing to



this national effort. These institutions are training students in semiconductor chip design, testing and validation, helping build the country's talent pipeline.

Key institutions involved in the programme include the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi, the National Institute of Technology Delhi, the Indraprastha Institute of Information Technology Delhi, the Delhi Technological University, the Netaji Subhas University of Technology, the Jawaharlal Nehru University, the Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women, and the Vivekananda Institute of Professional Studies.

Another organisation

involved in supporting innovation under the programme is DV2JS Innovation LLP, which is also based in Delhi. Students at these institutions are already designing semiconductor chips using advanced EDA tools and training infrastructure. Officials say these efforts are helping India develop a strong base of semiconductor engineers and innovators.

According to the minister, India is preparing for a surge in jobs in the sector. As the global semiconductor market is projected to reach about 2 trillion dollars in value, nearly two million skilled professionals will be required worldwide. This demand is expected to create signifi-

cant job opportunities for Indian engineers.

A major part of this effort involves giving students access to advanced design tools used in the semiconductor industry. World-class Electronic Design Automation tools have been made available to students in 315 academic institutions across the country. These tools are supported by major global technology companies, including Synopsys, Cadence Design Systems, Siemens, Renesas Electronics, Ansys, and AMD.

With the help of these tools, engineering students are able to gain hands-on experience in designing semiconductor chips. These student-designed chips are then fabricated and tested at the Semiconductor Laboratory Mohali, allowing them to understand the entire process from chip design to fabrication, packaging, and testing.

Officials said the initiative has evolved into the world's largest open-access Electronic Design Automation programme. So far, more than 1.85 crore

hours of EDA tool usage have been recorded by students and researchers across the country for chip design training.

Vaishnaw also highlighted that students from universities across India are participating in semiconductor design work. Institutions from regions stretching from Assam to Gujarat and from Kashmir to Kanyakumari are part of the programme.

Under the next phase of the initiative, the programme will be expanded significantly. The Government plans to increase the number of participating universities from 315 to 500 under the Semicon 2.0 initiative, strengthening India's base of skilled semiconductor engineers.

The Government said the broader goal of the Semicon 2.0 initiative is to promote semiconductor design, manufacturing, and innovation in India. By strengthening talent development and research infrastructure, the country aims to emerge as a global hub for semiconductor technology and manufacturing in the coming years.

From Baghpat to AIIMS: Doctor's journey inspires young women

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On the occasion of International Women's Day, the journey of Swati Tomar is being highlighted as an example of determination, academic excellence and dedication to women's healthcare.

Originally from Baghpat, Dr Tomar became the first doctor in her family, marking a significant milestone for her household. Her achievement reflects years of consistent hard work and focus on education. Today, she is associated with All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi, one of India's most prestigious medical institutions.

Dr Tomar's academic journey began at Vivekanand School, Anand Vihar in Delhi. It was here that she built the foundation for her future career in medicine. Teachers and mentors recall her as a focused and disciplined student who consistently



Dr Swati Tomar

performed well in her studies. Her excellence continued during her undergraduate medical training. While pursuing MBBS, she secured a distinction in Anatomy, demonstrating strong academic performance early in her medical career. She was also awarded the Dr S Ponnammal Gold Medal in Obstetrics and Gynaecology, a recognition that reflected her growing interest in women's healthcare.

After completing her MBBS, Dr Tomar cleared the highly competitive postgraduate entrance examination of All India Institute of

Medical Sciences, New Delhi, in her very first attempt. She chose to specialise in Obstetrics and Gynaecology, a field that focuses on the health and well-being of women. According to those close to her, the decision was driven by a desire to contribute meaningfully to women's healthcare in the country.

During her postgraduate training at AIIMS, Dr Tomar continued to receive recognition for her academic work. She won the Torrent Young Scholar Award and later emerged as the second runner-up at the national level in the same competition. These achievements further strengthened her reputation as a promising young medical professional.

Following her post-graduation, she completed her senior residency at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi. Her commitment to patient care and professional ethics was formally recognised during this period.

Traffic curbs in North Delhi for major DDA event

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vehicular movement in several parts of North Delhi is expected to be affected on Sunday morning as traffic restrictions come into force for a large public event at the DDA Utsav Sthal, officials said.

According to the Delhi Traffic Police, an official function organised by the Delhi Development Authority is scheduled to take place at the venue. During the programme, several housing projects and new sections of the Delhi Metro are expected to be inaugurated.

Authorities estimate that around 25,000 people will attend the event. To manage the large gathering and ensure security arrangements, traffic restrictions will remain in place between 7.30 am and 2 pm in the surrounding areas.

Police said only vehicles carrying valid labels will be allowed on certain routes during the restricted period. Commuters have been advised to plan their journeys accordingly and avoid several key roads in North Delhi.

According to the advisory, Shanti Swaroop Tyagi Marg from Camp Chowk to Burari



Chowk will remain closed for general traffic during the event. Similarly, Shah Alam Bandh Marg from the T-point at Shanti Swaroop Tyagi Marg to the Majlis Park red light will also remain shut to regular vehicles.

Traffic police have further advised commuters to avoid Arihant Marg, Shanti Swaroop Tyagi Marg, Shah Alam Bandh Marg and Outer Ring Road during the restricted hours to prevent congestion. Special traffic diversions have also been put in place around the venue. Vehicles coming from Kingsway Camp Chowk will not be allowed to move towards the event venue or towards Burari Chowk.

Instead, commuters trav-

elling from that side have been advised to use the Burari flyover or the Mukundpur flyover as alternate routes. Traffic officials said these diversions are aimed at reducing congestion near the venue and ensuring smooth movement of emergency and authorised vehicles.

For those travelling along 100 Foota Burari Road, the advisory recommends using Bund Road from the Burari Metro Station. Motorists have been specifically asked to avoid Burari Chowk and Mukundpur Chowk during the restricted hours, as heavy traffic is expected in these areas.

Officials said the measures have been introduced to

manage the large number of visitors expected at the event and to ensure safety and security arrangements around the venue.

The Delhi Traffic Police has urged commuters to follow traffic instructions, use alternate routes where possible and allow extra travel time on Sunday morning.

Authorities also appealed to residents of North Delhi to cooperate with traffic personnel deployed in the area and avoid unnecessary travel through restricted zones during the event period.

The advisory said normal traffic movement will be restored after the programme concludes and the crowd disperses later in the afternoon.

CM Rekha travels in DTC bus, reviews Saheli Pink NCMC Card system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta travelled in a Delhi Transport Corporation bus on Saturday to review the functioning of the Saheli Pink NCMC Card and assess how the system is working on the ground.

During the ride, the Chief Minister used the card herself and observed the process followed by passengers while boarding the bus. Officials said the visit was aimed at understanding the passenger experience and ensuring that the facility works smoothly for women commuters across the city.

According to the Government, the Saheli Pink NCMC card allows women to travel free of cost on DTC buses through a simple tap-based system. As passengers board the bus, they only need to tap their card on the electronic machine installed near the entrance. The journey is instantly registered in the system.

Officials said the process is designed to be quick, transparent and convenient for passengers. The card is based on the National Common Mobility Card system, which enables contactless travel and digital recording of trips.

During her bus journey, the Chief Minister interacted with passengers and observed the functioning of the ticketing system. She said the initiative aims to make public transport more



accessible and convenient for women in the national Capital.

The Chief Minister said the facility is especially designed for women, including mothers, daughters and working professionals who rely on public transport for their daily travel. The CM noted that the card system helps simplify the process of availing free bus travel while ensuring transparency in ticketing records.

Government officials said the Saheli Pink NCMC card is being issued free of

cost to women at several designated centres across Delhi. To obtain the card, applicants are required to complete a registration process using their Aadhaar number and mobile number.

Once registered, women passengers can use the card to access free travel on DTC buses across the city. Authorities said the initiative is expected to improve convenience for women commuters and encourage greater use of public transport.

The Government has appealed to women across Delhi to get the card issued and make use of the facility. Officials said the system has been introduced to streamline the free travel scheme and ensure that passengers can access it through a simple digital process.

Transport department officials added that the card system is part of broader efforts to modernise ticketing and mobility services in Delhi's public transport network. By adopting contactless smart card technology, authorities aim to make bus travel faster and more efficient for passengers.

The Chief Minister also urged women commuters to register for the Saheli Pink NCMC card and take advantage of the facility. She said expanding the use of digital ticketing systems will help improve service delivery while making daily travel more convenient for thousands of women using DTC buses across the Capital.

Man beaten to death in Holi clash in Uttam Nagar; protests erupt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 26-year-old man was allegedly beaten to death with rods and sticks during a clash between two families in West Delhi's Uttam Nagar on Holi, triggering protests, vandalism and heavy police deployment in the area over the following days.

The victim, identified as Tarun, died during treatment after he was attacked by a group of people on Wednesday evening. Authorities have so far arrested six people in connection with the case, including a juvenile, and are examining CCTV footage to identify other suspects.

According to the preliminary investigation, the dispute began after a nine-year-old girl from Tarun's family acciden-

tally threw a water balloon from the terrace of their house. The balloon reportedly landed on a woman who lived in the same locality. Tarun's father, Memraj, alleged that the situation escalated despite the family apologising for the incident. He claimed that the woman soon returned with several members of her community.

"Within a short time, around 15 to 20 people gathered with sticks and rods and started attacking us," Memraj told reporters. He said family members ran inside their house to escape the assault, but the attackers allegedly locked the door from outside. Several members of the family sustained injuries during the incident, he added.

Tarun, who had been playing Holi elsewhere and was unaware of the clash,



Heavy security deployment in Uttam Nagar following a violent clash during Holi celebrations on Wednesday

PANKAJ KUMAR

returned home during the chaos. According to family members, the group attacked him as soon as he entered the street.

His uncle Ramesh said around eight to ten people allegedly assaulted Tarun with sticks, rods and stones. "He had no idea about the fight. But they attacked him

repeatedly and hit his head," he said. Tarun, who was studying digital marketing, was rushed to the hospital but later died during treatment.

A grieving Memraj said his son was the main support for the family. He urged authorities to take strict action against those responsible for the attack. He also appealed

CM Rekha condemns incident, promises action

New Delhi: Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta termed the incident extremely painful, condemnable, and shocking to the entire society. "Delhi has a zero-tolerance policy for such heinous and violent crimes. Such brutality will not be tolerated at any cost," the Chief Minister said. The administration has

been given clear and strict instructions to immediately arrest all those involved in this crime and ensure strict action against them. The Delhi Government stands with the victim's family during this difficult time. I will ensure that the family receives all possible assistance and justice.

to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta to ensure justice.

The violence sparked tension in the locality in the following days. On Friday and Saturday, protests broke out in the area, with members of organisations such as Bajrang Dal and Vishwa Hindu Parishad staging demonstrations. A group of protesters gathered near Uttam Nagar

East Metro Station and staged a sit-in protest, blocking traffic for several hours. During the unrest, a mob allegedly vandalised the house linked to the suspects involved in the killing.

Police said further investigation into the case is ongoing, and efforts are underway to identify and arrest others involved in the assault using CCTV footage and other evidence.

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IN FOCUS



Southern Command General Officer Commanding-in-Chief Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth during the Winter Term Passing Out Parade.

Dera Sacha Sauda chief acquitted in murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

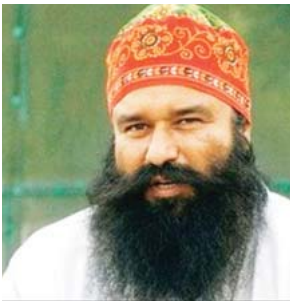
The Punjab and Haryana High Court has acquitted Dera Sacha Sauda chief Gurmeet Ram Rahim Singh in the 2002 murder case of a journalist, sect head's lawyer Jitender Khurana said on Saturday.

The court acquitted the Dera chief more than seven years after he was convicted and sentenced to life imprisonment. "The high court division bench headed by Chief Justice Sheel Nagu on Saturday acquitted him in the murder case of journalist Ram Chander Chhatrapati," Khurana said.

The division bench passed the order while hearing appeals challenging the 2019 conviction in the case, he said. "The bench, however, has upheld the conviction of three others in the case," Khurana added.

The journalist's son, Anshul Chhatrapati, said he will challenge the verdict in the Supreme Court.

Ram Rahim and three others were convicted by a special CBI court in Panchkula in January 2019 for the murder of the journalist in Haryana's Sirsa. Chhatrapati was shot outside his house in October 2002 after his newspaper 'Poora Sach' published



an anonymous letter narrating the alleged sexual exploitation of women followers at the Dera headquarters in Sirsa.

The journalist later succumbed to injuries, and a case was registered in which Ram Rahim was named as a conspirator. The case was handed over to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) in 2006.

The Dera chief is currently lodged in Rohtak's Sunaria jail. He is serving a 20-year jail term, given in 2017 for raping two of his disciples.

Anshul Chhatrapati termed the acquittal as a "setback" for his family.

"It is a setback for us, but whatever legal remedies we have, we will use them. We will challenge this verdict in the Supreme Court. We expect that the investigating agency, CBI, would also challenge the high court verdict," he said.

70 lakh seek inclusion claims in UP SIR exercise

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Over 70.69 lakh Form 6 claims for inclusion in the electoral rolls and 2.68 lakh objections via Form 7, seeking deletion of names, were received in Uttar Pradesh between January 6 and March 6 as part of the SIR exercise in 2026, Chief Electoral Officer Navdeep Rinwa said on Saturday.

Addressing a press conference at the Lok Bhawan here, Rinwa said that during the two-month claims and objections period, 70,69,810 Form 6 applications were received, with 35,72,603 submitted by women and 34,96,911 by men, indicating that the number of applications by women exceeded those by men. As many as 296 applications



were submitted by third gender voters. He said that since October 27, 2025, when the revision exercise was announced, the state has received 86,69,073 Form 6 applications, including 43,06,364 from men, 43,62,323 from women and 386 from third gender voters.

Regarding objections for deletion

of names from the rolls, Rinwa said 2,68,682 Form 7 applications were submitted between January 6 and March 6. Of these, 1,58,027 sought deletion of male voters, while 1,10,645 of female voters and 10 of third gender voters.

From October 27 to March 6, a total of 3,18,140 Form 7 applications were received, including 1,86,362 for male voters, 1,31,766 for female voters and 12 for third gender voters, he said. Rinwa said the draft electoral roll published on January 6 contained 12.55 crore voters, including 6.88 crore men (54.8 per cent), 5.67 crore women (45 per cent) and 4,119 third gender voters (0.01 per cent).

He said notices were issued to 3.26 crore voters whose details required verification. This included

1.4 crore voters whose details were not mapped with the 2003 Special Intensive Revision (SIR), and 2.02 crore voters where discrepancies were found, such as a mismatch in names or implausible age gaps between family members.

The first notices were issued on January 14, and hearings began on January 21, he said, adding that 100 per cent notices have now been generated, while about 3.60 crore notices (93.8 per cent) have already been served. "So far, hearings have been completed for around 2.80 crore voters, which accounts for about 85.8 per cent of the cases," Rinwa said. To facilitate the process, the Election Commission arranged hearings at 5,621 locations across the state and set up help desks to assist voters. Booth level officers

also visited households and carried out verification using a mobile application, he added. "Around 14 per cent of the hearings are still pending, but with the current pace of work, the process is expected to be completed within the stipulated deadline of March 27," Rinwa said.

The poll panel's state chief further said that a total of 22,55,473 Form 8 applications for corrections, change of address and replacement of EPIC cards were received between October 27 and March 6. Of these, 1,56,313 were for change of address, 20,25,611 for correction of entries in the electoral roll, 71,536 for replacement of EPIC cards and 2,013 related to identification of persons with disabilities, he said.

Hope Krishna temple is built in Mathura: CM Yogi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mathura

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said on Saturday that, if God blesses, a grand temple dedicated to Lord Krishna will be constructed in Mathura, akin to the Ram Janmabhoomi temple in Ayodhya.

After attending a meeting of the Braj Teerth Vikas Parishad, Yogi Adityanath visited the birthplace of Lord Krishna and addressed the devotees gathered for bhajan and Rasiya singing at



the Leela Manch near the birthplace. "The tradition of celebrating festivals is a significant strength in India. If Krishna Kanhaiya blesses, a grand temple of Lord Krishna will be built here,

just like the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi in Ayodhya," the Chief Minister said.

Earlier, Adityanath said, "Although I was not present during the Holi celebrations (the beginning of Rangotsav 2026), I could see from wherever I was that millions of devotees in Braj were engaged in celebrations and events at all the pilgrimage sites, including Mathura, Vrindavan, Barsana, Nandgaon, Gokul, Baldev, and Govardhan. These events were overwhelming for everyone. I wish you all

a very happy and auspicious festival."

According to the district administration, around 50 lakh devotees participated in the Holi celebrations in Braj this year.

"Holi celebrations endure forever in Braj Bhoomi. The memories of Krishna Kanhaiya are embedded in every particle here, as are the memories of Radha Rani," he added.

Adityanath arrived in Mathura on Saturday afternoon to attend the eighth meeting of the Uttar

Pradesh Braj Teerth Vikas Parishad. He inspected the "Annapurna Rasoi" which serves saints and tourists at the Tourist Facilitation Centre in Vrindavan, and visited the Sri Krishna Janmasthan to worship at the temples.

The State Government, under the leadership of dityanath, established the Uttar Pradesh Braj Teerth Vikas Parishad in 2017 to develop the Braj region in accordance with its religious, cultural, and historical identity.

SP wanted Nitish Kumar to become PM: Akhilesh Yadav



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Saturday said his party had wanted Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar to become the prime minister, but he is now set to become a Rajya Sabha member.

Addressing a press conference at the party office here, Yadav said that when the SP had formed an alliance with the Bahujan Samaj Party earlier, the party had wanted BSP chief Mayawati to become the prime minister.

"When the INDIA alliance was formed, we all wanted Nitish Kumar to become the Prime Minister. But when the Bihar election took place, we said he would retire as the chief minister and not as the prime minister. The Bharatiya Janata Party has gone a step further, and now he will retire as a Rajya Sabha member," Yadav said.

He alleged that the move amounted to an insult to people belonging to the PDA (Pichhde, Dalit and Alpsankhyak) community.

Bengal Government deliberately withheld central funds: Suwendu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Senior BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari on Saturday alleged that the West Bengal government had deliberately withheld central allocations for social welfare projects like Ayushman Bharat and PM Awas Yojana, depriving lakhs of people.

Addressing a 'Poriborton Yatra' rally at Manngalkot in Purba Bardhaman district, the leader of the Opposition said the names of 19 lakh farmers were not forwarded by the State to the Centre for the social welfare projects to help them financially. "Of the 54 lakh deserving recipients



for PM's social welfare project for farmers, names of 19 lakh were left out as they belonged to tribal, lower caste Hindu and backward caste Hindu communities. This State Government is anti-farmer," he alleged. In a scathing attack on the Mamata Banerjee Government, Adhikari

alleged that 7.11 crore people are being supplied substandard, soiled wheat under the Public Distribution System (PDS), despite the Centre spending ₹10,000 crore to provide high-quality wheat to the poor.

Referring to the state's Banglar Bari project, he said the allocation of Rs 1.2 lakh per housing unit is inadequate and vowed to hike it substantially if the BJP comes to power. "We will also implement the Ayushman Bharat scheme, which is accepted across India, and not the Swastha Sathi scheme, which is not accepted in most hospitals," he said.

Speaker Om Birla repeatedly pressed for Kota airport: Naidu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kota

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla had asked for an airport in Kota and kept pressing him about it in every Parliament session, Union Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu said on Saturday during the laying of the foundation for a Greenfield airport.

Addressing the gathering, Naidu praised Kota as the city associated with people from every part of the country through their children studying here and for its sandstone in construction.

The Greenfield airport will now facilitate people from any part of the country to fly to Kota, which has been difficult in the absence of an airport, he said. Naidu



Union Civil Aviation Minister K Ram Mohan Naidu

recalled, "Birla called me into his chamber and said, 'Greenfield airport has to be constructed in Kota, tell me when you are going to do it'. Since then, he has been pressing me in every session about its construction."

On the occasion, the Speaker thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi for fulfilling the promise of the airport that he made in Kota

during the 2023 campaign. He also thanked Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma and Naidu and said, "Both are committed to completing it by 2027".

The Union Minister said, "Under the leadership of Modi, a new airport is being constructed in the country every 45 days, and it is only because 'Modi Hai to Mumkin Hai'."

Earlier, leaders and people used to demand railway connectivity to their city, but now they demand air connectivity, he said.

The airport will bring a huge difference in the lives of the people with growth and opportunities for employment, Naidu said, mentioning the example of Bihar's Purnia, where the airport witnessed footfall of one lakh people in five months, adding one operational flight offered employment to over 100 people within the premises of the airport alone.

Addressing the gathering, Sharma claimed his government is committed to providing drinking and irrigation water to every household and farmer. "Every farm is set to get water for irrigation and every

household for drinking water in the State", Sharma said.

"We have produced 8,261 MW of electricity in two years and supplied electricity to 22 districts of the State during daytime, and in the time to come, our Government will provide a round-the-clock supply," Sharma added.

The CM said the Congress Government was known for cases of paper leaks and scams, while there has been no such case in his Government for over two years. With the appointment letter to over 21,800 youngsters by the prime minister in Ajmer on February 28, the State Government has given jobs to 1.25 lakh people so far in two years, while the process for 1.35 lakh jobs is underway, he claimed.

President Murmu cries. .

Murmu was received by Union Minister of State for Tribal Affairs Durgadas Uikey. Siliguri Mayor Gautam Deb was the only representative from the State present at the airport to receive her.

Murmu said Mamata Banerjee was like her "younger sister", but wondered whether the CM was "upset" as neither she nor any State minister was present to receive her during her visit to north Bengal. "Mamata Banerjee is like my younger sister. I am also a daughter of Bengal. I do not know whether she is upset. Anyway, that does not matter. All of you stay well," the President said, addressing a gathering of tribals at Bidhannagar near Siliguri after attending a programme at Gosaipur near Bagdogra airport earlier during the day.

"Had the programme been held there (at Bidhannagar), it would have been better. There is ample space there, and many people could have attended. But I do not know why the State administration did not permit the meeting there. Today's programme is being held at such a place that it is difficult for people to come here. Perhaps the State Government does not want the welfare of tribals, and that is why they were prevented from coming here," Murmu said. Accusing the West Bengal Government of insulting President Droupadi Murmu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said the TMC dispen-

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sation has "truly crossed all limits". Modi said that the office of the President is above politics and its sanctity should always be respected. He expressed the hope that better sense will prevail among the West Bengal government and the ruling TMC. The PM said that the pain and anguish expressed by the President, who herself hails from a tribal community, has caused immense sadness in the minds of the people of India. "The TMC Government of West Bengal has truly crossed all limits. Their administration is responsible for this insult to the President," the PM remarked on social media. Modi said it is equally unfortunate that a subject as important as Santal culture is treated so casually by the West Bengal Government. Banerjee hit out at Murmu for questioning the pace of development among tribals in the State, accusing her of indulging in politics ahead of the Assembly polls "at the behest of the BJP". "BJP has stooped so low that they are using President Droupadi Murmu to malign the State," the CM said at a protest site in Kolkata.

"I can welcome you if you come once a year, but if you come during elections, it won't be possible for me to attend your programmes as I am busy with people's rights," she said at the SIR protest site in Kolkata. Murmu was invited to the annual programme of the tribal community, which was originally scheduled to be held at Bidhannagar in Siliguri.

However, citing security and other logistical reasons, authorities shifted the venue to Gosaipur near Bagdogra airport.

Decks cleared for Nitish...

"At the legislature party meeting held at the chief minister's residence, a unanimous decision was taken to make Nishant the deputy CM in the new Government," Singh said a day after the JD(U) president briefed his colleagues about his decision to give up the post and move to the Rajya Sabha.

"It was also decided that Nishant shall formally join the JD(U). Since he must become a member of the legislature to hold a constitutional post, he would be elected to the legislative council in April when biennial elections to nine seats are scheduled. He need not necessarily contest from the seat that falls vacant upon his father's resignation," a JD(U) legislator said. JD(U) working president Sanjay Kumar Jha confirmed that Nishant's formal induction into the party will take place on Sunday, but did not divulge further details.

"Nishant will join the JD(U) tomorrow, though I feel joining is not the right word since he has always been in the party. Better to say he will start working actively from the party," Jha told the media hours after the party supremo's son visited his residence to interact with leaders.

Dubai-Kolkata Emirates flight resumes operations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

After a few days of disruptions linked to the West Asia conflict, Dubai-based airline Emirates resumed services to Kolkata airport on Saturday evening, with the first aircraft from the Gulf nation expected to land late at night.

An Airports Authority of India (AAI) spokesperson said Emirates flight EK 572, operating from Dubai (DXB) to Kolkata (CCU), took off from Dubai at 7.43 pm IST. The flight, originally scheduled to arrive here at 6.50 pm, now has a revised estimated time of arrival (ETA) of 11.50 pm.



After landing at NSC Bose International Airport, the aircraft will operate the return service, EK 573, scheduled to depart at 1.30 am instead of the original 8.25 pm.

This will be the first Emirates arrival in Kolkata after the recent conflict-related disruptions in West Asia. Earlier in the day, a flydubai flight from Dubai arrived at the city airport at 12.53 am with 163 passengers.

3 workers die of asphyxiation while cleaning tank

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Surat

Three workers died of suspected asphyxiation after entering an underground tank of an effluent treatment plant for cleaning at a dyeing mill in Gujarat's Surat city, police said on Saturday.

The incident occurred at Paras Print Private Limited in the Pandesara industrial area, but was reported to the police on Friday, he said. Sonu , Dilip , and Sandeep died, while another worker, Mahendra, is undergoing treatment at a private hospital, Inspector JR Chaudhar said, adding that they were all natives of Bihar.

Kota region to emerge as major growth centre in Rajasthan: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kota

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said Kota would emerge as a major centre of growth in Rajasthan with the development of modern infrastructure, including the new airport project.

In a video message at the foundation-laying of greenfield airport in Bundi's Shambhupura, Modi said that development in the Hadoti region, comprising Kota, Bundi, Baran and Jhalawar, is all set to gain fresh momentum with the project, to be built at a cost of around Rs 1,500 crore.

The prime minister said that before 2014, there were only about 70 airports in the country, but today, this number has increased to more than 160.

"These new airports have facilitated air travel, promoted tourism, created employment opportunities for the youth and accelerated the development of their region," he said.

The PM recalled that during his visit to Kota in November 2023, he had promised that the long-pending demand for an airport would soon be fulfilled.

"Today I am happy that the moment has come when the construction work on the Kota Airport is about to begin," Modi said.

The airport project would significant-



PM Narendra Modi delivering video message during foundation stone laying ceremony of Kota airport PTI

ly improve connectivity for Kota and neighbouring districts such as Bundi, Baran and Jhalawar, he said.

Modi said the facility would reduce the need for residents to travel long distances to catch flights and would also boost tourism, trade and employment opportunities in the Hadoti region.

"When connectivity increases, the potential for development also accelerates. The new airports built in different parts of the country in the last 11 years have given a new impetus to development," he said.

Modi said that when the State Government and the central Government work together, when the

intentions are clear, and the resolve is strong, the pace of development increases manifold.

"That is what is happening in Rajasthan today," he added.

He also highlighted the region's strengths in sectors such as energy production, agriculture and traditional products, including Kota stone and Kota Doria sarees, and said better connectivity would help these industries reach wider markets.

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Chief Minister Bhajanalal Sharma and Union Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu were present at the ceremony.

ISRO, ESA sign agreement on earth observation missions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

The ISRO on Saturday announced that it has signed an agreement with the European Space Agency (ESA) to collaborate on joint calibration, validation activities and scientific studies for earth observation missions.

In a statement, the Bengaluru-headquartered space agency said, the agreement titled "ESA-ISRO Arrangement concerning Joint Calibration and Validation Activities and Scientific Studies for Earth Observation Missions" was signed virtually on March 4 by ISRO Scientific Secretary M

Ganesh Pillai and ESA Director for Earth Observation, Simonetta Cheli.

The arrangement strengthens their long-standing cooperation that began in 1978 and was renewed in 2002. Cheli highlighted the importance of the collaboration in the context of upcoming Earth observation missions, particularly ESA's FLEX (Fluorescence Explorer) mission aimed at improving understanding of vegetation biology.

Pillai noted that the partnership between the two agencies spans several areas including Earth observation, navigation, ground station support and human spaceflight cooperation.



Congress slams Govt over US permission to buy Russian oil

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress on Saturday doubled down on its attack on the Modi Government over US officials' remarks on India's Russian oil purchase and accused it of being "cowardly and compromised".

The opposition party's jibe came after the US said it has given "permission" to India to buy Russian oil that is on ships already floating on waterways with a view to easing supplies around the world amid the West Asia conflict.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has given the Modi Government its certificate for faithfully following President Trump's orders.

"Does anything more need to be said about how cowardly and compromised the self-proclaimed 56-inch chest has become?" Ramesh said on X, posting a video clip of Bessent, in which the US Treasury secretary says that the US has let India buy Russian oil "to ease the temporary gap of oil around the world". Dismissing opposition charges, a senior Government functionary on Friday said India has never been dependent on permis-



Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh

sion from any nation to buy Russian oil, and though the US sanctions' waiver allowing refiners to purchase it removes friction, it does not define the country's policy.

Russian oil continued to flow into India even after the US objected to it and imposed sanctions, the functionary said, citing a 2013 adjustment done by the then Congress Government in oil imports under US sanctions.

After the US announced that it is issuing a temporary 30-day waiver to allow Indian refiners to purchase Russian oil, the BJP on Friday had termed the development a success of the strategic oil diplomacy under Prime Minister Modi, and said it's a "big egg on the face of anti-India Rahul Gandhi and the Congress".

Jaishankar defends India's humane decision as Iranian warship IRIS Lavan docks in Kochi

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said India's decision to allow the Iranian naval vessel IRIS Lavan to dock in Kochi was guided by humanitarian considerations, even as the development coincided with rising tensions in regional waters.

Speaking at the Raisina Dialogue during a session titled "Heart of the Seas: The Future of the Indian Ocean," Jaishankar explained that the Iranian ship had sought emergency access to an Indian port after reporting technical difficulties while operating close to India's maritime boundaries.

"We felt it was the humane thing to do," Jaishankar said, referring to New Delhi's decision to permit the vessel to dock. He noted that the ship had originally been scheduled to arrive in India for a fleet review but had ultimately been "caught on the wrong side of events."

According to the minister, Iran had approached India on February 28 seeking urgent permission for the vessel to enter port due to technical issues. The request was approved on March 1, after which the ship took



several days to reach India before docking at Kochi earlier this week.

Jaishankar noted that the ship carried several young naval cadets, underscoring the humanitarian dimension of India's response. "They were coming in for a fleet review and then they got in a way caught on the wrong side of events," he said.

The docking has drawn attention because it came just days before another Iranian warship, IRIS Dena, was reportedly sunk by a United States submarine off the coast of Sri Lanka while returning from an international naval exercise hosted by India. More than 100 sailors are believed to be missing or presumed dead following the incident.

Referring to developments

in the region, Jaishankar said that countries sometimes face difficult decisions in rapidly evolving security situations. "One obviously had a similar situation in Sri Lanka, they took the decision which they did and one of them unfortunately didn't make it," he remarked.

Emphasising India's approach, Jaishankar said the Government had considered both legal and humanitarian aspects before granting permission. "We approached the situation from the point of view of humanity, other than whatever the legal issues were, and I think we did the right thing," he said.

The minister also reiterated India's support for international maritime norms, particularly the United

Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS), which governs navigation rights and responsibilities in international waters.

Addressing the wider strategic debate surrounding the incident, Jaishankar noted that the Indian Ocean has long witnessed the presence of foreign military forces. He pointed out that the US military base at Diego Garcia has existed in the region for nearly five decades, while international military deployments in Djibouti began in the early 2000s. He also referred to the development of Sri Lanka's Hambantota port during the same period, indicating that the Indian Ocean's strategic landscape has been evolving for years.

Officials said the IRIS Lavan, carrying a crew of 183 personnel, is currently stationed at Kochi, where the sailors are being accommodated at Indian naval facilities while the vessel undergoes necessary checks.

The episode has unfolded amid heightened geopolitical sensitivities in the Indian Ocean region, where growing military presence and maritime competition among global powers continue to shape the security environment.

States Focus



Women's empowerment key to nation's progress: President

On the eve of International Women's Day, President Droupadi Murmu said that educated and empowered women can contribute strongly to a prosperous and progressive nation. In a message issued on Saturday, the president asserted that women are the foundation of our society and nation. Women have demonstrated their talent and hard work in various fields, including education, science, sports, art and defence, the president said. Emphasising that educated, self-reliant, and empowered women can strongly contribute to a prosperous and progressive nation, Murmu noted that young women are shaping the dreams of a new India, and they need appropriate opportunities, guidance, and encouragement.



Veteran journalist Narayan Bareth passes away at 68

Veteran journalist Narayan Bareth passed away here after suffering a cardiac arrest while undergoing treatment for pneumonia, a family member said on Saturday. He was 68. His funeral will be held later in the day in Jaipur. "Bareth had been hospitalised for several days due to pneumonia and suffered a cardiac arrest on Friday night, leading to his death," the family member said. The veteran journalist had worked with the BBC and later served as the Rajasthan Information Commissioner.

Stalin pays tribute to DMK veteran leader K Anbazhagan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

DMK President MK Stalin on Saturday paid rich tributes to the late veteran party leader K Anbazhagan, describing him as a "source of comfort and guidance".

Anbazhagan, who served as a 9-time MLA and was the party's general secretary for 43 years, was a close associate of DMK patriarch M Karunanidhi.

He passed away on March 7, 2020. In a statement on Saturday, Stalin said,

"Professor K Anbazhagan, the great man, a warrior of principles. Whenever the party faced crisis, the professor stood shoulder to shoulder with Kalaighnar (M Karunanidhi). After the passing of Kalaighnar, he was a source of comfort, embrace and guidance for me."

"On the memorial day of our professor K Anbazhagan, who stood as the definition of friendship and commitment to principles, let us take an oath to establish the Dravidian Model Government again!" he said.

Congress appeasement politics denied citizenship to Hindu refugees: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Haridwar

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Saturday said it was the Congress's "politics of appeasement" that denied citizenship to Hindu, Sikh, Buddhist, and Jain refugees.

He said that the Narendra Modi Government will grant Indian citizenship to these refugees from Bangladesh, Pakistan, and Afghanistan, irrespective of the Congress's opposition.

Shah made the remarks while addressing the 'Jan Jan Ki Sarkar, Chaar Saal Bemisal' programme held at Bairagi Camp here to mark four years of Pushkar Singh Dhami's Government in the



Union Home Minister Amit Shah addressing the gathering during an event marking four years of the Uttarakhand Government in Haridwar PTI

State. "I want to say that Hindu, Sikh, Buddhist, and Jain refugees from Bangladesh, Pakistan, and Afghanistan have as much right to this country as Narendra Modi," Shah said.

"Rahul Baba, protest as much as you want. We will grant citizenship; you cannot stop us," he said, referring to the former Congress president. The home minister said the Government

removed encroachment by over 10,000 illegal migrants in Uttarakhand, and accused the Congress of spending all its energy in protecting them. The Centre will expel every single infiltrator from the country, from Kedamath to Kanyakumari, he asserted. Shah congratulated 162 refugees from Afghanistan and Pakistan who received Indian citizenship certificates at the event. "This is the proof of our resolve to give shelter to the victims of religious harassment."

The minister said that the Universal Civil Code (UCC) will become instrumental in stemming the "demographic change" in the country.

AI a game-changer, Andhra to soon produce quantum computers for world, says Naidu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Stressing that artificial intelligence is set to be a game-changer, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Saturday said his state will soon produce quantum computers for the world, while a data centre is also being set up by Google in the southern state.

Speaking at the 11th Raisina Dialogue, the Chief Minister said Artificial Intelligence (AI) would soon change the daily lives of people.

Naidu also stressed the importance of the demographic dividend to defend Andhra Pradesh's decision to



Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu

incentivise having more children. "In Andhra, Google is investing 15 billion USD for a one gigawatt data centre, which is the biggest investment in the recent past," Naidu said.

"Today, we are all talking about Silicon Valley; in the future, people will talk about a Quantum Valley in Amaravati... By the year-end, manufacturing will start,

and we will supply quantum computers to the world," Naidu said.

Andhra Pradesh is setting up a dedicated Quantum Valley tech park in Amaravati, aiming to become a global hub for quantum computing research, development, and manufacturing.

Naidu also termed India's move from IT to AI a "game-changer".

"AI will play a crucial role in every person's day-to-day life. I am confident that it will effect transformative changes in the near future," the TDP supremo said. The Chief Minister also said that the Andhra Pradesh Government is now developing Amaravati as the "most liveable city" in the country.

Break mental barriers to empower women, says NCW Chairperson

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

National Commission for Women (NCW) Chairperson Vijaya Kishore Rahatkar on Saturday said that true empowerment of women begins with breaking mental barriers created by fear, self-doubt and long-standing social conditioning.

Addressing a national convention of women thought

leaders in the national Capital, Rahatkar noted that Indian civilisation has traditionally viewed women not merely as individuals or social roles but as embodiments of power, creation and consciousness.

Referring to the cultural symbolism of Goddess Saraswati, Lakshmi and Durga, she said Indian society has historically recognised women as the founda-

tion of knowledge, prosperity and strength rather than limiting them to the family sphere.

Rahatkar stated that real freedom for women begins from within, as many limitations are often internalised from childhood through societal expectations about how far girls can dream, speak or aspire.

"When a woman recognises that she is not merely a



NCW Chairperson Vijaya Kishore Rahatkar

victim of circumstances but a carrier of change, she rises with confidence and becomes a force of transformation in society," she said.

Citing the mythological story of Goddess Durga emerging from the collective energies of the gods to defeat Mahishasura, she said the narrative symbolises how united positive forces can defeat injustice.

The NCW chief also

emphasised that empowering mothers is key to building a strong nation, as confident mothers nurture confident children, who in turn strengthen society and the country.

She said discussions on the empowerment of women must also connect India's traditions with contemporary realities to ensure greater participation of women in nation-building.

BJP leader detained over illegal opium farm in Chhattisgarh



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

Police have detained a BJP Kisan Morchha leader and other individuals for questioning in connection with the alleged cultivation of illegal opium on a farm in Durg district of Chhattisgarh, an officer said on Saturday.

Amid the controversy, Vinayak Tamrakar, the State Coordinator of the Rice Mill Processing Project of the BJP Kisan Morchha in Durg district, has been suspended for tarnishing the party's image. Tamrakar has denied allegations against him, saying they are linked to political malice.

The illegal crop was reportedly being cultivated in the middle of a seven-acre corn field. Acting on a specific tip-off, a joint team of police and administrative officials reached the spot in Samoda village Saturday morning and launched an investigation.



States Focus



CURBS LIFTED IN KASHMIR AFTER PROTESTS OVER KHAMENEI KILLING

Life returned to normal across Kashmir on Saturday as authorities lifted restrictions which were in effect the whole week in the wake of protests in many parts of the valley following the killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. "Restrictions have been lifted from all parts of the valley and the situation is normal," officials said. They said security forces have removed barricades that were put up at some places, including the Lal Chowk city centre here, to prevent the assembly of people. The iconic Ghanta Ghar at the Lal Chowk had been sealed with barricades erected all around it after it witnessed massive protests on Sunday after Khamenei's killing in a joint strike by the US and Israel.



PUDUCHERRY CM GREETES WOMEN AHEAD OF WOMEN'S DAY

Puducherry Chief Minister N Rangasamy greeted women on the eve of International Women's Day. In his message, Rangasamy said that women are playing a significant role in various sectors and particularly in education, health and administration. He said that women's role is immeasurable not only in the wellbeing of families, but also in the development of the nation. The Union Territory administration had been implementing several schemes for the safety and security of women and also for strengthening their social status and economic empowerment, he said.

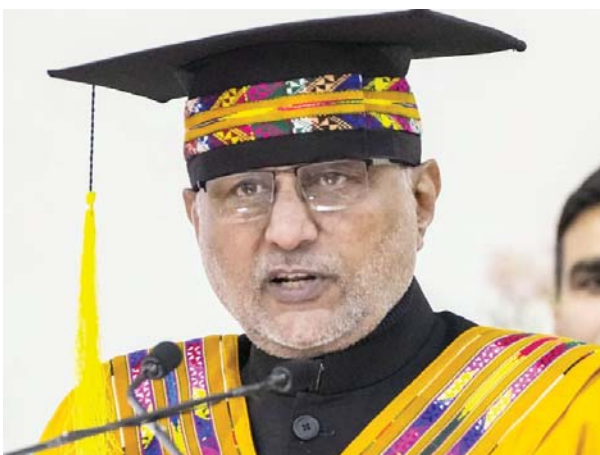
Northeast now defined by new economic opportunities: VP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Aizawl

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Saturday asserted that the Northeast is no longer defined by its geographical distance from the national Capital, but by its proximity to new economic opportunities.

Addressing the 20th convocation of the Mizoram University (MZU), the Vice President noted the shift in the region's development narrative over the last decade and credited the Centre's focus on the 'Act East' policy.

He said that infrastructure milestones, such as the recently inaugurated Bairabi-Sairang railway line, alongside central schemes such as UDAN (regional connectivity) and PM-DevINE, are successfully integrating the region into



Vice President CP Radhakrishnan addressing the 20th Convocation of Mizoram University in Aizawl, Mizoram

PTI

the national mainstream.

Congratulating the graduating students, Radhakrishnan urged them to view themselves as the "architects of Viksit Bharat (developed

"The youth of the Northeast must look beyond seeking employment and instead focus on creating it," the Vice President said. He identified tourism, bamboo-based industries, organic agriculture, handicrafts, and digital services as key sectors where the region holds a competitive global advantage.

Addressing social challenges, Radhakrishnan expressed grave concern over the "menace of drug abuse" among the youth. He called for a disciplined and purposeful lifestyle, urging the graduating students to lead the fight against substance abuse in their communities.

He advised the responsible use of social media and urged the youth to harness digital tools for social good rather than falling prey to their distractions.

130 Maoists surrender before Telangana CM in Hyderabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Ahead of March 31 deadline set by the Centre, as many as 130 Maoists surrendered before Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy here on Saturday.

As part of the surrender process, the cadres handed over 124 firearms, including AK-47 Rifles and over 5,200 live ammunition of various calibre, the highest in recent times in the country with respect to the quality and numbers of arms surrendered by the PLGA (People's

Liberation Guerrilla Army).

Of the 130 surrendered ultras, 125 belong to Chattisgarh, four are from Telangana, and one from Andhra Pradesh, DGP B Shivadhar Reddy said.

"Now there is no Telangana state committee of Maoists. It had completely vanished," the DGP told reporters.

The surrender of weapons has significantly weakened the operational and combat capability of the CPI (Maoist) in the region and put an end to prolonged insurgency in the Central Regional Bureau



Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy looking at a weapon after as many as 130 Maoists surrendered before him in Hyderabad

PTI

(CRB) area, the DGP said.

The surrendered Maoists symbolically handed over their weapons to the chief minister. The surrendered Maoists

belonged to the People's Liberation Guerrilla Army (PLGA), which has now completely lost its existence, the DGP said. Chief Minister Revanth

17 from J&K crack UPSC, leaders hail success

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

A visually impaired serving officer of the Life Insurance Corporation of India, also an alumni of Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) hailing from Bandipora along with a Kashmiri pandit girl from Shopian, a serving officer from the Lamberi area of Nowshera, and the son of a labourer from the South Kashmir district of Pulwama, Friday figured in the long list of successful candidates from the Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir who cracked the prestigious Civil Services Examination 2025.

A total of seventeen candidates, including three female candidates, mostly from remote areas of Jammu and Kashmir, made it to the final list. However, the journey of a visually impaired candidate, Irfan Ahmad Lone of Manzpora in Naidkhai area of



Bandipora, is remarkable and stands out as one of the most inspiring case studies. Since yesterday, their homes have been flooded by family friends, local leaders, close relatives and others who wanted to join the momentous occasion.

Lt-Governor Manoj Sinha and Chief Minister Omar Abdullah also congratulated all the successful candidates. Omar said their accomplishment reflects dedication and

perseverance and will inspire countless young aspirants across the region to pursue their dreams with determination and commitment.

Acknowledging the same, former Minister and senior PDP leader Naeem Akhtar on Saturday congratulated Irfan Ahmad Lone for successfully clearing the UPSC exam. In a statement, Akhtar said that Irfan Ahmad Lone's remarkable achievement has brought immense pride and

recognition to the entire Bandipora district.

"I feel proud as I belong to Bandipora district, and it is always a moment of great happiness when someone from my district cracks such a prestigious examination at the national level," he said.

Akhtar said he has known Irfan personally and closely, describing his journey as one of extraordinary resilience. "I have known Irfan intimately. He comes from a disadvantaged socioeconomic background and has battled immense odds to achieve what he has today," he said.

Highlighting Irfan's earlier accomplishments, Akhtar said that before clearing the civil services examination, Irfan had also cracked the competitive examination for a senior officer's position in Life Insurance Corporation of India and is currently serving there.

He further noted that Irfan

completed his graduation from University of Delhi and later pursued his master's degree from Jawaharlal Nehru University, demonstrating consistent academic excellence despite his visual impairment.

The highest ranking candidate, Suvan Sharma, cracked the exam by securing AIR 148. An alumnus of Government College of Engineering and Technology, Jammu, Suvan, presently serving in the IRMS cadre, had also cracked the JK Public Service Commission exam. Suvan, son of Dr TR Raina, ex-HoD Blood Bank GMC Jammu and Nirmal Sharma (Retd- IAS), is set to get married to an IAS officer of the Telangana cadre next week.

Sugandha Gupta, daughter of a serving bureaucrat, Virender Gupta, cracked the exam in her first attempt, securing (AIR-207).

301 rank row: Two candidates named Akanksha Singh claim same position

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

A controversy has surfaced following the declaration of the UPSC results, with two women from different States claiming the same rank. The dispute centres on the 301st rank, with both candidates named Akanksha Singh claiming the position.

On one hand, Akanksha Singh from Ara in Bihar, granddaughter of Brahmeshwar Singh, founder of the banned militia Ranvir Sena, has been widely reported to have secured the rank.

On the other hand, another candidate, also named Akanksha Singh from Ghazipur in Uttar Pradesh, has claimed that the rank belongs to her. The row intensified after



an admit card circulating on social media appeared to show the same name and roll number, further complicating the matter.

With conflicting claims emerging, attention is now on the Union Public Service Commission for an official clarification. Speaking to reporters on Friday, Brahmeshwar Singh's granddaughter Akanksha claimed

that she secured the 301st rank in the UPSC Civil Services Examination 2025 in her second attempt.

"I was confident about securing the result this time around. This was my grandfather's dream. He had a lot of belief in me," she said. Brahmeshwar Singh was murdered in 2012. Akanksha said she studied for eight to 10 hours daily.

Bihar's Raghav Jhunjunwala secures AIR 4

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Raghav Jhunjunwala, who secured the fourth rank in the UPSC Civil Services Examination 2025, on Saturday, said the support of his parents, teachers, and hard work helped him crack the test.

Raghav, a resident of Bihar's Muzaffarpur district, cleared the examination on his third attempt and secured the fourth rank. He is a graduate in economics from the University of Delhi.

In his first attempt, Raghav cleared the prelims, while in the second, he reached the personality test interview but could not qualify. "This



was my third attempt at the UPSC CSE. I completed my early schooling in Muzaffarpur before moving to Delhi for higher studies,"

Raghav told reporters.

He credited his success to the support of his parents and teachers, along with the consistent hard work for the

examination. According to family members, after completing his schooling at Delhi Public School, Raghav finished Class 12 at GD Mother School in Muzaffarpur, where he emerged as the CBSE Bihar topper.

Arun Kumar, Raghav's maternal uncle, said, "He started preparing for UPSC CSE in 2022, the year he graduated with economics as his honours subject. Raghav used to study 12-14 hours a day. He has been academically bright since childhood and has remained focused on his goal of joining the civil services, he added. Apart from studies, Raghav has hobbies like photography and badminton, Kumar said.

Cancer survivor from Chhattisgarh secures rank 946

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Raipur

Overcoming a six-year battle with cancer and resigning from three jobs, Sanjay Dahariya from Chhattisgarh's Mahasamund district has secured the 946th rank in the UPSC Civil Services Examination 2025 in his third attempt.

The 38-year-old son of a farmer from Beltukri has brought immense pride and joy to his family and the people of his village. Dahariya's academic journey began at a local Government school, but it took a significant turn when he was selected for Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya, Mana (Raipur), in Class 5.



The path to the civil services was fraught with professional and personal hurdles for Dahariya. After a stint with the State Bank of India in West Bengal from 2009 to 2011, he resigned to focus on higher goals. However, in 2012, he was diagnosed with cancer in the salivary glands, leading

to a gruelling treatment that lasted six years.

Undeterred, Dahariya, who also suffers from a minor vision impairment, continued his pursuit of civil services and kept his career on track with another stint at a bank in Raipur and at the Mahasamund Post Office.

He began appearing for the

UPSC Civil Services Examination in 2022, dedicating himself entirely towards his goal, striking gold in the third attempt in 2025.

"I hope to serve the country through the civil services. Whether I secure an IAS cadre or another service, my commitment to public service remains firm," Dahariya said, crediting his success to the unwavering support of his family and mentors during his illness.

Mahasamund Collector Vinay Kumar Langeh and District Education Officer Vijay Kumar Lahare congratulated Dahariya, hailing his achievement, which serves as an example for courage and perseverance.

Rahul Gandhi announces five guarantee schemes if UDF comes to power in Kerala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday announced five guarantee schemes that would be implemented if the UDF comes to power in Kerala. He said free bus travel would be provided for all women, and a monthly assistance of ₹1,000 would be given to college-going girl students. Gandhi also announced that welfare pensions would be increased to ₹3,000 per month. A health insurance

scheme in the name of former chief minister Oommen Chandy would be introduced, providing coverage of up to ₹25 lakh for each family. The Congress leader also promised interest-free loans of up to ₹5 lakh for small businesses.

In addition, he said a dedicated minister would be appointed for the welfare of senior citizens. Gandhi made the announcements while inaugurating the valedictory function of the 'Puthuyuga Yatra' in Thiruvananthapuram. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi



LoP in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi with Congress MP KC Venugopal and others at Sivagiri Mutt in Kollam, Kerala

PTI

interacted with women tea pluckers at an estate in Peerumade on Saturday.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, on his way to board a helicopter in the morning, noticed a group of women plucking tea leaves at the Glenmary estate and asked his convoy to stop before approaching them for an interaction.

Accompanied by Congress MPs K C Venugopal and Dean Kuriakose, Gandhi spoke to the workers and enquired about their wages and the tea plucking process. The women

workers explained to the Congress leader the nature of their work and showed him how the tea-plucking machine is used.

After the interaction, Gandhi took photographs with the workers before leaving the place. Gandhi had arrived at Marian College in Kuttikkanam to interact with students on Friday.

He had stayed at a resort in Peerumade on Friday night and left for Thiruvananthapuram on Saturday morning to attend various events.

PROSPECT

Free health check-up camp organised for anganwadi workers



On the occasion of International Women's Day, Anganwadi workers were honoured for their outstanding work at a programme organised at a city hotel. The Chief Guest, Leena Johri Additional Chief Secretary, Department of Women and Child Development, felicitated the Anganwadi workers. During the programme, health check-ups of the Anganwadi workers were conducted, and a stall showcasing learning materials prepared at the local level for children was also set up. The event was organised by Sesame Workshop India Trust with the support of Marico Limited. The programme was supported under Nihar Shanti Pathshala Funwala, a Marico CSR initiative. Sonali Khan, Managing Trustee, Sesame Workshop India Trust, shared that a programme is being implemented in Bagraich in collaboration with Anganwadi workers as part of the Early Childhood Development initiative. Under this programme, efforts are being made to strengthen Foundational Literacy and Numeracy (FLN) in 100 Anganwadi centres across Bagraich district for young children. On this occasion, Deputy Director Seraj Ahmad, Satya Naidu, CSR Manager at Marico Limited, and Vimal Singh, CDPO, Huzoorpur, were also present.

Board push to include coconut oil in PDS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Saturday said the Coconut Development Board has reached out to State Governments across the country, suggesting the inclusion of coconut oil in the PDS. Briefing the media following a stakeholders' meeting with coconut growers and industry representatives here, the minister stated that substituting other oils with coconut oil in the PDS would not only provide a stable market and better prices for farmers but also offer healthy nutritional options to consumers. "Coconut oil should be provided in the PDS instead of other oils. If we promote coconut oil in the PDS, it will benefit the farmers. The Coconut Development Board has written to all state Governments with this request. We will discuss this further with the State Governments," the minister said.

Chouhan announced that the Central Government is in the final stages of drafting a dedicated Coconut Promotion Scheme aimed at addressing the long-standing grievances of farmers. He noted that the scheme was initially announced by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in the budget, but the Government decided to finalise its contours only after direct consultations with farmers from Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Karnataka, Odisha, and other producing states to ensure the solutions are grounded in reality. Addressing the technical challenges in the sector, Chouhan highlighted that many coconut plantations are over 60 years old, leading to a significant drop in productivity and a lack of resistance to diseases. He said the new scheme would focus on introducing high-yielding varieties that can withstand climate change and combat pests like white fly and root wilt. The minister stressed the



need for biological control of diseases rather than chemical methods, as bio-control preserves the export value and ensures higher market prices for the produce. He also advocated for a zero-waste approach for the coconut crop, which is traditionally regarded as a

Kulpavriksh, where every part of the tree is useful. He suggested that farmers should adopt integrated farming models by utilising the vacant space between coconut trees for inter-cropping with cocoa or pepper, as well as engaging in animal husbandry and fisheries to diversify their

income streams. To support this, he mentioned that the Government aims to promote mechanisation and the formation of Farmer-Producer Organisations to reduce production costs and improve value addition. During the interaction, Chouhan also touched upon

the status of other cash crops in the region, including cashew, coffee, cocoa, and sandalwood. He expressed concern over the declining area of sandalwood cultivation in Tamil Nadu and assured that the Government would take steps to promote these crops by addressing issues related to productivity and disease management starting this year. On the sidelines of the agricultural discussion, the Union minister raised concerns regarding the implementation of central welfare schemes in Tamil Nadu. He claimed that nearly two lakh houses under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana for 2024-25 were yet to be sanctioned by the state and noted that a new housing survey conducted across the country in 2024 had not been carried out in Tamil Nadu. He further urged the state Government to address approximately three lakh complaints received regarding MGNREGA implementation to ensure there is no wastage of funds.

Women leaders are key to Viksit Bharat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Women are natural leaders and are playing a pivotal role in India's journey towards a Viksit Bharat, speakers said at a day-long conference titled "Celebrating Women Leadership" held in the national Capital on Saturday. The event was organised by the Indo-American Chamber of Commerce (IACC) in collaboration with the Society of Indian Law Firms (SILF), a day ahead of International Women's Day. Addressing the gathering as chief guest, Chetan Sharma said women are destined to play leading roles as India moves rapidly toward development. Highlighting the cultural reverence for women, he noted that Indian tradition regards women as the source of creation and leadership. "In our culture it is believed that where women are worshipped, divinity resides.



Mothers are the origin of all things, and women naturally bring excellence to leadership," he said. Speaking as Guest of Honour, Nupur Sharma highlighted the emphasis on women's empowerment under Narendra Modi. She said the Prime Minister had long advocated greater participation of women in governance and development, and that numerous Government schemes today

focus specifically on empowering women. She also underlined India's cultural tradition of revering Shakti, the divine feminine power. Another Guest of Honour, Suvarna Raj, called for a shift in societal attitudes toward disability. She said disability lies more in mindset than in physical limitations and stressed the need for accessibility, inclusive sports programmes for specially-abled children, and greater

recognition of Paralympians as role models. Senior legal professional Nina Gupta observed that while women today are increasingly empowered, societal attitudes still sometimes push them to the margins. She said the legal profession, once heavily male-dominated, has witnessed a remarkable transformation with women now leading courtrooms and institutions.

Conference Chair Lalit Bhasin highlighted IACC's commitment to gender-inclusive leadership, noting that all four regional directors of the chamber are women. In his presidential address, Manoj K Singh emphasised women's natural leadership qualities, while Pia Singh stressed the importance of harmony and equality between men and women for building a more balanced society. Healthcare leader Upasana Arora highlighted the historical strength of Indian women, citing figures such as Ahilyabai Holkar, Rani Lakshmbai and President Droupadi Mummu as enduring inspirations. The conference also presented Women Leadership Awards to ten distinguished women from sectors including healthcare, law, energy and skill development in recognition of their contributions to society and leadership.

Government assures adequate fertiliser stock for Kharif season

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Department of Fertilisers has moved to reassure the farming community regarding the availability of soil nutrients for the upcoming Kharif season, dismissing concerns over potential global supply chain disruptions caused by geopolitical tensions in West Asia and the Strait of Hormuz. In a statement issued on Friday, the Ministry of Chemical and Fertilisers confirmed that the country's inventory remains robust. Data indicates a significant 36.5 per cent year-on-year surge in overall fertiliser reserves, rising from 129.85 Lakh Metric Tonnes (LMT) on March 6, 2025, to 177.31 LMT this year. "This formidable buffer, driven by an unprecedented increase in critical soil nutri-

ents, demonstrates that the nation is exceptionally well-stocked and fully insulated against any global supply chain shock," the Department noted. Current reserves include 59.30 LMT of Urea, 25.13 LMT of DAP, and 55.87 LMT of NPK stocks. Officials emphasised that these levels provide a vital operational cushion, ensuring that international logistics bottlenecks do not impact farm-gate supplies. To maintain this momentum, the Government has already imported 98 LMT of finished fertilisers up to February 2026, with an additional 17 LMT lined up for the coming three months. Furthermore, Indian firms have secured long-term supply agreements for Phosphatic and Potassic (P&K) fertilisers to hedge against regional price and supply volatility.

During a high-level review meeting, the Department underscored that gas supply to the fertiliser sector remains a "top national priority," ensuring that domestic production continues unabated. Fertiliser companies have also been encouraged to prepone their scheduled plant maintenance to March to optimise resources during the current lean consumption period. The Government has urged farmers to continue their Kharif preparations without panic, affirming that their interests remain a central focus of the national agenda. The Department, in coordination with the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, continues to monitor the situation in real time to ensure seamless distribution as global energy markets evolve.

ICC, ICC India and Chintan Research Foundation convene dialogue on WTO reform amid changing global trade realities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The International Chamber of Commerce (ICC), ICC India, and the Chintan Research Foundation (CRF) convened a high-level dialogue on "WTO Reform at a Turning Point: A New Approach for a New Reality" to examine the evolving role of the **World Trade Organisation (WTO)** in a rapidly changing global trade landscape. The event brought together business leaders, policy experts, and trade practitioners to discuss how the multilateral trading system can be strengthened to remain effective, inclusive, and responsive to contemporary challenges. The dialogue highlighted that the global trading environment has changed significantly since the WTO was established in the 1990s. While earlier decades were characterised by shorter supply chains and relatively stable economic conditions, today's global economy is shaped by geopolitical tensions, complex global value chains, and rapid digital transformation. In this

context, participants emphasised the growing importance of strengthening the WTO to ensure stability, predictability, and a rules-based framework for global trade. From a developing country perspective, discussions underscored the need to address issues related to responsibilities, exemptions, and exceptions within the WTO framework, going beyond the traditional debate on Special and Differential Treatment (S&DT). Participants also stressed the importance of maintaining fairness and inclusiveness in WTO governance while preserving core institutional principles such as **consensus-based decision-making**. Another key theme was the need to integrate private sector perspectives more meaningfully into WTO processes, recognising that businesses are the primary actors driving international trade. The dialogue also emphasised the increasing complexity of global value chains and the need for deeper integration between international supply chains and



domestic economies, particularly in sectors such as electronics and manufacturing. Participants highlighted that closer engagement between policymakers and industry will be essential to identify practical solutions to emerging trade challenges. The importance of WTO reform was discussed in the context of rising geopolitical tensions, increasing tariffs, and the growing uncertainty facing global businesses, particularly **micro, small and**

medium enterprises (MSMEs). Participants emphasised the need for a **structured and time-bound process for WTO reform**, with clearly defined milestones and targets rather than broad commitments. Several areas were identified where progress could be made, including advancing discussions on **digital trade and e-commerce frameworks**, strengthening trade facilitation and digitalisation, and exploring mechanisms to enhance **private**

sector engagement within the WTO system. Participants also highlighted that WTO reform presents an opportunity for countries such as India to play a constructive leadership role in shaping a pragmatic and forward-looking agenda for the multilateral trading system. Discussions further highlighted the importance of stability and predictability for businesses operating in global markets. Companies emphasised

the need for greater awareness and understanding of trade rules and dispute settlement mechanisms, particularly as firms from emerging economies increasingly compete in international markets. Participants also raised concerns regarding the growing impact of **non-tariff barriers, sustainability regulations, and environmental standards** on global trade flows. While acknowledging the importance of climate and environmental objectives, it was emphasised that such measures should not become disguised barriers to trade. The WTO was seen as a potential platform for facilitating **technology transfer and cooperation**, particularly to support developing countries and MSMEs in adapting to new regulatory requirements. The **WTO dispute settlement system** was identified as a critical pillar of the multilateral trading system. Participants stressed that restoring an effective and time-bound dispute resolution mechanism is essential for maintaining confidence

in global trade and providing businesses with the certainty needed for investment and long-term planning. Businesses across sectors also highlighted practical operational challenges affecting international trade, including logistics costs, regulatory complexities, and the proliferation of non-tariff measures. While regional and bilateral **free trade agreements (FTAs)** are playing an increasingly important role in shaping trade flows, participants noted that the WTO continues to provide the foundational framework governing global commerce. Approximately **72 percent of global trade still takes place under WTO Most-Favoured Nation (MFN) terms**, underscoring the continued relevance of the multilateral trading system. The discussion also reflected concerns about the increasing fragmentation of global trade governance and the growing influence of geopolitical dynamics on global value chains. In this environment, participants stressed the impor-

tance of preserving the **core principles of the WTO**, including **non-discrimination, Most-Favoured Nation (MFN) treatment, inclusiveness, and consensus-based decision-making**. At the same time, participants acknowledged that new approaches may be required to address emerging trade issues. While **plurilateral initiatives** may offer opportunities to advance discussions on specific areas such as digital trade, it was emphasised that such efforts should complement rather than replace the broader multilateral framework. The dialogue concluded with a strong consensus that **the WTO remains indispensable for ensuring predictability, fairness, and stability in global trade**. Strengthening the organisation through pragmatic, inclusive, and forward-looking reforms will be critical to ensuring that the multilateral trading system continues to support economic growth, investment, and employment in an increasingly complex global economy.

PROJECT MANAGEMENT UNIT (PIU)-USDMA
Uttarakhand Disaster Preparedness And Resilience Project (UPREPARE)
5th Floor, USDMA Building, 36 IT Park, Sahasradhara Road Dehradun
Email : upreparepiu@gmail.com & procurement.uprepare@gmail.com

Ref. No.: 269/A-25/RFB/SEOC/PIU-U-PREPARE/2025-26
DATE: 07.03.2026

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Government of India has received financing from the World Bank towards the cost of the UPREPARE and intends to apply part of the proceeds for following package of works. A complete set of bidding documents in English may be downloaded by interested eligible bidders from the website <https://ukenders.gov.in> which will be available from 11/03/2026.

S No.	Package No.	Name of Package	Method of Procurement
1	03/RFB/INTERIOR/U-PREPARE/2025	Execution of Interior Work in SEOC and Conference Halls at USDMA Building, IT Park, Dehradun	Request for Bid (RFB)

Note:- 1. The corrigendum for the above packages will be uploaded on website www.uktenders.gov.in & www.u-prepare.com
2. Email id procurement.uprepare@gmail.com may be contacted for any information related to the quotations.

PROGRAM DIRECTOR

Dabur's Réal Celebrates Women's Day by Silencing Self-Doubt and Honouring 'Real' Love

New Delhi, March 2026: On the occasion of International Women's Day, Dabur India Limited, a leader in the packaged fruit juice market, has launched a new campaign for its flagship juice brand Réal titled "Keep It Réal." The campaign focuses on empowering women to overcome self-doubt and celebrate the authenticity of their journeys.

Moving beyond traditional Women's Day messaging, the campaign highlights a common but often unspoken challenge—the inner critic that many women face while balancing personal and professional roles. Réal's message emphasises that while moments of doubt may exist, a woman's love for her family, her work, and herself remains stronger and more meaningful.

"As a brand rooted in authenticity, we wanted to celebrate not just achievements but the real journeys behind them, including moments of doubt," said Mayank Kumar, Vice President – Marketing, Dabur India Ltd.

As part of the initiative, Réal has also introduced **"Real Conversations,"*** a series of candid dialogues with women from diverse backgrounds, addressing everyday challenges and highlighting resilience, care, and passion as powerful forces that help women move forward.

SBI launches \$500 million social loan to advance women's economic empowerment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Country's leading lender SBI on Saturday announced the launch of a \$500 million syndicated social term loan facility, focused exclusively on women empowerment with a greenshoe option, on the eve of International Women's Day. This syndicated transaction is a milestone for SBI and the global ESG financing landscape, for the noble cause of women empowerment, the bank said in a statement. This financing is focused on accelerating social impact and demonstrates SBI's commitment



to reduce 'the gender gap' and contributes meaningfully to United Nations' Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 5 – 'Achieve Gender Equality and Empower all Women and Girls'. On the occasion, SBI Chairman C S Setty said, "On this

women's day, we are happy to announce that as a responsible organisation, we are deeply committed to fostering women empowerment as a cornerstone of sustainable development." This landmark social loan embodies the bank's dedication to Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) principles, with a sharp focus on creating opportunities for women, he said. "We believe that true progress depends not only on economic growth but also on our ability to drive positive social change, empower women, and build an inclusive society for all stakeholders," he added.

‘SASHAKT NAARI – VIKSIT BHARAT’: ORGANISED BY CHINTAN RESEARCH FOUNDATION

Heart of India’s Growth Story



L-R: Shishir Priyadarshi, President, CRF; Annapurna Devi, Minister for WCD, Govt of India; and Dr Priti Adani, Chairperson, Adani Foundation, during the lamp lighting at Sashakt Nari — Viksit Bharat, organised by Chintan Research Foundation.



Subodh Singh Head (Mumbai Region), Adani Foundation, Dakshaben Keshavbhai Chaudhary, Suman Vijay Parab, Jyoti Pradip Deshmukh, Sonalben Naran Goyal, Kailashben Rajubhai Patel, Pushpalata Krushna Gautam, Anita Maran, Suraja TK, Shishir Priyadarshi, President, CRF.

“There is no limit to what women can accomplish, except the limits that they place upon themselves.” With this powerful reminder, the inaugural session of the Sashakt Nari, Viksit Bharat Conference 2026, organised by the Chintan Research Foundation (CRF), set the tone for a wide-ranging discussion on the central role of women in India’s development journey recently. Held in the spirit of International Women’s Day and its theme “Give to Gain”, the conference underscored a simple but powerful idea: when societies invested in women’s empowerment, the gains are collective, economic and intergenerational. Opening the session, Shishir Priyadarshi, President of CRF, emphasised that the vision of

Viksit Bharat must go beyond conventional economic indicators. “Viksit Bharat is not merely about GDP growth, infrastructure or global rankings,” he said. “It is about who participates in growth, who benefits from it, and who shapes its direction.”

Despite rising education levels, women’s participation continues to be constrained by unpaid work, social norms, safety concerns and limited access to finance. He stressed that women-led development must be seen as an economic growth strategy, and called for institutional reforms, greater access to capital, shared care responsibilities and stronger partnerships. Thus, the conference was designed not merely

to highlight challenges but to identify pragmatic solutions.

Dr Priti Adani, Chairperson of the Adani Foundation, delivered the keynote address, situating women’s empowerment within India’s broader developmental trajectory. Reflecting on the nation’s aspirations, she posed a fundamental question: “Viksit Bharat for whom, and by whom?” She emphasised that no nation has achieved sustainable development while leaving half its population on the margins of economic activity.

While India’s history offers numerous examples of women’s leadership, Dr. Adani stressed that the transformation India seeks must extend far beyond celebrated figures.

“The India of tomorrow will be shaped by millions of women in villages, small towns and emerging urban centres—women who may never appear in textbooks but whose economic participation will determine the strength of our nation,” she said.

The event was attended by Smt. Annapurna Devi, Union Minister for Women and Child Development, who joined as the Chief Guest. In her remarks, the Minister underscored the centrality of Naari Shakti in India’s development vision.

Like the speakers before her, the Minister too emphasised that empowerment must begin at the grassroots and extend across the life cycle; from education and health to economic opportunity and leadership.

Fostering Women’s Entrepreneurship at the National Conference

The ‘Sashakt Naari, Viksit Bharat’ national conference, organised by Chintan Research Foundation convened leading voices across policy, industry, and philanthropy to address the evolving landscape of women-led development in India.

Segregated amongst multiple panels featuring distinguished dignitaries, one of the highlights of the conference was a panel which focussed entirely on Enterprise, Equity and Empowerment. Moderated by Gargi Rawat, Senior Anchor at NDTV, the session moved beyond conventional discourse to tackle the structural, financial, and societal mechanics required to scale women-led enterprises. The panel underscored the collective consensus that unlocking the entrepreneurial potential of women is not merely a social imperative, but a foundational pillar for a resilient and developed economy.

A recurring theme throughout the discussion was the urgent need to transition from short-term charitable initia-



(From Left - Dr. Abhishek Lakhtakia, Gargi Rawat, Pallavi Joshi Bakhru, Nidarshana Gowani, Shirley Daniel, Sita Pallacholla)

tives to robust, scalable ecosystems. Sita Pallacholla, CEO of WE Hub, Government of Telangana (India’s first state government backed organisation supporting women entrepreneurs), highlighted the effectiveness of institutional frameworks that guide women from idea validation to sustainable income. Striking a chord with the audience, she noted, “Women are often over-mentored and underfunded,” emphasising the necessity of practical, hands on financial support and bootcamps. She also shared compelling success stories born from this structured approach, including

that of Dr Hima Bindu, a paralysed doctor who scaled the production of 14 wheelchair variants, and also of a grassroots millet cookie entrepreneur who transitioned from the informal sector to supplying the Telangana Secretariat and modern supermarkets through formalisation and branding support.

Complementing this state level perspective, Dr Abhishek Lakhtakia, CEO of the Adani Foundation, detailed the corporate sector’s role in driving structural shifts at the grassroot level. He articulated a clear departure from short-term charity towards impactful

interventions.

“We believe in long term sustainable impacts,” Dr Lakhtakia stated, illustrating how traditional Self-Help Groups (SHGs) can be transformed into robust, entrepreneurship based organisations. By enabling women to establish their own market presence, through ventures like cloud kitchens, catering, and Swateja Mart, these initiatives have demonstrated remarkable market integration. Highlighting the scale of this success, he noted that these women-led projects are now achieving an impressive ₹86 crore in annual turnover.

Breaking Lines of Control and Patriarchy: Law, Security and Defence

The persistence of gender hierarchies across institutions of power continues to shape women’s participation in law, governance, and national security. While constitutional guarantees of equality have expanded opportunities for women in public life, structural barriers and deeply embedded social attitudes often limit their advancement to positions of leadership. These tensions formed the focus of the panel discussion titled “Breaking Lines of Control and Patriarchy: Law, Security and Representation”, held as part of the Sashakt Nari, Viksit Bharat: Women-Led Development @2047 Conference organised by the Chintan Research Foundation in New Delhi.

The panel featured Justice Hima Kohli of the Supreme Court of India, Deepti Mohal Chawla, Additional Secretary in the Ministry of Defence, and Gathi Prakash, Partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. Through their professional experiences, the panellists reflected on how women navigate institutions historically dominated by men and



(From Left - Justice Hima Kohli, Deepti Mohal Chawla, Devna Arora, Gathi Prakash)

what reforms are necessary to transform representation into meaningful participation.

Opening the discussion, Justice Hima Kohli offered a compelling reinterpretation of the phrase “lines of control”. While the term typically evokes images of contested borders and geopolitical tension, she suggested that women encounter their own invisible lines of control in everyday life. These boundaries are not enforced by military posts or physical barriers but by inherited customs, social expectations, and deeply entrenched beliefs about gender roles.

Reflecting on the role of the judiciary, she observed that the law itself has historically been shaped within male-dominated public spaces. Women entered the legal framework initially as subjects rather than authors of legal norms.

Over time, however, the judiciary has played a crucial role in recalibrating the law in accordance with constitutional morality.

Offering a perspective from the defence establishment, Deepti Mohal Chawla framed women’s empowerment as integral to national development and security. She argued that no

country can aspire to sustained economic growth or strategic strength while limiting the potential of half its population.

Chawla also highlighted the continuing importance of safety and institutional support for women. Ensuring physical security and equitable working environments is not merely a social concern but a national imperative tied directly to governance and development.

Approaching the issue from the perspective of legal practice, Gathi Prakash highlighted the paradox between scientific equality, constitutional guarantees, and lived experience.



From Left - Amb. Veena Sikri, Dr. Shamika Ravi, Dr. Cchavi Vasisht

India’s ‘Purple Economy’ in the Spotlight: Fireside Chat Ties Unpaid Care Work to Women’s Day ‘Give to Gain’ Call

Unpaid care work, often called the ‘purple economy’, quietly powers India’s households, families, enabling labour market participation of others, supporting public services and even national growth, yet it remains largely invisible in the economic calculations. This hidden labour in the form of cooking, cleaning, childcare, and eldercare, falls overwhelmingly on women’s shoulders, which ultimately restricts female labour force participation, mobility, and entrepreneurial capacity. A compelling fireside chat titled Nurturing the Care Economy — Recognising Unpaid Care Work, held during the Chintan Research Foundation (CRF) national conference brought this issue to life.

The ‘Give to Gain’ theme for International Women’s Day 2026 too recognises women’s unpaid work at home and offers practical ways to ease women’s overwhelming burdens. By giving respect, visibility, knowledge, funding and resources, equal pay and budget along with opportunities and voice, at the home, work and community, the goal is to reduce this “time poverty”.

Women across the globe toil longer hours than men once unpaid domestic and care work enters the picture as the World Inequality Report 2026 starkly reveals. And in India, this injustice cuts even deeper. Dr Cchavi Vasisht, Associate Fellow at CRF, opened the session by stating the striking data from India’s Time Use Survey, that women spend 305 minutes daily on unpaid care activities, compared to men’s 88 minutes, shouldering nearly 84 percent of the total load. This work generates value equivalent to 15-17 percent of GDP, and must be viewed not merely as a private household responsibility but as a critical macroeconomic challenge which demands urgent policy attention to unleash women’s economic contributions.

Dr. Shamika Ravi, member of the Prime Minister’s Economic Advisory Council, emphasised that unpaid care work should not be treated as a women’s issue alone but as a central economic concern. She highlighted structural peculiarities of India’s labour market, particularly the relatively low labour force participation rate (LFPR) compared with other major economies. While China and Vietnam have LFPRs of around 70-75 percent, India’s LFPR remained close to 50 percent a decade ago and has only recently increased to around 55-56 percent.

Ambassador Veena Sikri deepened the narrative with the social and cultural dimensions of unpaid work, breaking down unpaid labour into two major components, i.e. care responsibilities for children, the elderly, and the sick and the household chores such as cooking, cleaning, and maintenance. Even after entering the labour market, women face the double burden as they remain responsible for household duties. This persistent imbalance restricts women’s economic participation and reinforces gender inequality. South Asia exhibits some of the highest levels of gender imbalance in unpaid work globally, with limited progress in redistributing household responsibilities. She also noted that rural women’s agricultural work remains undercounted.

Daughters of the Soil: Voices from Rural India

At the Sashakt Nari Viksit Bharat Conference 2026, one of the most compelling conversations unfolded in the panel titled “Daughters of the Soil: Voices from Rural India.” The session brought together grassroots women leaders and entrepreneurs from across India who shared their journeys of transformation from limited economic opportunities to becoming drivers of livelihood generation in their communities. The discussion highlighted how targeted training, financial linkages, and community engagement by both public institutions and private philanthropic organisations can help rural women overcome entrenched social barriers and build sustainable local economies. Rural women’s economic empowerment is not merely about income generation but also about dignity, agency, and leadership within communities. The stories shared during the session illustrated this case very beautifully.



One such story was that of Sonalben Naran Goyal, Founder of Sri Gopal Gir Gaushala, whose entrepreneurial journey began with a single cow received at the time of her marriage to establish a farm with 50 Gir cows. However, she soon realised that milk sales alone were insufficient to sustain the business and later expanded to value-added dairy products such

as ghee and buttermilk, significantly enhancing their earnings. Today, Sonalben leads a team of ten women who contribute financially to their families’ livelihoods. Her journey demonstrates how diversification and skill development can transform subsistence activities into sustainable enterprises. The panel further highlighted the role of col-

lective women-led enterprises, particularly Self Help Groups (SHGs), in creating new livelihood opportunities.

Dakshaben Keshavbhai Chaudhary, representing tribal and marginalised communities, described how professional guidance and financial support helped tribal women overcome deeply rooted social barriers. Today, she

to between ₹8,000 and ₹23,500 and enhancing their social standing within their communities.

Collectively, the stories shared in the session underscored a powerful message: when rural women gain access to skills, credit, markets, and institutional support, they not only transform their own lives but also become drivers of inclusive rural development.

'SASHAKT NAARI – VIKSIT BHARAT': ORGANISED BY CHINTAN RESEARCH FOUNDATION



(Top Left) A video grab of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta's message to the participants at the 'Sashakt Nari-Viksit Bharat' event, (above and left) A view of the attendees at the event organised recently



(From Left - Nandita Das, Shishir Priyadarshi)

Listening Beyond the Screen: Nandita Das on Cinema, Gender and the Power of Conversation

At the 'Sashakt Nari, Viksit Bharat' conference, actor and filmmaker Nandita Das reflected on the intersections of cinema, gender, and social change, urging audiences to pay closer attention to women's voices and experiences both on and off the screen. A multidisciplinary artist with a career spanning more than four decades, Das has appeared in over forty films across ten languages and directed acclaimed works such as Firaq, Manto, and Zwigato. Her work has consistently explored questions of dignity, identity and social complexity, often centering stories that mainstream cinema tends to overlook.

In a fireside conversation with Shishir Priyadarshi — President CRF, titled "Listen to Her", Das described the phrase not merely as a session title but as a broader call to examine whose voices are amplified in public discourse and whose remains unheard. Speaking candidly about the film industry, she noted that it has historically been male-centric. "When you go to a producer with a project," she said, "the first question is often: who is the hero?" Stories rooted in women's experiences, she explained, are still often perceived as niche rather than mainstream, which creates economic hurdles for filmmakers seeking to tell such narratives.

The conversation also explored the evolving media landscape. While the emergence of multiplexes and streaming platforms once seemed to promise greater space for diverse storytelling, Das observed that commercial pressures remain strong. Digital platforms increasingly prioritise instant audience engagement within the first few minutes, she noted, leaving little room for slower narratives that unpack complex social realities. Her project "Listen to Her" examines the domestic sphere during the COVID-19 pandemic, revealing the irony behind the universal call to "Stay Home, Stay Safe." For many women, she explained, the home became a site of heightened vulnerability rather than protection. She also reflected on the subtle ways women often express frustration and anger. Social conditioning, she said, discourages blunt confrontation, leading many women to communicate dissent through sarcasm or quiet resistance.

Das described conditioning itself as a deeply embedded structural force that shapes behaviour and expectations. Reflecting on her own upbringing, she shared that her parents practised a rare role reversal in household responsibilities and childcare. That environment, she said, enabled both her and her younger brother to pursue their aspirations with equal encouragement. Such nuanced stories, however, can be difficult to explain within the commercial logic of the film industry. As a result, many of her projects rely on diversified funding models involving individual supporters, philanthropic grants and independent investors. "Art", she remarked, "is more like alchemy than science," underscoring the inherent unpredictability of filmmaking.



(From left - Aarushi Nishank, Dr. Sonali Ghosh, Prakriti Srivastava, Ruchi Kashyap, Anju Bisht, Gargi Rawat)

Bearing the Brunt, Driving the Solutions: Women and Climate Action

Climate change is increasingly recognised as one of the defining challenges of the 21st century, yet its impacts are neither uniform nor gender neutral. Across many regions, women often face disproportionate vulnerabilities due to unequal access to land, finance, information, and decision-making spaces. At the same time, women are also emerging as powerful agents of climate action, leading conservation initiatives, strengthening community

resilience, and innovating sustainable solutions at the grassroots. These themes were at the heart of the panel discussion titled "Bearing the Brunt, Driving the Solutions: Women and Climate Action" at the Sashakt Nari, Viksit Bharat: Women-Led Development @2047 Conference, organised by the Chintan Research Foundation in New Delhi.

Moderated by senior journalist Gargi Rawat, the session brought together diverse voices from conservation, grassroots development, environmental advocacy, and sustainable innovation. The panel featured Ms Prakriti

Srivastava, former Principal Chief Conservator of Forests in Kerala; Dr. Sonali Ghosh, Field Director of Kaziranga National Park; Ms Aarushi Nishank, National Convener of the Sparsh Ganga Foundation; Ms Ruchi Kashyap, Executive Trustee of Atmashakti Trust; and Ms. Anju Bisht, Managing Director of Saukhyam Reusable Pads.

The discussion also explored how environmental activism and cultural engagement can mobilise wider public participation in climate action. Ms. Aarushi Nishank spoke about the role of social movements and community campaigns in strengthening environ-

mental awareness. Through initiatives under the Sparsh Ganga Foundation, she highlighted efforts to restore rivers, promote ecological responsibility, and encourage youth participation in conservation efforts. She emphasised that environmental awareness must move beyond policy discussions and become embedded in everyday social practices.

As the session concluded, the panel underscored the importance of integrating gender inclusive approaches into climate policy and governance. Recognising women's leadership, strengthening community participa-

Women Diplomats Reflect on Changing Landscape of Global Diplomacy

At the conference 'Sashakt Nari, Viksit Bharat', a fireside chat titled "Diplomacy Through Her Lens" brought together senior women diplomats to discuss their professional journeys, the evolving role of women in foreign services, and the institutional dynamics that continue to shape diplomatic careers.

The conversation featured Marje Luup, Ambassador of Estonia to India; Mahishini Colonne, High Commissioner of Sri Lanka; Diana Micekeviciene, Ambassador of Lithuania; and Mary M. Mutuku of Kenya. The discussion was moderated by Shishir Priyadarshi.

Referring to the diplomatic community in New Delhi, Priyadarshini noted that a little over 30 women ambassadors are currently posted in the capital. While this reflects important progress, he remarked, it also highlights how far diplomatic institutions still have to go in achieving balanced representation.

Reflecting on her own experiences,



(From left - HE Diana Micekeviciene, HE Mahishini Colonne, HE Mary M. Mutuku, HE Marje Luup, Shishir Priyadarshi)

Ambassador Micekeviciene observed that gender identity sometimes continues to surface in professional diplomatic spaces. Although women have gained greater representation, she noted that female diplomats are occasionally made conscious of being "women first and diplomats second". She added that earlier in India, male counterparts were often prioritised in formal settings, though this dynamic is gradually changing.

High Commissioner Colonne offered a different perspective, emphasising the importance of professional identity beyond gender labels. "I do not see

myself as a 'woman diplomat'. I see myself as a diplomat who happens to be a woman," she said, adding that effective leadership depends on clarity of purpose, fairness in decision-making and consistency in managing teams. Drawing comparisons between Sri Lanka and India, she highlighted Sri Lanka's long history of women in political leadership, including the election of the world's first woman prime minister, Sirimavo Bandaranaike.

Women have also maintained strong representation within Sri Lanka's foreign service without formal reservation policies, although subtle preferences can

still shape leadership dynamics.

Ambassador Mutuku highlighted the challenges faced by women in relatively young diplomatic services. In many societies where leadership has traditionally been male-dominated, she noted, women often have to work harder to establish credibility. Factors such as age and seniority can further complicate perceptions.

She also emphasised the potential for stronger India-Kenya cooperation in diplomatic training and capacity building, drawing on shared colonial histories and vibrant diaspora ties.



(From left - Antara Lahiri, Sheela Bhatt, Archana Borhade, Joyeeta Basu)

Changing the Script: Women in Media Call for Power Behind the Camera

A session featuring prominent women from the media and film industries examined how storytelling shapes society and why women must play a larger role in shaping the narratives that define public culture. The discussion brought together journalist Joyeeta Basu, filmmaker Nandita Das, cinematographer Archana Borhade, film editor Antara Lahiri, and senior journalist Sheela Bhatt, who reflected on gender biases, structural barriers and the changing role of women in India's evolving media landscape.

The conversation also explored how gender roles continue to influence professional environments within the film industry. Antara Lahiri noted that some departments are perceived as more "acceptable" for women due to stereotypes. Film editing, for instance, is often described as a "woman's profession," shaped by comparisons to traditionally feminine activities such as stitching or nurturing. At the same time, she pointed out that the industry's demanding work culture can create significant challenges. Editors frequently work extremely long hours, sometimes up to 16-18 hours a day, schedules that rarely account for women's health or personal responsibilities.

FIRE SIDE CHAT

Strength Behind the Goalpost: Savita Punia on Sport, Sacrifice and Success

The concluding moments of the 'Sashakt Nari, Viksit Bharat' conference organised by the Chintan Research Foundation were marked by an inspiring conversation with Savita Punia, captain of the India women's national field hockey team and widely known as the "Great Wall of India." A recipient of both the Padma Shri and the Arjuna Award, Punia joined Shishir Priyadarshi for a brief conversation to formally close the day-long conference dedicated to women-led development.

Reflecting on her journey, Punia spoke about the path that took her from a small village in Haryana to becoming one of India's most celebrated hockey players. Her career, marked by perseverance and resilience, has made her a central figure in India's recent successes in international women's hockey. Her story, she explained, began at the age of 13 when a teacher at her government school suggested that she try her hand at sports. What began as a simple recommendation soon became a defining turning point in her life. For her family, the opportunity to move from a rural setting to pursue sports training in the city was seen as a moment of great possibility.

During the interaction, Punia spoke candidly about the



responsibilities that come with leading the national team. Captaincy, she said, brings both pressure and accountability, requiring discipline and constant effort to support the team. Throughout the conversation, however, she repeatedly returned to the importance of family. Despite her global recognition, she remains closely connected to her village and continues to prioritise her parents' happiness. Her journey, she reflected, stands as a reminder that talent flourishes when supported by belief, opportunity and perseverance — values that resonated strongly with the broader theme of the conference celebrating women's leadership and empowerment.



Balendra Shah set to form next Govt in Nepal

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

RSP's Balendra Shah on Saturday defeated four-time PM K P Sharma Oli by a huge margin and set to form the next Government in Nepal. Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday congratulated the people and Government of Nepal for the successful conduct of elections. Rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah 'Balen', the prime ministerial candidate of the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) defeated Oli, the chair of Nepal's legacy party, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist–Leninist)—CPN-UML --by a huge margin of about 50,000 votes in Jhapa-5 con-

stituency. Balen, 35, secured 68,348 votes against 74-year-old Oli's 18,734, the Election Commission (EC) said. The RSP, which was formed in 2022 by Ravi Lamichhane, has won 70 seats out of the 87 seats for which results have been declared by 8:30 pm, according to the Election Commission (EC). RSP's seats include a clean sweep in all 10 constituencies of Kathmandu district even as it is leading in 52 seats across the country, the EC data showed. Legacy parties were far behind in convincing voters for whom the major issues included fighting corruption and an end to nepotism apart from a generational change in political leadership of the



Rastriya Swatantra Party's Rajiv Khatri addressing the media in Nepal

Himalayan nation. The Nepali Congress (NC) won ten and was leading in nine seats; the CPN-UML won just three seats and is leading in eight; the Nepali Communist Party (NCP) won two seats and is leading in five, the Shrama Shakti Party (SSP) was leading in three seats, and the Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP) won one seat, the EC data showed. Among the winners is one independent. Nepal witnessed about 60 per cent voter turnout during the March 5 elections to the House of Representatives. The counting of votes started late Thursday night and as of

5 pm Saturday, counting was in progress in 162 constituencies, the Election Commission said. The election was being closely watched by India, which is hoping for a stable Government in the politically fragile Himalayan nation to take forward the developmental partnership between the two sides. PM Modi said that as a close friend and neighbour, India remains steadfast in its commitment to working closely with the people of Nepal and its new Government to scale new heights of shared peace, progress and prosperity. "Balen babu, congratulations for the victory," Oli wrote in his social media post. Oli, who too was projected as the PM face of the CPN-UML, wished Balen for a full five year tenure for his Government in the Himalayan nation that has seen 14 Governments in the last 18 years. "I wish your five year tenure be trouble free, successful and hearty congratulations," Oli said as he attached a 2022 photo showing him gifting a tabla to Balen after the rapper-turned-politician won Kathmandu mayor's election as an independent. The RSP, which projected Balendra as its prime ministerial candidate and had organised its first election campaign in Janakpur in Madhesh, is heading towards a clean sweep of the province.

Iran conflict: Oil and gas prices rapidly rising

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

The price of oil surged higher and showed no signs of halting its rapid climb a week after the US and Israel launched major attacks on Iran that escalated into a war in the Middle East. The conflict, in which nearly every country in the Middle East has sustained damage from missiles or drone strikes, has left ships that carry roughly 20 million barrels of oil a day stranded in the Persian Gulf, unable to safely pass through the Strait of Hormuz, the narrow mouth of the Gulf that is bordered on its north side by Iran. The disruption and damage to key oil and gas



facilities in the Middle East has led to an interruption in the supply of oil and gas. Oil prices surpassed \$90 a barrel Friday, with American crude settling at \$90.90, up 36 per cent from a week ago, and Brent, the international standard, climbing 27 per cent over the course of the week to land at \$92.69. The fallout is ratcheting up what

consumers and business will pay for gasoline, diesel and jet fuel, with some drivers already feeling it at the pump. "It's crazy. It's not needed, especially at a time when people are already struggling, but not unexpected from all this turmoil that's going on," said Mark Doran, who was pumping gas in Middlebury, Vermont Friday. "I don't think there's been an end in sight to any Middle East conflict that's been started by us, so the fact that they say that there's going to be an end that quickly is not believable, and the Middle East is, you know, a place that the US is not going to solve." On Monday, President Donald Trump said that the US expected its military oper-

ations against Iran to last four to five weeks but has "the capability to go far longer." And on Friday, Trump appeared to rule out talks with Iran absent its "unconditional surrender." "The more news we get, the more it seems like this is going to last a really long time," said Al Salazar, head of macro oil and gas research at Enverus. In the US, a gallon of regular gasoline rose to \$3.32 on Friday, up 11 per cent from a week ago, according to AAA motor club. Diesel was selling for \$4.33 a gallon Friday, up 15 per cent from a week ago. The price shocks were felt even more heavily in Europe and Asia, markets that rely more heavily on energy supplies from the Middle East.

Hezbollah issues evacuation warning to northern Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dubai

Lebanon's militant Hezbollah group issued a warning on Saturday for the residents of the northern Israeli towns of Kiryat Shmona and Nahariya to evacuate immediately. Shortly after the Hezbollah warning was issued, alert sirens sounded near Nahariya, Kiryat Shmona and Tiberias. Hezbollah's warning came after Israel's military ordered people in large parts of southern Lebanon and the southern suburbs of Beirut to evacuate. The warnings made



tens of thousands flee their homes and were followed by intense airstrikes. Meanwhile An Israeli special force that landed in eastern Lebanon overnight in search of information about a navigator who has been missing for nearly 40 years did not find his remains, the Israeli military said on Saturday.

23 dead, flights disrupted and military deployed after heavy rains in Kenya

EVELYNE MUSAMBI
■ Nairobi

23 people died, flights were disrupted and the military was deployed as motorists in the Kenyan capital were stranded for hours on Saturday after roads were flooded following heavy rains overnight. George Seda, the police boss in Nairobi, said Saturday that six people drowned and two others were electrocuted, warning that the death toll may rise as search and rescue operations continue. Seda also said that more than 100 vehicles were damaged, with some overturning on the roadside and in parking bays.



Kenya Airways Saturday said flights were disrupted, with some diverted to the coastal city of Mombasa, and that disruptions would continue for hours. The military was deployed to assist emergency rescue services, and the local toll road operator waived fees for an elevated road. Heavy rain began on Friday and continued overnight, submerging vehicles and forcing motorists in some areas to wade through hip-high water to reach higher ground. Videos of flooded homes and overturned vehicles were shared on social media. A military rescue unit was deployed overnight to support emergency services as Kenya Red Cross response units struggled to

reach people in need. Kenya Red Cross Secretary-General Ahmed Idris said search and rescue teams were working tirelessly to assist those stranded. "We are severely limited by the traffic and the situation on what used to be roads. We are doing our best to reach those in need," he wrote on X. Kenya's Public Service Minister Geoffrey Ruku said Saturday that he was coordinating national disaster preparedness, response, and recovery efforts. He urged Kenyans to be cautious and prioritise their safety. Some residents blamed the flooding on clogged

Nightclub bombing in Peru injures 33, including minors: Authorities

ASSOCOTED PRESS
■ Lima

A bombing at a nightclub in Peru has injured 33 people, including minors, authorities said on Saturday. The explosion occurred in the pre-dawn hours at the Dali nightclub in the province of Trujillo along Peru's norther coast, according to a statement from the local Emergency Operations Center. It's a region that has recently been plagued by violence and crime. It wasn't immediately clear who was responsible. At least five of the injured are in serious condition, according to the executive



director of the Trujillo Health Network, Gerardo Florian Gomez. Some of the victims suffered amputations and shrapnel wounds and are undergoing surgery, he told reporters. Among the injured are three minors:

one 16-year-old and two 17-year-olds, Florian said. The explosion occurred less than a month after another blast in the same city that damaged 25 homes but caused no injuries or fatalities.

Russian missile strike kills 10 in Kharkiv

SUSIE BLANN
■ Kyiv

At least ten people were killed and 10 others, including three children, were wounded on Saturday by a Russian missile that hit a five-story residential building in Ukraine's second-largest city, Kharkiv, officials said. President Volodymyr Zelenskyy condemned the attack and called for an international response. He said that Russia struck Ukraine overnight with 29 missiles and 480 drones, targeting energy facilities in Kyiv and other central regions and with damage reported in at least seven other locations across the country. According to preliminary



Firefighters battle a fire in an story apartment building in Ukraine

data, air defence systems downed 19 missiles and 453 drones, with hits from 9 missiles and 26 strike drones recorded at 22 locations. In Kharkiv, in Ukraine's northeast, emergency workers were combing the rubble, looking for survivors. In the Kyiv region, damage from debris was reported in

three districts, according to local authorities. In the southern Odesa region, 80 firefighters were called in to help battle massive fires at infrastructure facilities following an attack with multiple drones. Ukraine's state rail operator, Ukrzaliznytsia, said damage to the rail infrastructure forced changes to

15 terrorists killed in two separate operations in Pak



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Islamabad

Pakistani security forces have killed 15 terrorists in two separate intelligence-based operations in the restive Balochistan province, the army said on Saturday. According to Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), the media wing of the Pakistan army, intelligence-based operations (IBOs) were conducted on Thursday after the reported presence of militants. The first operation was carried out in Harnai district of the province. During the conduct of the operation, the troops effectively engaged the 'Khawarij' hideout, the army said, adding that after an intense engagement, 12 terrorists were killed. The Pakistan Govt notified the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban

Pakistan (TTP) as "Fitna al-Khawarij", a reference to a group in earlier Islamic history which was involved in violence. In another intelligence-based operation conducted in Basima district, the forces tracked the presence of terrorists and effectively engaged them using mixed calibre weapons. After an intense fire exchange, three terrorists were killed, the army said. It added that weapons, ammunition and explosives were also recovered from the slain terrorists. Balochistan has been facing a low-level insurgency and militants frequently target the security forces and Government infrastructure. The Pakistani Government accuses the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) and TTP of these attacks.

Nigerian Army kills 45 militants in Katsina State



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Abuja

Nigeria's military killed 45 militants in the country's northwest region, the Katsina state Government said on Saturday. The clashes between the military and the gunmen happened on Friday in the Danmusa area of Katsina, the state's Commissioner for Internal Security and Home Affairs Nasir Muzau said in a statement. It followed a failed attempt by the gunmen to steal cattle on Thursday. "Seeking revenge, the bandits returned in large numbers on March 6," Muzau said. "What followed was an intense and fierce battle. The

army successfully neutralized all 45 bandits." Nigeria is battling a complex security crisis from different armed groups, especially in the north of the country. The United States has sent troops to the West African nation to help advise its military on the fight against insecurity. Among the most prominent Islamic militant groups are Boko Haram and its breakaway faction, which is affiliated with the Islamic State group and known as Islamic State West Africa Province. There is also the IS-linked Lakurawa, as well as other "bandit" groups that specialize in kidnapping for ransom and illegal mining.

Sri Lanka will repatriate bodies of Iranian sailors



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Sri Lanka will repatriate the bodies of the Iranian sailors who were killed on IRIS Dena, the first Iranian ship that was torpedoed by the US, the Deputy Defence Minister said on Saturday. Sri Lanka said on Wednesday it had recovered 84 bodies of Iranian sailors after the US submarine attack sank the Iranian frigate IRIS Dena off Galle on the island's southern coast. The ship had been returning to Iran from Visakhapatnam, India, where it had participated in a naval fleet review exercise. "The bodies are kept under refrigeration and action will be taken to send them back to Iran," Minister Aruna Jayasekera told reporters answering a query here on Saturday. The Government maintains that the situation has not improved yet to try sending them by air or by sea. The magisterial inquiry and the post-mortem on 84 bodies were concluded in the southern port town of Galle on March 5. Eighty of the 84 were identified by the survivors.

Top PLA general calls on military to resolutely obey Xi Jinping's command

KJM VARMA
■ Beijing

President Xi Jinping on Saturday met a largely condensed delegation of military officials at the annual parliament session after a major purge of the top brass of the PLA, while a top general called on the defence personnel to resolutely obey the Chinese leader's command. President Xi attended a plenary meeting of the delegation of the People's Liberation Army (PLA) and the People's Armed Police Force at the fourth session of the National People's Congress (NPC), China's national legislature, currently holding its annual session. This is Xi's first meeting after the

removal of two senior Chinese military officials, including the highest-ranking PLA official Gen Zhang Youxia in January regarded as a major purge of the PLA in recent history, sending shock waves among the rank and file. Zhang Youxia was the Vice Chairman of the all-powerful Central Military Commission (CMC), headed by Xi himself. After his removal, the six member CMC, which is the overall high command of the Chinese military, has been reduced to two -- Xi and Gen Zhang Shengmin, secretary of the discipline inspection body. Significantly, Zhang Shengmin, the last standing General of the six member



CMC, in his speech at the current parliament session called on the military to resolutely obey the c o m m a n d of Xi. "We must deepen

political rectification, improve Communist Party conduct, fight corruption, and strengthen loyalty to the party's core and resolute obedience to the command

of President Xi Jinping." Zhang also called for more efforts to improve combat-oriented training and preparedness to safeguard national sovereignty, security and development interests. "It is also necessary to push for high-quality development, step up building integrated combat capabilities, strengthen the development and application of combat capabilities in new domains and of new qualities, and enhance military governance," Zhang was quoted as saying by the Hong Kong based South China Morning Post on Saturday. Significantly, no military officials from the Politburo of the ruling Communist Party of China (CPC) attended the

current two sessions of the NPC and the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference (CPPCC), which began from March 4. According to the official website of the NPC, the military delegation attending the two sessions has been condensed from 281 to 243 members, reflecting the series of expulsions of the PLA officials in the last few years for corruption and indiscipline. Besides corruption, the main allegation against the sacked military officials was indiscipline and disobedience of the CPC leadership. Since he came to power in 2012, Xi has been insisting that the military should function under the leadership of

the CPC. Critics say that through the anti-corruption movement he consolidated his power, emerging as the "core" leader of the party, next only to the party founder Mao Zedong. Purges notwithstanding, China on Thursday hiked its defence budget to about 1.91 trillion yuan (\$277 billion), an increase of seven per cent from last year in yuan terms, as part of its efforts to ramp up rapid modernisation of armed forces to catch up with the US military. China, which in the past grew at double digits, has been setting a five per cent target for the GDP in the last three years amid growing domestic and external economic challenges. (AP)

FIT India launches three-day IWD Carnival

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

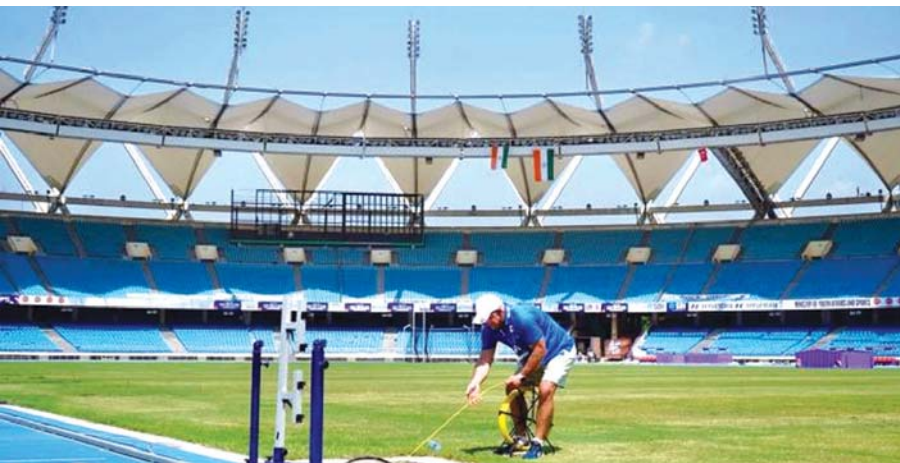
The Fit India Movement launched a three-day International Women's Day (IWD) Carnival at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium starting on Saturday to celebrate the spirit of International Women's Day.

The event, themed "Strong Women, Strong Nation," brought together more than 500 women from India's armed forces and security services, including the Border Security Force, Central Reserve Police Force, Indo-Tibetan Border Police and Delhi Police, celebrating women's strength, resilience

and leadership through fitness activities and sport.

The event featured participation from several prominent personalities who shared their insights on fitness, wellness and women's empowerment. Among them were Paralympic medallist and Arjuna Awardee Preeti Pal, renowned nutritionists Nidhi Nigam and Tanvi Tutlani, entrepreneur Yukti Arya, meditation expert Nivedita Shreyans, yoga experts Divya Ahuja and Pankhuri Srivastav, specialist pelvic floor physiotherapist Dr Garima Biswas, and Fit India champion Timsy Bector.

"When I began my sports



career, many people said I would not be able to achieve anything. I turned that criticism into motivation," Preeti Pal said in a release.

"I decided that since they believed I couldn't, I would prove that I could. Always remember that we are

women and we can achieve anything, never let anyone tell you that you cannot reach your goals."

The morning began with a yoga session, followed by energetic Zumba workouts and breathing exercises aimed at promoting mindfulness and holistic wellness.

The highlight of the event was the Sisters' League, a unique sports league where women of all ages participated in both competitive and recreational activities.

From football shootouts to the traditional tug of war, the event created a lively atmosphere of sport, fitness and the camaraderie of sisterhood.

Chakaravarthy bowled too full or too short: Chawla

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Mystery spinner Varun Chakaravarthy has paid the price for bowling "too full or too short" in the last two matches of the T20 World Cup, believes former India spinner Piyush Chawla.

Chakaravarthy returned figures of 1/40 and 1/64 against the West Indies and England in the last two games. It remains to be seen if India opt to replace him with left-arm spinner Kuldeep Yadav for the final against New Zealand in Ahmedabad on Sunday.

"I feel sometimes when you get desperate or when you try to do too many things, you end up bowling too full or too short, and that's exactly what's happening with Varun," Chawla told JioStar. "His strength is to bowl that hard length, not the one that fast bowlers bowl, but for a spinner, the good length where the bounce is

around knee-high. "Because with his pace, if the batter is not picking him up from the hand, it becomes really difficult as he's so quick off the surface." The 37 year old Chawla, who played 25 ODIs, three Tests and seven T20Is for India, said Chakaravarthy tends to leak runs when he misses his length.



"But when you are a little off radar, then you go for plenty, and this is what's been happening with Varun Chakaravarthy in the last couple of games. "Either he's too full or too short, and with this kind of pace, it becomes easier for the batter to when the bounce is so true on the surface."

India eye women's hockey World Cup berth under returning coach Marijne

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Under a new but familiar coach in Sjoerd Marijne, India will aim to secure a coveted berth at the upcoming FIH Women's Hockey World Cup when they open their campaign against Uruguay in the Qualifiers on Sunday.

The tournament will feature eight teams — hosts India, England, Scotland, Korea, Italy, Uruguay, Wales and Austria — competing for three coveted qualification spots for the global showpiece.

At stake will be three direct World Cup berths, with the teams finishing first, second and third in the tournament earning direct qualification for the 2026 edition to be hosted jointly by Belgium and the Netherlands from August 14 to 30 alongside the men's event. It will be Marijne's first assignment back as head



coach, as the Dutchman returns for the second time since leaving the position after the team's historic fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021. India are currently ranked ninth in the world and are the second-highest ranked team in the tournament behind England, who are ranked seventh globally.

"We are really excited to play the qualifiers at home in front of our fans. The team has been preparing very hard for this tournament because we know what is at stake. Every team here is competing for a

place in the World Cup, so we expect tough matches from the start," India captain Salima Tete said.

Going by world rankings, India start as favourites against Uruguay and if not for a bad day in office, they are certain to win.

After Uruguay, India will take on Scotland and Wales on March 9 and 11 respectively.

Meanwhile in other matches of the day, England will play Italy. Korea will be up against Austria and Scotland against Wales.

In the qualifiers, the teams are divided into two

pools, with England, Korea, Italy, and Austria in Pool A, while hosts India, Scotland, Uruguay, and Wales form Pool B.

The top two teams from each pool will progress to the semifinals. The winners of both semifinals and the bronze medal match will secure automatic qualification for the World Cup. Additionally, the highest world-ranked team finishing fourth in this tournament will also earn a place at the World Cup.

The upcoming World Cup will feature 16 teams in both the men's and women's competitions, with nine teams in each category already having secured qualification.

India have played in eight editions of the Women's World Cup so far and are targeting their ninth appearance. Their best finish came in the inaugural edition of the tournament in 1974, when they finished fourth.

Taiwan beats Vietnam 1-0 in Women's Asian Cup match

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Perth

Taiwan defeated Vietnam 1-0 on Saturday to move into second place in Group C at the Women's Asian Cup with one match remaining.

Su Yu-hsuan scored the decisive goal in the 26th minute after Saki Matsunaga's shot hit the crossbar, leaving Su to nod the rebound into an empty net for the team which won the last of its three Asian Cup titles in 1981.

It was a deserved victory for Taiwan, 2-0 losers to Japan on Wednesday, which created several chances to extend its lead. Vietnam, the 2022 quarterfinal



ist, beat India in its opener but struggled to threaten the Taiwan defense and failed to record a shot on target. Thi Duyen Tran came closest with a first-half chance that went wide from inside the

area. Both teams now have three points from two games. Taiwan sits ahead of Vietnam and behind Japan, which faced India later Saturday. India is still seeking its first point in the tournament.

Record attendance continues Australian organisers said Saturday that the tournament had sold 250,000 tickets. The milestone follows the tournament already breaking the all-time total attendance record, with 92,795 fans at the first 10 matches.

That surpassed the previous record of 59,910 for the 2010 edition in China. The top two teams in each of the three groups advance to the quarterfinals along with the two best third-place teams.

‘Surya’ Uday: Plucky New Zealand stand in the way of India's date with history

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ Ahmedabad

An insanely talented and incredibly consistent Indian cricket team will carry the weight of a nation's hopes in its pursuit of history when it goes up against a tenacious New Zealand in a classic David versus Goliath final of the T20 World Cup here on Sunday.



On November 19, 2023, the expansive amphitheatre called the Narendra Modi Stadium witnessed a teary-eyed and emotionally spent Rohit Sharma drag himself up the dressing-room stairs after Australia had silenced India in the ODI World Cup final.

The distraught home side and a silent stadium, with 93,000 people, have carried the cross ever since even though the T20 team somewhat made amends for that heartbreak by winning the 2024 world title under Rohit.

The shortest format team will now look to become the first side ever to defend the crown under Suryakumar Yadav and also the first to win the coveted trophy three

times. Suryakumar, a street-smart cricketer who embodies the famous Mumbai spirit, will not only be itching to create his own legacy as captain but also want to put an end to the agony of November 19, 2023.

Suryakumar and his mates can draw inspiration from what happened exactly 364 days back on March 9, 2025. It was the day India beat an almost similar New Zealand side in the ICC Champions Trophy albeit in the 50-over format.

Suryakumar wasn't a part of that side but can always take heart from that one-sided win in Dubai.

To win a final, one needs

a lot of pluck but also can't do without a slice of luck. It need not be a perfect game but right things need to happen at the right time.

India literally won the semifinal of the ongoing showpiece when Harry Brook dropped Sanju Samson. The 'Men In Blue' wouldn't mind such bloopers from opposition on Sunday.

It won't be unfair to say that from draws, to venues to the tacky TV commercials and the awful social media din, this Indian team has had the rub of the green all the way till final. If they win, it will be a job well done and nothing more. If they lose, all

hell might break lose. As skipper, Suryakumar not only has the chance to become the first among equals to defend a World Championship.

He has led the side impressively for last two years even though he has hardly walked the talk as a batter himself, especially on big days and against big nations.

He can change it all on Sunday in what will be the most defining moment of his entire career. His every failure will be summarily forgotten should he click on what is expected to be a warm evening.

But at Motera, India's one-stop destination for all big cricketing events, India will have one of the most "loved" cricketing nations standing in its way.

On a given day, a Finn Allen, a Lockie Ferguson or a Matt Henry know how to punch way above their weights.

This New Zealand team has an air of familiarity about it but the most genial assortment of players in global cricket can never be viewed with contempt. (PTI)

NZ will be ‘chokers’ if they lose final: Dale Steyn

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

South Africa pace great Dale Steyn says New Zealand would deserve to inherit the unwanted "chokers" tag if they fail to beat hosts India in the T20 World Cup final in Ahmedabad on Sunday, saying it would be nearly impossible for the Kiwis to topple the home side..

New Zealand have entered the summit clash for the second time in the T20 World Cup history by beating favourites and perennial



"chokers" South Africa in the first semifinal at the Eden Gardens in Kolkata.

India beat England by seven runs in a high-scoring second semifinal at Mumbai on Thursday. Steyn said New Zealand have made it to the

final of the World Cups more than the Proteas, and if they come short on Sunday the chokers tag should be handed over to them.

New Zealand played the finals of the 2019 50-over World Cup, 2021 T20 World Cup and the 2025 Champions Trophy, and came up short on all three occasions.

"Let's be honest here. Everyone likes to call South Africa chokers, but I am going to say it. New Zealand haven't won many World Cups themselves, and they have been in more finals than we have. So,

no offence, New Zealand, but please go on to win this," said Steyn in a chat with AB de Villiers on the latter's YouTube channel.

"Otherwise, I am formally handing over that card to you; it's yours. I love New Zealand, but they won't beat India."

The legendary South African pacer, who has more than 400 Test wickets to his name, believes India are the favourites and said it would take a "monumental choke" from the hosts to lose the title clash.

Agarkar's three years: The art of taking tough calls beyond numbers

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ Ahmedabad

When Ajit Agarkar took over as the chairman of India's senior selection committee, the circumstances were anything but routine.

His appointment followed the unceremonious exit of Chetan Sharma (caught making loose comments on a TV channel's sting operation). The transition came with the kind of scrutiny that accompanies every powerful position in Indian cricket.

Three years later, his tenure can best be described as eventful, filled with difficult calls, bold convictions and an acceptance that the role of a selector rarely fetches applause.

A selector is like a wicketkeeper. The good catches might draw a feeble applause but a sharp drop will invite sharper criticism. There is a certain symmetry to Agarkar's journey.

Back in 2020-21, when the top selector's post had opened up, it was Chetan Sharma who had

pipped him despite Agarkar being an applicant. When the opportunity finally came his way in mid-2023, he inherited a responsibility to rebuild trust in a selection process that is constantly under public glare.

In the broader history of India's selection committees, particularly in the years following the influential tenures of Dilip Vengsarkar and Krishnamachari Srikkanth, Agarkar has arguably been among the most talked-about chairman.

That attention has come not merely from the position he holds but from the nature of decisions he has been willing to take.

Over the past three years, the Indian team has played four ICC finals (2023 ODI World Cup, 2024 T20 World Cup, 2025 Champions Trophy, 2026 T20 World Cup), winning two and losing one.

It could be three wins overall if India wins on Sunday against New Zealand in the T20 World Cup final. While the players and support staff rightfully command the spot-



light for performances on the field, the selectors' role in shaping squads for global tournaments cannot be overlooked. Agarkar's tenure has been marked by calls that demanded conviction that could withstand criticism.

His bullish backing of Suryakumar Yadav as a long-term T20I captain over Hardik Pandya was one such move.

Far more sensitive was the decision to replace an extremely successful and sentimental favourite

Rohit Sharma as ODI captain. In both instances, Agarkar did not attempt to hide behind silence.

He fronted up, taking the inevitable bullets that came with high-profile calls. If statistics alone were the parameter, every cricket lover could pick their own playing eleven. But selection is rarely that straightforward.

It demands the ability to identify players, understand roles and visualise how individuals fit into a larger tactical framework. On that

front, it must be said that Agarkar and his panel, earlier comprising S Sharath (now replaced by Pragyan Ojha), along with Subroto Banerjee (now replaced by RP Singh), SS Das and Ajay Ratra, have done more than a commendable job in white-ball cricket. Call it the IPL effect, but India today possesses an enviable depth of talent.

New Zealand's Glenn Phillips remarked ahead of Sunday's final that India have enough players to field "three T20 teams".

Managing talent in abundance, at times can be way more challenging than managing the paucity of it. For a selection committee, every opportunity granted to one player inevitably means disappointment for another. May be for Agarkar, the most crucial realisation has been that a selector cannot afford to be a people pleaser.

The role demands distance, clarity and the courage to accept that popularity cannot be the yardstick for every decision. It has not been an easy path. (PTI)

England, SA, WI to leave India on ICC charter flights over weekend

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

England, South Africa and West Indies are set to depart India over the weekend on chartered flights arranged by the ICC following disruption to commercial air travel due to the ongoing conflict involving US, Israel and Iran.

A source told media that England, who went down to India in the second semifinal on Thursday, are expected to leave from Mumbai on Saturday evening on a direct flight to London.

West Indies and South Africa are the other two teams still in the country despite their campaigns having ended.

While the Windies were knocked out of the T20 World Cup after India defeated them by five wickets at the Eden



Gardens on Sunday, South Africa's campaign ended after their defeat to New Zealand here in the first semifinal on Wednesday.

Both South Africa and West Indies will travel together from Kolkata on a another charter flight.

The two sides are likely to fly first to Johannesburg before the West Indies contingent continues onward to Antigua. The exact departure time is yet to be confirmed but the flight is expected to leave on Sunday.

Women of the Woods

This Women’s Day, honour the women carrying families through silence and struggle, says SAKSHI PRIYA

Fifty-four percent. It’s a number that should stop you cold. That is the actual percentage of indigenous women in our rural heartlands who can’t even read their own names. Let that sit with you for a second. While the rest of the world is busy prepping grand speeches and hashtags for Women’s Day, a staggering 67 percent of young tribal girls are vanishing from their classrooms before they even see the eighth grade. It is a harsh, deeply uncomfortable reality staring right back at us.

Step off the paved highways. Walk into the quiet, deep forests where the air smells of wet earth and survival. Here, the polished illusion of modern empowerment shatters. Extreme poverty and the brutal, everyday demand of staying alive tear schoolbooks away from these girls. Heavy baskets and the heavy, quiet chains of early marriage replace their education. It makes you wonder — how liberated are we, really, when the very foundation of our rural world bleeds in total silence?

What happens to the estimated 400 million rural women globally who live entirely off the grid when the empowerment seminars end? The global data on female poverty is a bitter pill to

swallow. Millions of them survive on less than two dollars a day, bearing the absolute total weight of their household’s survival. Nobody tracks their daily commutes across barren lands. Nobody records how many miles they walk just to keep their children breathing. The mainstream conversation around equality completely ignores the women fighting the ugliest wars against starvation and systemic exploitation. Real resilience is rarely glamorous. It is fought in the dust, usually with bare hands.

We clap for the loud, visible victories. But what about the victories that look like a handful of rice? We walk right past the mothers who are quietly bleeding into the soil, the women tearing themselves apart just to make sure their kids survive one more sunset. Nobody cheers for a mother pulling her family through another brutal day of starvation. The absolute heaviest courage on this planet never gets a microphone. It lives down in the dirt, held together by women who refuse to let their children go hungry. Leave the global summits behind and travel into the deep tribal heartlands of eastern India. In the Khunti district of Jharkhand, the modern infrastructure the world constantly brags about evaporates completely. Here, a specific group of ten Adivasi women live a reality defined entirely by raw grit. Many of these women are widows. Some care for husbands incapacitated by illness or chronic unemployment. They carry the survival of their families entirely alone. Smartphones bypassed them. Formal schooling evaded their generation. But they possess something else — heavily calloused hands and an ancient, generational skill.



forests to harvest raw bamboo. Sitting on the hard earth for hours, they weave intricate baskets, ceremonial flowers, and the traditional *soop* mandated for local weddings and rituals. Then comes the hardest part. They strap massive, back-breaking loads of this handiwork to their shoulders and walk. They cover miles of unforgiving dirt roads. They navigate chaotic city markets and knock on doors in neighbouring settlements, desperate to barter their indigenous heritage for a daily meal. To navigate this landscape as a single, unprotected woman brings a crushing vulnerability that would shatter most people. Yet they keep walking. Hunger leaves absolutely zero room for surrender.

And poverty like that? It brings out the worst kind of predators. Human traffickers hover around these tribal belts constantly, looking for desperate, ungarded young women and vulnerable widows. It’s happening every day. Communities are quietly losing their daughters and sisters to a brutal underground trade. Right in the middle of this nightmare, living in a forgotten village in Jharkhand, stands Bhoothmani. We talk a lot about female resilience around early March, but her life is the actual, bleeding blueprint of it. They took her at eight years old. When she finally surfaced on a quiet road, there was almost nothing left. The trauma had taken her memories and her voice. Normally, when a person goes through something that deep, they never really return.

A nine-month bridge course slowly dragged her back to the real world. She fought her way into a regular classroom, eventually married a local driver, and had two children. For a very brief window, she actually got to taste a quiet, ordinary life. Then her husband passed away. Whatever tiny safety net she had built evaporated overnight. She was completely alone again — a single mother standing face-to-face with the exact same crushing poverty and extreme vulnerability that almost destroyed her own youth.

Grief destroys people out here every day. You would expect someone in her shoes to simply give up. Bhoothmani went the other way completely. She took that entire trauma and forged it into armour. Signing up as a Paralegal Volunteer, she started walking right back into those isolated villages. She tracks down terrified parents and tells them the absolute, brutal truth about where their missing daughters actually end up. Now she sits on the Child Welfare Committee board. When a phone rings at two in the morning about a trafficker on the move or a sudden child marriage, she is the one who answers. She intercepts them herself.

Her husband is gone. Her fire is entirely intact. She has personally rewritten the fate of thousands of young girls across the district. The men hunting these villages are



dealing with someone they failed to destroy. You sit across from Bhoothmani, ask her why she risks her life going back into the darkest parts of the district, and her answer leaves you completely quiet. She will not stop until every girl and woman in her community can step outside their homes and smile. No looking over their shoulder in absolute terror. That is her entire life’s mission. This raw, bleeding edge of womanhood rarely makes the front page. But on a day meant to celebrate power, Bhoothmani is the hero we should be talking about.

The survival of *Santhal, Munda, Oraon, and Ho women* directly challenges everything we casually label as progress. These women have always stood as the original protectors of *Jal, Jungle, and Jameen*. They still form human shields to save their forests today, tying rakhis to ancient tree trunks, ready to spill their own blood before letting a single axe touch the bark.

Their feminism was pulled barehanded from the rough red soil of Jharkhand. You see that exact fire in the heavily calloused fingers of the Khunti widows, weaving bamboo in the dust to keep starvation locked out of their homes. You see it in mothers pushing through severe anaemia every single day because stopping to rest means their children go hungry. True empowerment remains a complete lie while this massive gap exists. Offering a fleeting moment of acknowledgement once a year is a pitiful bare minimum. The grinding struggles of these matriarchs form the actual, bleeding heart of this land. Bouquets will be passed around all week. Our screens will be buried under a mountain of those perfectly polished hashtags. But we really need to pause and face a hard, jagged truth. If that woman weaving bamboo baskets can never afford to rest her scarred shoulders, and the monsters Bhoothmani spends her life fighting are still out there circling the dark woods, whose freedom are we actually celebrating?

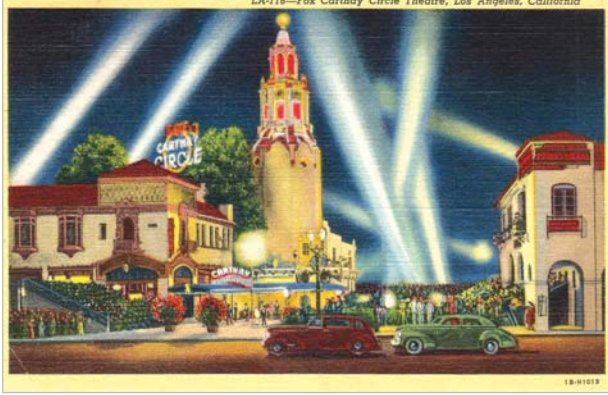
LETTERS TO ALL THE WOMEN

To all the amazing women,

We know how relentless the noise gets. You are constantly expected to hold up the entire sky whilst making it look completely effortless. That weight? It’s a lonely, heavy thing to carry. But you never walk into a room with empty hands. You carry every battle you survived right through that door with you. You have yourself. That fierce, quiet instinct sitting right behind your ribs is your absolute best guide. If a choice makes perfect sense to your own heart, take the leap. Ignore the audience. And this Women’s Day, do not sit around waiting for someone else to bring you flowers. Go buy them for yourself. Better yet, realise you do not even need the bouquet. You planted the entire garden. Happy Women’s Day

- The Editorial Desk

Shadows of Greatness Return



Cinema once built dreams on celluloid. An exhibition revisits Hollywood’s golden era through rare archives, posters and stories

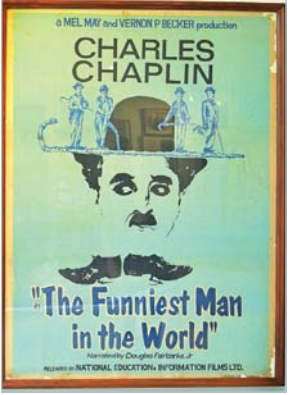
TEAM VIVA

Cinema acts as a vital link, binding the hardness of reality to the collective dreams of the public. Between 1914 and 1964, Hollywood under went a radical metamorphosis, outgrowing its early identities as a niche experiment to become a dominant global dialect. This era of transformation defined the IIC Main Gallery’s recent exhibition, ‘The Greatest Show on Earth’, which brought decades of archival research into the public eye. Drawing from the extensive archives of the Tuli Research Centre for India Studies and curated by Neville Tuli, the showcase illuminated thirty years of dedicated scholarly preservation.

The story started when filmmakers broke from Thomas Edison’s patent control. This freedom birthed studios like Paramount and Universal. A

striking visual anchor was Gigi Scaria’s 2010 inkjet print, *Who Deviated First?* This work on archival paper stands 197 centimetres tall. The artwork functions as a vertical interrogation of the past. Its massive scale forces a break in the horizontal flow of the historical film posters and rare archival materials. It questions the exact moment when the rigid, epic traditions of 1913 Italian spectacles like *The Last Days of Pompeii* and *Quo Vadis* began to splinter into new artistic directions. Scaria’s work pulls the raw, visual weight of the silent era into the present, grounding today’s perspectives in those early, unspoken roots.

What is it about a century of flickering shadows that allows



these early cinematic experiments to still dictate the shape of modern fears and ambitions? The exhibition addresses this by organising the archive across ten distinct pillars, juxtaposing the irreverent wit of the Marx Brothers against the high-gloss ‘Glory of Stardom’ featuring legends like Marilyn Monroe, Clark Gable, and Marlon Brando. The ‘German Expressionism’ section presented the haunting geometry of *The Cabinet of Dr Caligari*, *Faust*, and *Metropolis*. Why do century-old shadows still grip the modern psyche? These productions fundamentally altered the global perception of psychology and the unknown. Within *The Nature of Uncertainty*, Hitchcock’s suspense and *Dracula*’s dread probe fear. Rooted in thirty years of research, the showcase establishes cinema as a vital prism for decoding international cultural shifts.

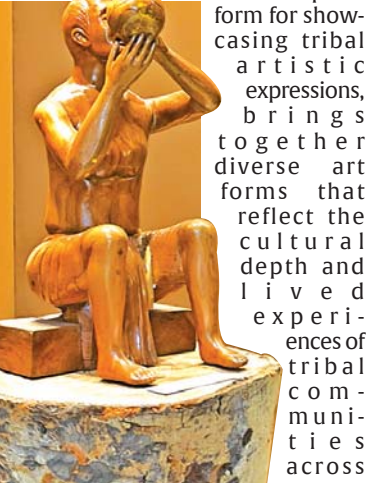
From the early drama of the 1922 film *Foolish Wives* to the arrival of James Bond and Walt Disney, the exhibition offered a raw, detailed journey. The display proved that the early pioneers turned light and shadow into a permanent world legacy.

Art, Identity and Empowerment



TEAM AGENDA

Art can be a powerful instrument not only of creative expression but also of social transformation. This message resonated strongly at the inauguration of the TAF - Tribe Art Fest - A Painting Exhibition, launched by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs to celebrate India’s rich tribal art, heritage, and cultural traditions. The exhibition, conceived as a vibrant platform for showcasing tribal



artistic expressions, brings together diverse art forms that reflect the cultural depth and lived experiences of tribal communities across the country. By presenting traditional motifs, symbols, and narratives through visual art, the festival seeks to foster cultural awareness, unity, and appreciation of India’s indigenous heritage. The inauguration ceremony was attended by several distinguished dignitaries. Dr. Jai Madaan, celebrity spiritual mentor, cultural creator, and motivational speaker, graced the event and spoke about the importance of cultural consciousness and the profound wisdom embedded in tribal traditions. According to her, tribal art is not merely decorative but deeply spiritual and reflective of a community’s relationship with nature, identity, and collective memory.

Highlighting the deeper role of artistic expression, Dr. Madaan described art as a medium of healing and empowerment. She particularly emphasized its significance for tribal women, noting that creative expression allows communities to preserve traditions while also strengthening self-confidence and social visibility.

One of the major highlights of the exhibition is a striking installation titled ‘Tribal Ashtlakshmi,’ created by Siddhhi Arts using fiberglass and

brass. The installation symbolises the healing power and empowerment of tribal women. Conceptually, it draws inspiration from the eight sacred forms of Goddess Lakshmi, each representing a different dimension of prosperity. The installation links these eight forms with the diverse regions of India and portrays prosperity not merely as material wealth but as a broader concept encompassing knowledge, courage, nourishment, strength, resilience, and spiritual grace. By integrating eight traditional art forms into a single visual narrative, the artwork celebrates the creativity, dignity, and cultural richness of tribal communities. The exhibition serves as a reminder that tribal art is not only a repository of heritage but also a living tradition that continues to inspire dialogue on identity, empowerment, and cultural pride.

As visitors engage with the artworks and installations, the festival underscores a broader vision - one where art becomes a bridge between communities, nurturing both cultural preservation and social empowerment.

ONE OF THE MAJOR HIGHLIGHTS OF THE EXHIBITION IS A STRIKING INSTALLATION TITLED “TRIBAL ASHTLAKSHMI,” CREATED BY SIDDHHI ARTS USING FIBERGLASS AND BRASS



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In one of the most dramatic escalations in West Asia, the US and Israel launched a massive joint military assault on Iran on February 28, 2026. The strikes killed Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Iran retaliated through missile attacks across the region. What Washington and Tel Aviv describe as a "preventive strike" against Iran's nuclear ambitions has been condemned by many analysts as destabilising act that could ignite a wider regional war with profound global consequences

US-Israel attack on Iran: Escalating crisis in West Asia

Today, the situation between Iran, Israel, and the US is deeply rooted in several decades of political animosity, strategic competitions and long-standing regional conflicts. Before the 1979 Iranian Revolution, there was a hidden partnership between Iran and Israel that included both military and intelligence cooperation. However, this partnership ended on account of the establishment of the Islamic Republic of Iran by Imam Ruhollah Khomeini in Iran. Iran, since then, has severed all diplomatic ties with Israel and referred to it as the "Islamic enemy." At the same time, Iran began to support Hezbollah and other proxy groups in the region. When Iranian students stormed the US Embassy in Tehran and took 52 US diplomats hostage for 444 days, relations between Iran and the US were severely strained. Relations between Iran and the US have worsened in the last couple of decades due to Iran's increased influence in the region and controversy surrounding its nuclear program. Israel has consistently alleged that a nuclear-armed Iran would present an existential threat; thus, Israel has relied on a variety of covert means to counter this apparent existential threat, including cyber-attacks, as well as periodic military clashes, all of which have contributed to making the geopolitics of West Asia so volatile.

Attacks and Loss of Human Life

The joint military attacks initiated against Iran by both the United States and Israel have been targeted against significant military infrastructure, such as military bases and command facilities, associated with the Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps (IRGC), resulting in the loss of numerous senior-level military leaders or security officers. The most significant impact would have been on 28 February 2026, when reports indicated that the commander-in-chief of Iran, the supreme leader, Ali Khamenei, had reportedly been killed, which created an unprecedented political and security void, thus further increasing instability within Iran's leadership and strategic command structure. Civilian losses are among the most disturbing consequences of conflict. One of the deadliest incidents occurred in the southern town of Minab, Iran, when an airstrike took place at the Shajareh Tayyebeh Girls' Elementary School during class hours, causing the deaths of more than 165 people, mostly school girls, and injuring many more. As per both the Iranian Government report



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and other Independent Reports based on Open-Source Intelligence, satellite imagery indicates that a precision airstrike caused this explosion. In addition to the tragic loss of life from these air strikes, the infrastructure has been destroyed, causing an interruption of daily life and increasing fear of continuing war throughout the country.

The Regional Crisis

Iran's retaliation against both the US and Israel was on a large scale, and the result has escalated quickly into a regional crisis. Iran retaliated with ballistic missiles as well as armed drones, targeting Israeli cities and key US bases in the Gulf (i.e., bases in Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, and the United Arab Emirates). Iranian forces targeted the command-and-control locations of the US Fifth Fleet in Bahrain, as well as other US logistic locations, signalling that Iranian forces view US military presence throughout the region as legitimate military targets. In the first wave of attacks from Iran, over 200 ballistic missiles and drones were launched, providing evidence of Iran's increasing capabilities to conduct long-range strikes.

These attacks resulted in significant loss of life and damage to many different infrastructure systems in Gulf countries. A total of at least six US military personnel were reported killed because of the attacks against US bases, while the airports, radars and energy facilities located in the attacked countries have all been severely impacted by these strikes. Additionally, strikes against Israeli cities such as Tel Aviv and Haifa resulted in several Israeli civilian casualties, even with advanced air defence systems attempting to intercept incoming projectiles. With Iran conducting air-space closures and attempting to launch missiles over the cities of Abu Dhabi and Dubai, heightened fears have arisen throughout the Gulf of a possible continuation of the US-Iran confrontation and a wider regional war, with a high probability of further instability in West Asia.

CONTINUED ON >> P11

CHRONOLOGY OF EVENTS

- JUNE 13-24, 2025** Israel launches major airstrikes on Iranian nuclear and military facilities, triggering a brief but intense 12-day war. Iran retaliates with missile attacks on Israeli cities before a fragile ceasefire is reached.
- LATE 2025** Tensions rise again amid stalled nuclear negotiations and Iran's missile tests, with the United States warning of possible military action.
- 27 FEB 2026** Reports emerge of military build-ups and evacuations of diplomatic personnel across the region.
- 28 FEB 2026** The United States and Israel launch coordinated strikes across Iran, targeting nuclear facilities, military bases and leadership compounds.
- 28 FEB 2026** Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei is killed in a targeted airstrike in Tehran as part of the opening wave of attacks.
- 28 FEB - 1 MARCH 2026** Iran retaliates with ballistic missiles and drones targeting Israel and U.S. military bases across the Gulf region.
- EARLY MARCH 2026** The conflict widens as strikes continue, raising fears of a prolonged regional war.

WHY THE WAR STARTED

- NUCLEAR TENSIONS:** The United States and Israel have long accused Iran of pursuing nuclear weapons, a charge Tehran denies, insisting its nuclear programme is for peaceful purposes.
- STALLED DIPLOMACY:** Negotiations to revive the 2015 nuclear deal collapsed, leaving diplomacy at a dead end and increasing pressure for military options.
- ISRAEL'S SECURITY CONCERNS:** Israel considers a nuclear-capable Iran an existential threat and has repeatedly warned it would act militarily to prevent it.
- REGIONAL POWER RIVALRY:** Iran's growing influence through allied groups across West Asia - including in Lebanon, Iraq, Syria and Yemen - has intensified confrontation
- RE-EMPTIVE STRIKE DOCTRINE:** Washington and Tel Aviv justified the attack as a "preventive" or "pre-emptive" strike aimed at destroying Iran's military and nuclear infrastructure.

Twenty one miles bottleneck that holds world hostage

The Strait of Hormuz has become the World's Most Dangerous 21 Miles. It did not take a landmine. It took a phone call from Lloyd's of London. Within hours of Operation Epic Fury launching - a US-led military response in the Persian Gulf region following escalating Iranian provocations - war risk underwriters began cancelling policies for Strait of Hormuz transits. The KHK Empress, loaded with Omani crude bound for Basra, executed a mid-strait U-turn and redirected to India. The Eagle Veracruz halted at the western approach, carrying two million barrels of Saudi crude destined for China. The Front Shanghai stopped off in Sharjah with Iraqi crude bound for Rotterdam. Nippon Yusen ordered its entire fleet to avoid Hormuz. Hapag-Lloyd suspended all transits.

None of these vessels was fired upon. Every one of them received the same call from their insurers. In a single morning, the world learned something that naval strategists have long understood but policymakers have consistently underestimated: you do not need to close a strait. You only need to make it uninsurable and this is the weapon no Navy can counter. Sea lanes of communication - SLOCs in military parlance - are not merely trade routes. They are the circulatory system of modern industrial civilisation. More than 80 percent of global trade by volume moves by sea. The world's ten busiest shipping lanes collectively carry goods worth over \$14 trillion annually. Disrupt even one critical chokepoint, and the tremor is felt on every continent within days. The Strait of Hormuz is the most consequential of these chokepoints. Fifty million years ago, the Arabian plate collided with the Eurasian plate and compressed the Persian Gulf into a basin that drains through a single geological bottleneck, barely twenty-one miles wide at its narrowest. Through this tectonic accident passes 21 percent of global petroleum supply, 20 percent of all seaborne liquefied natural gas, and one-fifth of industrial civilisation's daily energy needs - forcing the lifeblood of the modern world through a corridor narrower than the English Channel, bordered on one side by Iran.



KRIPA NAUTIYAL
Retired Additional Director General of the Indian Coast Guard

Other chokepoints amplify the fragility. The Strait of Malacca - through which passes over 40 percent of global trade including the bulk of China and Japan's energy imports - handles a vessel every few minutes. The Suez Canal, which the Houthi crisis of 2024-25 already demonstrated could be effectively blocked by a non-state actor with anti-ship missiles, connects Asian production to European consumption. The Bab-el-Mandeb, the Bosphorus, the Danish Straits - each is a hinge on which massive portions of global commerce swing. None has meaningful redundancy. The Insurance Weapon Iran has discovered - or perhaps merely refined - a strategic insight that upends conventional deterrence theory. The vulnerability of global shipping is not primarily physical. It is financial. Modern commercial vessels are not military assets; they are business investments governed by actuarial tables, Lloyd's syndicates, and P&I Club policies. A tanker operator cannot sail without insurance. A bank will not finance a voyage without it. A port authority will refuse entry to an uninsured vessel.

The numbers make the point precisely. Baseline war risk insurance for a strait transit sits at approximately 0.25 percent of hull value - around \$250,000 per voyage for a \$100 million tanker. The Financial Times confirmed that following Operation Epic Fury, premiums surged 50 percent within hours. At peak escalation, analysts project costs approaching US dollar 3,75000 per transit. For vessels with American or Israeli beneficial ownership, underwriters have moved beyond premium increases entirely: no policy is available at any price. The USS Abraham Lincoln carries enough Tomahawks to sink every IRGC patrol boat in 48 hours. The Fifth Fleet has rehearsed this scenario for decades. None of that matters. Aircraft carriers cannot force an underwriter to rewrite a policy. The most powerful navy in human history cannot compel a Lloyd's syndicate to decide that a VLCC transiting Iranian coastal waters represents an acceptable risk on a Saturday afternoon when missiles are landing in Dubai.

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CAPABILITY	IRAN	UNITED STATES
Active military personnel	~610,000 troops (Army + Revolutionary Guard)	~1.3 million active personnel
Reserve forces	~350,000	~800,000+
Defence budget	~US\$10-15 billion annually	~US\$850+ billion (largest in the world)
Ballistic missiles	Estimated ~2,000-3,000 missiles with ranges up to 2,000-2,500 km	Thousands of advanced cruise and ballistic missiles, including intercontinental systems
Drones / UAVs	Hundreds of combat drones (Shahed, Mohajer series) used for long-range attacks	Large fleet of advanced drones such as MQ-9 Reaper, Global Hawk
Combat aircraft	~300-330 mostly older fighters (F-4, F-5, MiG-29, F-14)	13,000+ military aircraft including F-35, F-22, B-2 stealth bombers
Naval power	Small navy with submarines, fast attack boats and missile craft	World's largest navy with 11 aircraft carriers and global deployment
Nuclear weapons	No confirmed nuclear weapons (suspected capability development)	~5,200 nuclear warheads in total arsenal
Strategic strength	Large missile arsenal and regional proxy networks	Global military reach with advanced technology and alliances

IRAN RELIES ON MISSILES, DRONES AND ASYMMETRIC WARFARE, WHILE THE US HAS TECHNOLOGICAL SUPERIORITY & MILITARY REACH

International Women's Day

An Indian Dream Powered by Nari Shakti



The idea of the Indian dream has changed in the last decade. Today, across villages, towns and cities, women are stepping forward with confidence and becoming equal partners in the country's growth. Women's Day is not only about celebrating achievements, but also about recognising how India is creating new opportunities for its daughters to learn, lead and contribute to the nation.

For many women, especially those from middle-class or modest backgrounds, the journey has not always been easy. Education, financial independence and social acceptance were once major challenges. But India is a country where determination and opportunity can transform lives. When families support their daughters and society provides the right environment, women rise with remarkable strength.

My own journey reflects this spirit. I come from a simple middle-class family in Gujarat, where, like millions of Indian households, values such as hard work, discipline and respect for education shaped our lives. Opportunities were limited, but dreams were not. From those humble beginnings, the opportunity to serve the people as a Member of Parliament and later as a Union Minister has been deeply humbling. It reminds me that in India, the daughter of an ordinary family can rise to positions of responsibility and serve the nation.

Across India today, women are excelling in every field and inspiring the next generation. In sports, players like Smriti Mandhana have become icons of modern Indian cricket, while champions such as P. V. Sindhu and Mary Kom have brought immense pride to the nation through their achievements on the global stage. In science and technology, leaders like Tessy Thomas have demonstrated the remarkable contributions of women in strengthening India's scientific capabilities. In business, entrepreneurs such as Falguni Nayar have built global brands and shown the power of Indian women's leadership.

These examples represent the confidence and capability of India's women today. Young girls across the country now grow up believing that their dreams are



DARSHANA JARDOSH
Former Minister of State for
Railways & Textiles, Govt. of India

not limited by their circumstances.

This transformation has been strengthened by policies that place women at the centre of development. Under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Narendra Modi, women's empowerment has become a national priority. The focus is

not only on welfare but on enabling women to participate actively in India's economic and social progress.

Several initiatives have contributed to this change. The Beti Bachao Beti Padhao campaign has helped create awareness about the importance of educating the girl child and improving gender balance. The sex ratio at birth, which was 918 girls per 1,000 boys in 2014-15, has improved to around 934 in recent years.

Equally important has been the effort to improve the daily lives of women. Through Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, more than 10 crore LPG connections have been provided to households, freeing women from the health hazards of traditional cooking fuels. Programs like Swachh Bharat Mission have led to the construction of over 11 crore toilets across the

country, improving dignity, safety and hygiene for women, especially in rural areas.

Financial empowerment has also been a major focus. Under Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, over 50 per cent of the more than 50 crore bank accounts opened belong to women, bringing millions into the formal banking system. Similarly, Mudra Yojana has supported entrepreneurship, with nearly 69 per cent of loans going to women entrepreneurs who are starting small businesses and generating livelihoods.

Schemes such as Sukanya Samridhi Yojana have also encouraged families to invest in the future of their daughters, with millions of savings accounts opened for girls across the country. At the grassroots level, self-help groups supported by government initiatives have empowered crores of women to build enterprises, strengthen household incomes and become active contributors to the nation's economy.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji has often spoken about the vision of women-led development. This idea recognises that when women lead, the entire society benefits. Families become stronger, communities become more resilient, and the nation moves forward with greater balance and compassion.

Across India today, this change is visible. Women are entrepreneurs, admin-

Schemes such as Sukanya Samridhi Yojana have also encouraged families to invest in the future of their daughters, with millions of savings accounts opened for girls across the country

istrators, scientists, farmers and public representatives. In villages, women are managing self-help groups and businesses; in cities, they are leading companies and innovation. Young girls today grow up believing that their dreams are achievable.

Women's Day therefore, is not just about celebration. It is about reaffirming our commitment to an India where every girl has the opportunity to study, grow and contribute to the nation. The story of modern India is increasingly the story of its women rising with confidence and determination.

As India moves forward towards becoming a developed nation, the strength of our progress will depend greatly on the aspirations and achievements of its women. When India's daughters dream bigger, the nation itself moves forward with greater energy and purpose. That, in many ways, is the true spirit of the Indian dream.

THE JOURNEY OF WOMEN'S RIGHTS IN INDIA

(1950s-1970s)

- 1950** - The Constitution of India guaranteed equality, non-discrimination, and universal adult franchise.
- 1955** - Hindu Marriage Act introduced legal safeguards in marriage.
- 1956** - Hindu Succession Act improved women's property rights.
- 1961** - Dowry Prohibition Act outlawed dowry.

Rise of Women's Movements (1970s-1990s)

- Feminist movements highlighted dowry deaths, workplace discrimination, and domestic violence.
- 1992-93** - Constitutional amendments reserved one-third seats for women in Panchayati Raj institutions, boosting grassroots political participation.

21st Century Legal and Social Progress

- 2005** - Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act strengthened protection against abuse.
- 2012** - The 2012 Delhi gang rape case sparked nationwide protests demanding stronger laws.
- 2013** - Criminal Law (Amendment) Act expanded definitions of sexual crimes and penalties.
- 2023** - Passage of the Women's Reservation Bill ensuring 33% reservation for women in Parliament and state legislatures.

WOMEN ACHIEVERS



P. V. Sindhu
Sports

ONE OF INDIA'S MOST SUCCESSFUL BADMINTON PLAYERS, SHE WON A SILVER MEDAL AT THE 2016 RIO OLYMPICS. SHE BECAME THE FIRST INDIAN TO WIN THE BWF WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS GOLD IN 2019.



Anita Dube
Arts

A PROMINENT VOICE IN CONTEMPORARY INDIAN ART, SHE IS KNOWN FOR HER WORKS EXPLORING IDENTITY, GENDER, AND POWER. SHE ALSO SERVED AS CURATOR OF THE KOCHI-MUZIRIS BIENNALE IN 2018.



Nirmala Sitharaman
Politics

ONE OF INDIA'S MOST POWERFUL POLITICAL LEADERS TODAY, SHE SERVES AS THE FINANCE MINISTER OF INDIA. SHE IS ALSO THE FIRST FULL-TIME WOMAN DEFENCE MINISTER.



Geetanjali Shree
Literature

A LEADING CONTEMPORARY HINDI WRITER, SHE WON THE INTERNATIONAL BOOKER PRIZE IN 2022 FOR HER NOVEL 'TOMB OF SAND.' SHE BECAME THE FIRST HINDI AUTHOR TO RECEIVE THIS PRESTIGIOUS RECOGNITION.



Pooja Chauhan
Chartered Accountant

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FROM AGENDA COVER

US-Israel attack on Iran: Escalating crisis in West Asia...

The continuing tensions in West Asia have massive economic and strategic ramifications for India, which has extensive commercial, energy, and people-to-people ties to the Gulf region. The Gulf Cooperation Council countries comprise more than 15% of India's total trade worldwide, with bilateral trade exceeding \$178 billion by 2024-25.

One immediate effect of the escalating tensions is on Indian agricultural exports to the Gulf. The UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and Oman all import substantial quantities of Indian agricultural products, such as grapes, onions, rice, and vegetables. Disruption in shipping routes, port closures, and limited regional airspace have delayed shipments and increased transportation costs, resulting in significant economic losses to both Indian exporters and farmers. Energy security is also a key issue.

Approximately 60% of India's crude oil and natural gas supplies come from the Gulf Region. Any disruption to maritime movements through the Strait of Hormuz would likely create upward pressure on crude oil and natural gas prices as well as increase inflation. The continuing tension could ultimately jeopardise the health and livelihoods of the over 9 million Indians who live in the Gulf Regions.

The Conflict Becoming a Global Crisis

The US-Israel military attacks on Iran have swiftly escalated into a worldwide crisis because of their impact on oil and gas supply chains and how these events affect international trade. The Gulf region supplies between 20% and 30% of the

world's oil supply and approximately 20% of liquefied natural gas (LNG). Therefore, this area serves as one of the main energy supply centres for the entire global economy. In response to the increased tensions, several Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) member governments tightened security for their oil and gas facilities.

Some of them have even temporarily reduced oil production out of fear that hostilities could lead to missile or drone attacks. As a result, this has created instability in the international energy markets, which has caused an increase in crude oil prices. A significant concern remains the ongoing challenges faced by vessels that are transiting through the Strait of Hormuz because it is a key part of the world shipping channel. Approximately 20-21 million barrels of crude oil (or approximately 1/5 of the World's total daily consumption) flow through the Strait of Hormuz each day. Any significant event that disrupts or halts shipping through this vital chokepoint could severely impact global oil supply. As a result of these attacks and subsequent supply chain disruptions, international shipping lanes have been disrupted, and ocean vessel insurance rates have significantly increased. As such, the current tensions between the US, Israel and Iran prove that a regional conflict can escalate rapidly and negatively impact the global economy. The points listed above demonstrate that the negative ramifications of a regional conflict can be felt at a global level.

This rapidly spreading conflict is not at all in the interest of any country or the region. So, it is the responsibility of each nation to work for peace and stability. We are living in the 21st century, and we wish to make this world a better world with the help of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). This could only be possible when we respect international law.

Twenty one miles ...

Goldman Sachs estimates Brent crude could peak at \$100 per barrel in a sustained Hormuz disruption. JP Morgan projects a range of \$100 to \$120. At those levels, the cascading consequences are severe and near-instantaneous. The arithmetic of alternatives is brutal. Bypass pipelines from Saudi Arabia and the UAE - the East-West Pipeline and the Abu Dhabi Crude Oil Pipeline - handle a combined maximum of approximately three million barrels per day. Hormuz handles twenty million. The gap cannot be closed by land routes, alternative sea lanes, or strategic petroleum reserves, which exist to manage disruptions measured in weeks, not months.

India at the Crossroads

India's exposure to a Hormuz crisis is uniquely acute - and uniquely complex. New Delhi imports approximately 85 percent of its crude oil requirements, with the Persian Gulf region supplying roughly 60 percent of that total. Iraq is India's largest single supplier, followed by Saudi Arabia and the UAE. The vast bulk of this supply transits Hormuz. A sustained closure would not merely increase India's energy costs; at sufficient scale and duration, it would threaten the macroeconomic stability of the world's most populous nation.

The economic arithmetic is stark. At \$130 per barrel crude, India's import bill increases by tens of billions of dollars annually, widening the current account deficit, pressuring the rupee, and potentially reigniting inflation that the Reserve Bank of India has worked carefully to manage. Indian refiners - Reliance, HPCL, BPCL - would face margin compression or pass costs to consumers, with downstream effects on transport, manufacturing, and agriculture.

But India's difficulty extends beyond the eco-

nomie. New Delhi has cultivated strategic relationships with all parties to the present crisis - the United States, Israel, the Gulf Arab states, and Iran. India's chabahar port project in Iran represents a significant infrastructure investment and a strategic gateway to Afghanistan and Central Asia. India has consciously pursued a policy of strategic autonomy, declining to join Western sanctions regimes against Russia, maintaining independent energy relationships, and voting with studied ambiguity at the United Nations. A Hormuz crisis forces India's hand in uncomfortable ways. The KHK Empress, in redirecting its cargo of Omani crude to Indian ports, illustrated that India may become a beneficiary of diverted shipments in the short term.

The Way Forward

The immediate crisis demands military deterrence - and the United States has that capacity in abundance. But deterrence alone cannot resolve a crisis whose primary mechanism is financial rather than kinetic. Several parallel tracks are essential. First, the international community must address the insurance market directly. Precedents exist: the government-backed insurance schemes developed during the Iran-Iraq Tanker War of the 1980s allowed commercial shipping to continue operating despite extreme risk. Second, diplomatic engagement cannot cease because military operations have begun. Historically, every major Persian Gulf crisis has ultimately been resolved through negotiation rather than force. India, with its relationships across all parties, is uniquely positioned to contribute to this diplomatic effort and should actively do so rather than retreating to the sidelines. Third, the crisis should accelerate structural reforms that analysts have recommended for years. The concentration of global energy trade through a handful of chokepoints is not an act of nature - it is the accumulated result

of decades of underinvestment in alternatives. The IMEC corridor - the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor announced in 2023 - represents precisely the kind of infrastructure redundancy that reduces strategic vulnerability. For India specifically, the way forward requires shedding the comfortable ambiguity of strategic autonomy in favour of principled engagement.

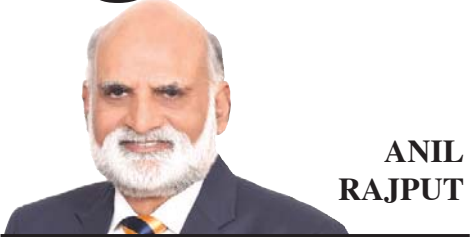
The Lesson That Cannot Be Unlearned

The present crisis will resolve - crises always do. Ships will eventually transit the strait again. Insurance premiums will fall. Oil prices will retreat from their peaks. The particular vessels frozen at the western approach will deliver their cargoes, late and at elevated cost, to their destinations. But something has been demonstrated that cannot be forgotten. The global economy is not merely vulnerable at its physical chokepoints - it is vulnerable at its financial ones.

The underwriters of Lloyd's, the P&I Clubs, the risk models that price commercial voyages through contested waters: these are as much a part of the strategic landscape as carrier strike groups and ballistic missiles. Trump or no Trump, Western consensus or fractured alliances, the world has a shared interest in ensuring that no single nation can hold the arteries of global commerce hostage. That interest does not belong to Washington or Tel Aviv. It belongs to Mumbai, to Shanghai, to Rotterdam, to every port and every kitchen table where the price of energy shapes the calculus of daily life. Twenty-one miles of ancient seabed should not determine the fate of eight billion people. That it currently can is the most urgent strategic challenge of our time.

“GOOD FOOD IS THE FOUNDATION OF
GENUINE HAPPINESS”
— AUGUSTE ESCOFFIER

Ugadi: Six Tastes, One Civilisational Memory



ANIL
RAJPUT

The advent of Chaitra, the first month of the Hindu lunar calendar, marks the beginning of the new year in several parts of India. Coinciding with the full bloom of Vasanta Ritu, when the air grows warmer and the neem flowers bloom, the occasion carries deep seasonal, cultural and spiritual significance. In parts of southern India, especially in Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana, the first day of the season, Chaitra Shukla Pratipada, is observed as Ugadi, the commencement of a new year heralding both a seasonal renewal and a reaffirmation of an ancient cultural ethos.

Some Puranic traditions associate this day with the beginning of creation by Lord Brahma. It also marks the first day of Chaitra and the opening of the new year in the Shalivahana Saka calendar, the ancient calendar used in regional almanacs and public records. In time, this day assumed both metaphysical and social significance. Temples and royal courts marked it with religious congregations, prayers, and the recitation of the Panchanga, sometimes referred to as Panchangam, the annual almanac through which planetary alignments, seasonal predictions, and agricultural forecasts were interpreted. Even today, this practice remains central to the occasion. Families and communities gather to heed forecasts of weather and rainfall, productivity and prosperity that act as reminders of the cosmic influence on human life.

The days preceding Ugadi are filled with excitement and expectation. Homes are cleaned, doorways adorned with fresh mango leaf toranas to welcome good fortune, and courtyards are decorated with colourful rangoli. New clothes are worn after oil baths signifying purity and prayers offered before household deities. Yet it is in the kitchen that the philosophy of the festival finds its most intimate expression. If the almanac offers a vision of the year to come, the festive meal prepares you to celebrate it.

The defining dish on this occasion is the Ugadi Pachadi, an eloquent seasonal representation of the underlying philosophy of the day. Prepared with neem blossoms, jaggery, tamarind pulp, raw mango, green chilli, and salt, it unites the six primary tastes recognised in Indian culinary traditions, bitter, sweet, sour, pungent, bright, and saline, representing the various moods of life, into a single delectable offering. Neem is cleaned to soften its bitterness, tamarind pressed for depth, jaggery dissolved and strained, and mango grated finely. The final balance of these ingredients rests on individual preferences and not on rigid recipes. In Karnataka, the creative pairing of Bevu Bella, neem and jaggery, expresses the same insight and maintains the harmony of different flavours. In this elaborate calibration lies the essence of Ugadi and the recognition that the events of the year ahead, should be approached with similar equilibrium and harmony.

From this symbolic beginning, the festive meal unfolds in a wider spread shaped by the agricultural patterns of the Deccan plateau. Rice preparations form the backbone of the Ugadi thali, expressing regional identity. In Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, Pulihora is indispensable. Tamarind pulp is simmered slowly with turmeric and salt until it thickens, then mixed with cooled rice, ensuring that each grain remains sep-

arate. A tempering of mustard seeds, chana dal, urad dal, dried red chillies, peanuts, and curry leaves is poured over while still hot, releasing fragrance and adding crunch to the dish. Pulihora is equally suited for temple offerings and domestic servings and it nourishes without being heavy with its sourness suiting the changing season.

Alongside it appears Mamidikaya Pulihora, or mango rice, made with fresh raw mangoes which capture the early fragrance of spring. Raw mango is grated and gently sauteed with green chillies, curry leaves, turmeric, and tempered seeds before being cooked with rice. Peanuts or cashews lend texture, turning the preparation into a complete festive meal rather than a mere accompaniment. Besides being a seasonal preparation, Mamidikaya Pulihora is easy to prepare in large quantities and also serves as prasadam. Its balance of sourness and spice awakens the senses after the austerity of late winter, aligning with the New Year's call to alertness and renewal.

Karnataka's festive table is distinguished above all by Obbattu, also known as Holige, a delicacy whose preparation depends as much on technique as on its ingredients. Chana dal is cooked until tender and drained thoroughly before being blended with jaggery and cardamom into a smooth filling. The dough made of wheat, kneaded with oil or ghee, is rested until pliant, then rolled with the filling. This is done with great care so that the sweet centre is enclosed without rupture. Roasted patiently on a griddle and finished with ghee, the bread emerges soft, fragrant, and lightly bronzed. In Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, similar versions known as Bobbattu are made with subtle variations of thickness, filling, and finish, showing how one culinary idea acquires regional personality without losing its common identity.

Sweetness is further expressed through Payasam, though here too the festive palate favours composure over extravagance. Whether prepared from vermicelli, rice, or lentils, the dish begins with milk or, in some households, coconut milk, simmered gradually until it thickens. Jaggery or sugar is added according to taste and traditions, while cashews and raisins fried in ghee are folded in towards the end. Cardamom adds fragrance and warmth. What matters most is the pace of preparation which is deliberately relaxed and meticulous to bring out the well recognized flavour. Offered first before the household shrine before being shared



with the family, it reinforces a principle central to Indian festive practice that sweetness must be consecrated before it is consumed. Savoury balance is essential to Ugadi cuisine as it seeks to mark a measured beginning of a new cycle and not indulgence. Kosambari, prepared from soaked moong dal, grated cucumber or carrot, fresh coconut, coriander, and a light tempering of mustard seeds, introduces freshness and restraint into the thali. Medu Vada, or Garelu in Telugu speaking households, adds crispness and satisfying depth, its fermented urad batter producing a contrast of a crisp surface and inner softness. Accompanying these are chutneys of coconut and tomatoes that are grated or crushed along with roasted chana dal, green chillies, a small piece of ginger, and salt. A little water is added to achieve a smooth yet lightly textured consistency. Besides bringing their vibrant colours to the plate, the coconut lends body and sweetness, while the tomatoes introduce a soft tang making for an irresistible combination. The chutney is finished with a tempering of mustard seeds, curry leaves, and dried red chillies briefly crackled in hot oil and poured over the surface.

Seasonal vegetable dishes commonly include raw banana, ash gourd, ridge gourd, bottle gourd, beans, or pumpkin, prepared with coconut, lentils, or mild spice according to regional habits. Papad and pickle sharpen the meal, while curd rice completes the menu, with its cool and



digestive properties after the flavours that precede it. The arrangement is deliberate. Ugadi meals are composed to balance the heat of spices with the coolness of rice and coconuts, richness with refreshment, and sustenance with reflection, in keeping with the spirit of the festival.

A host of beverages accompany Ugadi's culinary experience, offering refreshment suited to meet the gentle warmth of early spring. Among the most traditional preparations is Panakam, a drink made from jaggery dissolved in water and flavoured with dry ginger and cardamom. Light yet restorative, it is valued both for its cooling character and digestive properties, and in many households it is offered as an aperitif before the main meal begins. Alongside it appears spiced buttermilk, known regionally as majjiga or neer mor, where churned yogurt is diluted and tempered with roasted cumin, curry leaves, ginger, and occasionally green chilli. Its gentle acidity restores balance after richer foods and reflects the longstanding wisdom of pairing festive indulgence with digestive moderation.

As the mango season begins its advance, households also turn to beverages that preserve the fruit's tender vitality in its earliest form to capture the fruit's freshness. Raw mango panaka or lightly sweetened mango drinks combine grated green mango with jaggery, cumin, and water, producing a sharp yet refreshing preparation suited to the rising heat. In some homes, particularly in Karnataka, badam milk enriched with almonds, saffron, and cardamom are prepared as a celebratory drink served to guests, offering warmth and richness that complement the festive sweets that follow. Tender coconut water, sometimes lightly chilled and shared with visitors, provides a natural cooling drink with a host of electrolytes that rehydrates and refreshes. These drinks reflect the tropical landscape of the southern peninsula that is dotted with coconut groves and vast green rice and sugarcane fields.

The care devoted to the preparation of Ugadi cuisine merits recognition, befitting the commemoration of an ancient tradition that continues to be celebrated

with reverence. Lentils are sorted and soaked, jaggery melted and strained, neem blossoms gathered delicately, and mangoes selected for firmness and aroma. Grinding, roasting, tempering, and rolling unfold over hours of shared labour, where cooperation is as essential as skill. Elders recall well rehearsed recipes, while younger members watch closely and learn how consistency is tested by touch rather than measurement, how aroma is judged before a spice mixture is removed from the flame, and how balance is restored when one element threatens to overpower another. A spoonful of Pachadi is often tasted together, inviting children to identify the six flavours and understand the symbolism attached to each. Patience while rolling Holige, restraint while balancing sourness and sweetness, and attentiveness while tempering seeds cultivate qualities that extend beyond cooking. In these acts, participation becomes an expression of devotion and identity, and the kitchen itself becomes a place where history is kept alive through practice.

It is my considered view that Ugadi should retain its significance in contemporary urban life, where households are smaller and time is scarce. Ingredients may be procured from markets rather than gathered at home, and certain recipes may be simplified, but the impulse to prepare this sacred traditional cuisine should be kept alive. Families should continue to gather for Panchanga Shravanam, whether in temples, community halls, or before elders at home. Afterall, year after year, generation after generation, Ugadi survives not because it is spectacular, but because it answers a recurring human need. It offers a disciplined form of renewal at the threshold of a new year, reminding families that beginnings must be received with gratitude, sobriety, and togetherness.

The traditions and cuisine of Ugadi, I believe, carry this enduring cultural significance precisely because they are transmitted through living experience rather than instruction alone. When these dishes continue to be prepared with care, they do more than preserve flavour. They sustain judgement, memory, and belonging, all of which are learned most deeply through participation. It is, therefore, our collective responsibility to ensure that such traditions endure not merely as inherited customs repeated by habit, but as living practices that are prepared, shared, and understood by those who will inherit them.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

A delicious journey into the heart of Bihar

TEAM AGENDA

In a city celebrated for its diverse culinary landscape, discovering authentic regional flavours is always a delight. Potbelly continues to stand out as one of the few places where Bihari cuisine is not only preserved but celebrated with warmth, authenticity and creativity. With its newly refreshed menu and revamped brand identity, the beloved restaurant offers diners a deeper and more refined experience of Bihar's rich culinary heritage.

The moment one steps into Potbelly, the atmosphere immediately sets the tone. The restaurant's refreshed visual identity maintains its rustic soul while embracing a warmer and more contemporary aesthetic. The décor feels inviting rather than elaborate, allowing guests to relax and enjoy their meal in a cozy, comfortable setting. Soft lighting, earthy textures and thoughtfully designed interiors create an ambience that feels both traditional and modern at the same time.

But the true star here is the food. Bihari cuisine is often underrated in India's mainstream food conversa-

tion, yet Potbelly proves that it is both incredibly tasty and surprisingly healthy. The cuisine relies on simple ingredients, balanced spices and traditional cooking methods that enhance natural flavours rather than overpower them. The menu proudly continues to showcase Potbelly's signature dishes. The iconic Littichokha remains a must-try, featuring smoky, roasted wheat dumplings filled with sattu and paired with mashed vegetables seasoned to perfection. The comforting Dal BhaatThali and the generous Bhojpuri Thali offer a wholesome experience of traditional home-style meals, demonstrating how Bihari food is as nourishing as it is flavourful. For those who enjoy slow-cooked delicacies, the restaurant offers standout dishes like Champaran-style Mutton, a classic preparation known for its rich yet balanced spices. Equally delightful are the Chicken Ishtew and Khada Masala Chicken with LachhaParatha, both showcasing the depth and patience that define traditional Bihari cooking.

The biryani section features regional variations rarely found elsewhere. Options such as Kathal Biryani, Machhli Biryani, and the aromatic Yakhni-style Mutton Biryani are prepared using traditional slow-cooking methods in earthen pots, allowing the flavours to develop gradually and authentically. Starters add another layer of comfort and nostalgia. Dishes like Chana Dal PyazKachri, AlooLalu Chop, and the playful Phish Phingers celebrate the everyday snacks and street flavours of Bihar. Accompanied by baskets of freshly prepared pooris, pakoras and parathas, these dishes perfectly capture the essence of regional comfort food.

The beverage menu deserves a special mention as well. Rather than relying solely on modern mocktails, Potbelly embraces traditional Indian refreshments. Drinks like AamPanna, the refreshing Sattu Cooler (available in sweet and salty versions), and Mirchi Masala Lemonade bring nostalgic

flavours to the table. The iced teas infused with tulsi, rose and lemongrass add a refreshing contemporary twist. Equally impressive is the service. The staff greet guests with genuine warmth and serve each dish with a smile, enhancing the overall dining experience. The attentive yet relaxed hospitality reflects the restaurant's philosophy of honest food and heartfelt storytelling.

Founder Puja Sahu has long championed the idea that Bihar's cuisine deserves a prominent place on India's culinary map. With this thoughtful revamp, Potbelly strengthens that vision while staying true to its roots. Overall, Potbelly's refreshed menu and inviting ambience make it a destination worth revisiting. For anyone looking to explore authentic Bihari cuisine that is both delicious and wholesome, this restaurant offers a memorable and satisfying experience—one that celebrates tradition while welcoming the tastes of today's diners.



Women, Know that You Are Empowered!

Women can connect minds and build bridges between the communities. Women have the capacity to be excellent peacemakers. Because it is quite natural for them to relate on the level of the heart. The biggest strength that women have is their emotions, feelings, motivation and inspiration

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Women should know that they are empowered. They should never feel victimized. When you feel victimized, you lose energy, enthusiasm, and power. The spiritual path is where you get rid of both victim consciousness and culprit consciousness. As a victim, you remain in a small mind and keep blaming others. You can never reach the Self. The culprit mindset does the same. When you have doership, “Oh! I did these bad things”, even then you can’t reach the Self. So, stop blaming yourself and start praising yourself without shame or guilt.

You have all the power to stand up and assert your rights. Of course, we need to bring a lot of change in society. But you can do that without feeling like a victim. India has progressively shown how women can be empowered. For example, we always take the name of a woman before a man in this part of the world- it is Sita-Ram, Lakshmi-Narayan, and Gauri-Shiva. And even in our tradition, it is ‘Matru Devo Bhava’, mother first, and then the father.

Women can connect minds and build bridges between the communities. Women have the capacity to be excellent peacemakers. Because it is quite natural for them to relate on the level of the heart. The biggest strength that women have is their emotions, feelings, motivation and inspiration. Men can inspire to fight, but women inspire to unite. There are more wars in the world today because there is a lack of feminine leadership to unite people, overcome differences and bring home to us the purpose we are all born for!

In today’s war-torn world, we need women to come to the forefront and take more responsibility, without getting stressed. Women in many parts of the world are going through big trauma, but at the same time, I really commend their courage and the way they are coming together and standing up. I tell them, keep going. There is no going back, and success will be yours. Truth will always triumph.

I strongly suggest that they take a few minutes for themselves. It is essential for their own minds. Today, mental health is a big issue around the world. Every 40 seconds, a person is taking his or her life. In this situation, we all have to work towards better mental health, better education, better facilities and a better world in all. When women are determined, they can do wonders.

Women have greater roles to play. Women can influence many men around them - father, brother, children, and spouse. They should take the lead in society. Then there will be less conflict, greed, and corruption in the world. Corruption can only happen outside the boundary of belongingness. The heart can never be corrupt. It is the mind that goes corrupt. The heart always longs for the old, and the mind for the new. Your mind wants to hoard more, but the heart says, ‘I am happy.’ Heart wants to give, and mind wants to take. Women function more



“IN THIS SHORT SPAN OF LIFE, LET US SPREAD MORE LIGHT. LET US SPREAD MORE PEACE AND A SENSE OF BELONGINGNESS. WE NEED TO BRING SENSE TO PEOPLE WHO ARE IN FAVOUR OF WAR”
– GURUDEV

with their hearts. They should keep that quality alive while taking on more political and social responsibilities.

Women are born leaders. Women have both gentleness and strength. Indian scriptures place a tremendous amount of power in women. In fact, the primordial energy known as ‘Shakti’, which is the life force behind the whole creation, is feminine. That is why our scriptures honour women as the highest aspect of divinity- the ‘Aadhya Shakti’.

Women bring together the finest aspects of society. The ability to create and the transformational ability to make a difference in society. Women bring us to the planet and teach us how to live. A mother is our first Guru, our first teacher. Women teach us our first behaviour, our first step in life. And then women also have a great role to play in society. She can be a strong peacemaker; at

home, in the community, in society and in the world. Women can glue differences and bring people of diverse nature together - she does it in her home all the time.

In this fast-paced life, we need to balance our inner peace, beauty and ethical values with the external challenges we face, and women have it in them to do it. These qualities are inherent in a woman.

Usually, people think women are emotional, but the fact is, women are also great intellectual geniuses and excel in planning and execution. You see any department headed by a woman; chances are that department is much ahead of others.

Women are the backbone of any society. The role of women in the development of a society is of utmost importance. In fact, it is the only criterion that determines whether a society is strong and harmonious or not. Also, a corrup-

tion-free society can only emerge where women are given due regard, respect and importance. In building character and integrity, women can do a better job.

Life is short. In this short span of life, let us spread more light. Let us spread more peace and a sense of belongingness. We need to bring sense to people who are in favour of war. Tell them the whole world is standing for peace. This is the only planet we have.

So we need to unite everyone with this mission of a one human family free from conflicts, pain, and suffering, to dream of a beautiful world together.

I appeal to women, don’t wait for others to delegate power to you. Just assume it. Unfortunately, most of the feminist movements today are demanding rights. What are you demanding? From whom are you demanding? You are asking from an empty bowl. You have equal rights. You simply have to assert them! You don’t have to go and ask somebody; it is all there for you. Just own it! You are a born leader. You have the potential within you to bring prosperity, happiness and joy to this world. Make it happen.



WOMEN BRING TOGETHER THE FINEST ASPECTS OF SOCIETY. THE ABILITY TO CREATE AND THE TRANSFORMATIONAL ABILITY TO MAKE A DIFFERENCE IN SOCIETY. WOMEN BRING US TO THE PLANET AND TEACH US HOW TO LIVE. A MOTHER IS OUR FIRST GURU, OUR FIRST TEACHER. WOMEN TEACH US OUR FIRST BEHAVIOUR, OUR FIRST STEP IN LIFE. AND THEN WOMEN ALSO HAVE A GREAT ROLE TO PLAY IN SOCIETY. SHE CAN BE A STRONG PEACEMAKER;

AT HOME, IN THE COMMUNITY, IN SOCIETY AND IN THE WORLD. WOMEN CAN GLUE DIFFERENCES AND BRING PEOPLE OF DIVERSE NATURE TOGETHER - SHE DOES IT IN HER HOME ALL THE TIME. IN THIS FAST-PACED LIFE, WE NEED TO BALANCE OUR INNER PEACE, BEAUTY AND ETHICAL VALUES WITH THE EXTERNAL CHALLENGES WE FACE, AND WOMEN HAVE IT IN THEM TO DO IT. THESE QUALITIES ARE INHERENT IN A WOMAN.

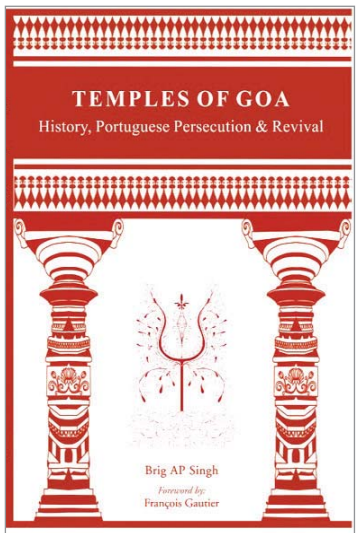
Uncovering Goa’s hidden soul

ANIL BHAT

Behind Goa’s sun-drenched beaches and colonial charm lies a story of extraordinary resilience—one that has remained hidden in plain sight for centuries. *Temples of Goa: History, Portuguese Persecution and Revival* by Brigadier AP Singh, SM, VSM (Retd), from the Army’s Corps of Engineers and an expert on ancient temple architecture who has documented over 1,500 temples, including Hoysala dynasty sites, focusing on lathe-turned pillars, stellate designs, and construction techniques, unveils this forgotten narrative with scholarly precision and deeply moving reverence.

This is not just another history book—it is about cultural restoration after a period of persecution and attempts to destroy the old culture of the original inhabitants of Goa, known as the Gawda, Kunbi, and Velip communities, predominantly agriculturalists and fisherfolk and forming the earliest self-sufficient village communities known as Gaunkaris. Singh takes readers on a remarkable journey through Goa’s heritage, from its ancient roots documented in Sanskrit, Kannada, and Marathi inscriptions to the richness of the Sahyadrikhanda of the Skandapurana treatises. Here, we discover the stories of the Gauda Saraswat Brahmins, a distinct Hindu Konkani-speaking community originating from the ancient Saraswati River region, later settling in Goa before migrating to coastal Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Kerala; the rise and fall of the Mauryas and Kadambas; and the intricate tapestry of dynasties that shaped this sacred land.

But what makes this work truly exceptional is its unflinching examination of survival against impossible odds. Singh delves deep and is bold enough to bring out the darkest chapter of Goa’s history, tracing Portuguese persecution by way of the brutal Goa Inquisition (1560-1821)—how Goa’s Hindu temples were destroyed, communities, customs, and traditions were specifically suppressed, “new Christians” persecuted for heresy, and the Konkani language was severely restricted and eventually banned. And how, after such horrible suffering, Goans emerged with their faith intact.



Title: Temples of Goa
Author: Brig AP Singh
MRP: ₹1500
Publisher: Indus University Press

This is a story of cultural defiance that deserves to be told and remembered. The destruction of temples forced the people to relocate deities to hidden, simple dwellings for worshipping them before new temples were built in the 17th-18th centuries. These reconstructed temples, often in “New Conquest” areas, blend Hindu and European architecture, making them unique but less recognised as traditional, ancient Indian temples.

Richly illustrated with stunning photographs of forgotten temples, ancient settlements, and sacred groves tucked away from tourist maps, the book reveals archaeological treasures that have been overlooked for far too long. Each image tells its own story of devotion, destruction, and miraculous revival. Vikram Sampath notes in the Preface that the author’s work is not only a meticulous documentation of architecture and devotion, but also a testament to undying Hindu resilience down the ages.

Dr Sushma Ashok Arur has written an informative Introduction, bringing out some unique and not much-known aspects of Goa and complimenting the author on his insightful research.

What the author brings out is that while Goa was conquered in November

1510, it was an ancient, wealthy, and strategic region with a history dating back to the 3rd century BC. Ruled by dynasties like the Mauryas, Kadambas, and Vijayanagara, it was a major maritime trade hub known by names such as Gomant and Govapuri/Gopakapattana, a bustling port city famous for trade.

Afonso de Albuquerque, a Portuguese admiral, defeated the forces of the Sultan of Bijapur, Yusuf Adil Shah, to establish Portuguese rule, which lasted until December 19, 1961, when, after a swift 36-hour military action by the Indian Army, Navy, and Air Force, code-named Operation Vijay, the Portuguese were forced to surrender, ending 451 years of colonial rule in Goa, Daman, and Diu. Goan temples are unique for their synthesis of Hindu traditions with Islamic and European architectural influences, resulting from rebuilding efforts in the 16th-18th centuries. Key features include distinctive deepa stambhas (lamp towers), red-tiled roofs, and serene water tanks, while retaining traditional Hindu garbhagriha (sanctum sanctorum) designs.

The oldest surviving and purely indigenous-style temple, such as the 12th-century Mahadev Temple at Tambdi Surla, is located in a dense forest, far from the tourist trail. “Tambdi” refers to the red laterite soil and “Surla” is the village/river. Other venerated temples are the Saptakoteshwar Temple, rebuilt in the 17th century by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj; Mangeshi Temple, Mangeshi, one of the most famous and largest temples, dating back over 450 years with its iconic seven-storey lamp tower; Shantadurga Temple, Kavlem; Brahma Karmali Temple, Valpoi, believed to be over 1,000 years old; Chandreshwar Bhutnath Temple, Quepem; Ramnath Temple, Ramnathim; and some more.

For anyone ardent about South Asian history, religious studies, colonial legacies, or simply seeking to understand the real Goa beyond its tourist veneer, this book is indispensable. Singh challenges us to see Goa not as a vacation destination, but as a living testament to the power of cultural memory and spiritual endurance.

(The book reviewer is a VSM (Retd), a strategic affairs analyst and former spokesperson, Defence Ministry and Indian Army)

Between dharma and discipline

TEAM AGENDA

Echoes of Dharma by Sarath Chandar Rao Sanku is not merely a memoir of professional years spent abroad; it is a layered meditation on identity, industry, culture, and karmic purpose. Represented and strategically positioned by Kala as literary agents, the book enters the literary space with a distinctive civilisational voice.

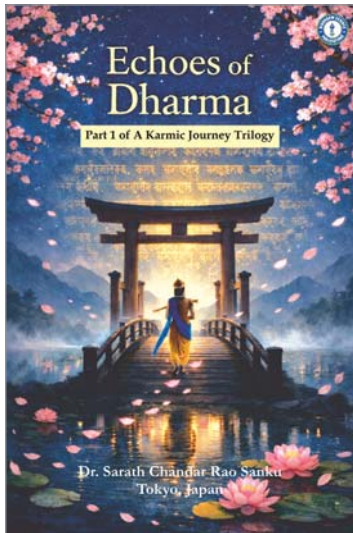
Subtitled *A Kshatriya in Japan and My Karmic Journey: Part I*, the narrative chronicles the author’s decade-long engagement with Japan between 1989 and 2000 - years that shaped him intellectually, professionally, and spiritually. Trained as an engineer with a PhD in Machine Dynamics and deeply immersed in the worlds of Mechatronics and industrial systems, Sanku approaches Japan not as a tourist or casual observer, but as a participant within its academic and corporate machinery.

At one level, the book traces a familiar arc: an Indian scholar travels to Japan, studies, works, absorbs discipline, and navigates cultural dislocation. Yet this is where the familiarity ends. The author challenges the romanticised global perception of Japan’s “phoenix-like” rise after World War II and interrogates the cultural and managerial frameworks that undergird that success.

One of the book’s most striking features is its unapologetic comparative lens. Sanku contrasts the structural simplicity of the Japanese language with the phonetic and expressive richness of Telugu, using linguistic architecture as a metaphor for civilisational temperament. These comparisons are not dismissive; rather, they are reflective - urging readers to reconsider assumptions about efficiency, expression, and cultural depth.

Equally provocative is his examination of “Kaizen,” the widely celebrated philosophy of continuous improvement. While acknowledging its operational discipline, the author questions its universal applicability. He argues that Kaizen thrives within Japan’s relatively homogeneous social order but may not seamlessly adapt to heterogeneous societies marked by plural identities and layered complexities. Such observations elevate the work beyond memoir into the realm of cultural analysis.

Yet *Echoes of Dharma* is not a critique



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Author: Sarath Chandar Rao Sanku
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of Japan alone. It is also an inward journey. The author’s rediscovery of his Kshatriya lineage and his reflections through the philosophical lens of the Bhagavad Gita give the narrative a contemplative core. The counsel of Lord Krishna to Arjuna — to perform one’s duty without attachment — becomes an ethical thread running quietly through factory floors, research labs, corporate boardrooms, and personal crossroads.

Chapters set in Osaka, Kyoto, Nagano,

and Tokyo offer vivid anecdotes — at times humorous, at times sharply observant. The “3k” work culture (kitanaï, kiken, kitsui — dirty, dangerous, difficult) is not discussed abstractly but experienced first-hand. The author neither glorifies nor disparages; instead, he observes with disciplined detachment.

Structurally, the book blends memoir, industrial insight, philosophical rumination, and civilisational commentary. The transitions between technical reflections and spiritual inquiry may occasionally feel abrupt, yet this hybridity mirrors the author’s own dual life: engineer and seeker, technocrat and traditionalist.

In an era where narratives about Japan often oscillate between uncritical admiration and superficial travelogue, *Echoes of Dharma* offers something more layered — a Bharatiya lens engaging a global civilisation without surrendering intellectual independence. It invites readers to reflect not only on Japan, but on the deeper question of how one retains civilisational grounding while navigating foreign systems.

Serious, reflective, and at times provocative, the book demands engagement. For readers interested in cross-cultural management, diaspora experience, spiritual introspection, and evolving civilisational discourse, it provides thoughtful material. Ultimately, it is less about geography and more about dharma — about understanding one’s duty amid the echoes of history, industry, and identity.